

MK KOMBO BIBLE - CHARACTER CROSS-REFERENCE

Tap MKX / XL or MK1 to jump directly to that version of the character.

CHARACTER	MKX / XL	MK1
Alien	MKX	-
Ashrah	-	MK1
Baraka	-	MK1
Bo' Rai Cho	MKX	-
Cassie Cage	MKX	-
Conan the Barbarian	-	MK1
Cyrax	-	MK1
D'Vorah	MKX	-
Ermac	MKX	MK1
Ferra/Torr	MKX	-
General Shao	-	MK1
Geras	-	MK1
Ghostface	-	MK1
Goro	MKX	-
Havik	-	MK1
Homelander	-	MK1
Jacqui Briggs	MKX	-
Jason Voorhees	MKX	-
Jax	MKX	-
Johnny Cage	MKX	MK1
Kano	MKX	-
Kenshi	MKX	MK1
Kitana	MKX	MK1
Kotal Kahn	MKX	-
Kung Jin	MKX	-
Kung Lao	MKX	MK1
Leatherface	MKX	-
Li Mei	-	MK1
Liu Kang	MKX	MK1
Mileena	MKX	MK1
Nitara	-	MK1
Noob Saibot	-	MK1
Omni-Man	-	MK1
Peacemaker	-	MK1
Predator	MKX	-
Quan Chi	MKX	MK1
Raiden	MKX	MK1
Rain	-	MK1
Reiko	-	MK1
Reptile	MKX	MK1
Scorpion	MKX	MK1
Sektor	-	MK1
Shang Tsung	-	MK1
Shinnok	MKX	-
Sindel	-	MK1
Smoke	-	MK1
Sonya Blade	MKX	-
Sub-Zero	MKX	MK1
T-1000	-	MK1
Takeda	MKX	MK1
Tanya	MKX	MK1
Tremor	MKX	-
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FIGHTING GAME TERMINOLOGY

Plain-English glossary for terms used throughout the MK Kombo Bible.

Neutral

Neither player has a clear offensive advantage; both are spacing, moving, poking, zoning, or looking for an opening.

BnB (Bread and Butter)

A dependable everyday combo. Reliability matters more than absolute maximum damage.

Confirm / Hit Confirm

Recognizing that the opening attack hit before committing to the rest of a combo or unsafe special.

Conversion

Turning an unexpected hit, Kameo assist, anti-air, low, or projectile into a real combo.

Route

The specific sequence chosen from a combo's starter to its ender.

Starter

The first attack or string that begins a combo.

Launcher

An attack that sends the opponent airborne so the combo can continue.

Reconnect / Pickup

Catching the opponent again after a launch, bounce, teleport, Kameo hit, or awkward airborne position.

Ender

The final attack or special. It may prioritize damage, carry, positioning, or setup.

Meterless

Uses no offensive meter; therefore it is available whenever the opening occurs.

One-Bar / Two-Bar

How much offensive meter the route spends.

EX / Enhanced

A meter-powered version of a special move, usually performed with Block plus the special input.

Kameo

MK1 assist fighter used for extensions, coverage, mix-ups, pressure, movement, or screen control.

Neutral Coverage

A move or Kameo that helps control space or create an opening while neither player has the advantage.

Pressure

Continuing offense while the opponent is defending, forcing repeated defensive decisions.

Plus / Advantage

You recover before the opponent, allowing your next action to begin first.

Safe / Unsafe

Safe: normally cannot be punished on block. Unsafe: the opponent can punish it on block.

Punish

Guaranteed offense after an opponent's move leaves enough recovery that they cannot block your response.

Whiff / Whiff Punish

A whiff is a missed attack; a whiff punish hits that attack during its recovery.

Mix / Mix-up

Offense forcing different defensive answers: overhead/low, throw/strike, left/right, etc.

Setplay

A planned post-hit or knockdown setup - bombs, missiles, portals, Kameo timing - built to force a defensive problem.

Oki / Okizeme

Your offensive plan as the opponent rises from a knockdown.

Meaty

An attack timed to meet the opponent as they rise, making it difficult to challenge safely.

Restand

Returns the opponent to standing instead of knocking them down, often preserving pressure.

Juggle

Keeping an airborne opponent in the combo before they hit the ground.

Cancel

Interrupting one move's recovery by transitioning immediately into an allowed move or special.

Stance Cancel

Entering and exiting a stance to alter timing, movement, pressure, or routing.

Armor

Lets a move absorb/resist an incoming hit while continuing, subject to matchup-specific counters.

Zoning

Controlling distance with projectiles, long attacks, traps, or movement.

Chip

Small damage dealt through block by certain attacks or specials.

Carry / Corner Carry

How far a combo moves the opponent toward the corner.

Side Switch

A route or move that changes which side of the opponent you occupy.

Cash Out

Spend meter, Kameo resources, or position to take larger damage now.

Scaling

Damage reduction applied as a combo grows; more hits do not always mean proportionally more damage.

Frame Trap

Pressure where your advantage causes an opponent's attempted button to lose to your next attack.

Wake-up

The opponent's immediate action after rising from a knockdown.

MKX • Kung Lao

STYLE: Mobility / hat control / spin launcher / pressure

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Kung Lao uses movement, hat control and Spin conversions to turn small openings into momentum. His core combo engine works in every variation; Tempest adds Orbiting Hat pressure, Buzz Saw adds stronger hat-projectile conversion and low-hat utility, and Hat Trick turns hat placement/call-back into a setup and conversion system.

SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Hat Toss	B, F, Y	B, F, Triangle	B, F, 2
Spin	D, F, X	D, F, Square	D, F, 1
Teleport	D, Up	D, Up	D, Up
Dive Kick (air)	D + B	D + Circle	D + 4

WHAT THE SPECIALS ARE FOR

Hat Toss: projectile/screen check. **Spin:** fast launcher and punish tool. **Teleport:** repositioning and read-based attack. **Dive Kick:** air-angle change and combo ender/bridge.

LEARN FIRST

Spin + F23 + one core meterless BnB. The variation sections come after the universal Kung Lao engine is dependable.

MKX • Kung Lao - Variations

TEMPEST

Orbiting Hat / Hat Spin pressure. Best first variation for learning close pressure and extending the core combo engine.

BUZZ SAW

Hat trajectories, EX Straight Hat and Low Hat give Kung Lao stronger ranged/low-hat conversion choices. It is the closest of the three to a projectile-heavy classic Lao feel.

HAT TRICK

Hat Trap plus Hat Call Back creates delayed threats, setup pressure and unusual conversions. This variation changed materially through patches, so its section emphasizes documented post-patch routes.

VARIATION COMBO RULE

First learn the **Core / All-Variation** routes. Then learn only the routes that teach what your chosen variation adds. We do not repeat identical BnBs three times.

MKX • Kung Lao - Important Strings

BUILT-IN / IMPORTANT STRINGS

F23 - ADVANCING / PUNISH STARTER

Xbox: F + Y, A

PlayStation: F + Triangle, Cross

Universal: F + 2, 3

WHY IT MATTERS

Practical 11-frame punish/advancing starter in period Kung Lao BnB material.

B321 - FOOTSIE / COMBO STARTER

Xbox: B + A, Y, X

PlayStation: B + Cross, Triangle, Square

Universal: B + 3, 2, 1

WHY IT MATTERS

A major conversion string across all three variations.

11212 / 112124 - JAB CONFIRM

Xbox: X,X,Y,X,Y / X,X,Y,X,Y,B

PlayStation: Square,Square,Triangle,Square,Triangle /
Square,Square,Triangle,Square,Triangle,Circle

Universal: 1,1,2,1,2 / 1,1,2,1,2,4

WHY IT MATTERS

Fast pressure/punish family that appears in core and variation-specific routes.

44 - HEAVY PUNISH

Xbox: B, B

PlayStation: Circle, Circle

Universal: 4, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Higher-damage punish starter and common extension after variation tools.

MKX • Kung Lao - Core / All Variations

CORE COMBOS

EASY / METERLESS

Xbox: FYA~DFX, JY, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: FTriCross~DF Square, J Triangle, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: F23~DF1, J2, J4~D+4, 21

Core punish route documented at roughly 25%. This is the first Kung Lao BnB regardless of variation.

JAB STARTER / METERLESS

Xbox: XXYXY~DFX, JY, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: SqSqTriSqTri~DF Square, J Triangle, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: 11212~DF1, J2, J4~D+4, 21

Fast-string version of the same universal Spin engine.

HEAVY PUNISH / METERLESS

Xbox: BB, Run, BAYX~DFX, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: CircleCircle, Run, BCrossTriSq~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: 44, Run, B321~DF1, J4~D+4, 21

Higher-damage universal punish route; period guides list it in the mid-30% range.

CORE LESSON

All three variations still need Kung Lao's Spin timing. Variation tools enhance this engine; they do not replace it.

MKX • Kung Lao • Tempest

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY TEMPEST

Xbox: BAYX~Hat Spin, Run BAY~DFX, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: BCrossTriSq~Hat Spin, Run BCrossTri~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: B321~Hat Spin, Run B32~DF1, J4~D+4, 21

Documented around 34% before later scaling changes. Teaches Hat Spin -> run -> Spin.

PUNISH / TEMPEST

Xbox: XX~Hat Spin, BB, Run BAYX~DFX, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: SqSq~Hat Spin, CircleCircle, Run BCrossTriSq~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: 11~Hat Spin, 44, Run B321~DF1, J4~D+4, 21

Adds a fast starter into Hat Spin and the heavy 44 bridge.

METER / TEMPEST

Xbox: FY~Hat Spin, BB, Run BAYX~DFX, BAYX~EX DFX, NJY, FB

PlayStation: FTri~Hat Spin, CircleCircle, Run BCrossTriSq~DF Square, BCrossTriSq~EX DF Square, NJ Triang

Universal: F2~Hat Spin, 44, Run B321~DF1, B321~EX DF1, NJ2, F4

A period 1-bar optimization route. Treat damage percentages as patch-sensitive; the route's learning value is the EX Spin extension.

CORNER / TEMPEST

Xbox: BAYX~Hat Spin, BAYX~DFX, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: BCrossTriSq~Hat Spin, BCrossTriSq~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: B321~Hat Spin, B321~DF1, J4~D+4, 21

Compact Tempest corner route.

MKX • Kung Lao • Buzz Saw

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY / BUZZ SAW

Xbox: FYA~DFX, JY, JB~D+B, BAY~BFY

PlayStation: FTriCross~DF Square, J Triangle, J Circle~D+Circle, BCrossTri~BF Triangle

Universal: F23~DF1, J2, J4~D+4, B32~BF2

Core Spin conversion with a hat-based ender. Use this first to feel the variation without changing the entire combo.

1 BAR / STRAIGHT HAT

Xbox: BAYX~EX Straight Hat, Run BAYX~DFX, Run, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: BCrossTriSq~EX Straight Hat, Run BCrossTriSq~DF Square, Run, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: B321~EX Straight Hat, Run B321~DF1, Run, J4~D+4, 21

Documented Buzz Saw route around the high-30% range in early BnB guides. The lesson is converting EX Straight Hat into a run extension.

LOW-HAT CORNER

Xbox: BYY~EX Low Hat (hold), BAYX~DFX, JB~D+B, YX

PlayStation: BTriTri~EX Low Hat (hold), BCrossTriSq~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Triangle Square

Universal: B22~EX Low Hat (hold), B321~DF1, J4~D+4, 21

Corner variation route built around the held low hat. Learn it as a mix-up/conversion lesson, not just a damage number.

BUZZ SAW STRATEGY

Buzz Saw's value is not that every combo becomes different. Its hat options change how you start, end and set up the next interaction. Use Core BnBs when no Buzz Saw tool improves the situation.

MKX • Kung Lao • Hat Trick

VARIATION COMBOS • POST-PATCH FOCUS

OVERHEAD / HAT TRAP

Xbox: BYY~Hat Trap, Hat Call Back, FYX~Hat Toss

PlayStation: BTriTri~Hat Trap, Hat Call Back, FTriSq~Hat Toss

Universal: B22~Hat Trap, Hat Call Back, F21~Hat Toss

Documented post-patch meterless overhead setup family. The important skill is timing the delayed Hat Call Back.

OVERHEAD CONVERSION

Xbox: BYY~Hat Trap, Hat Call Back, FY~DFX, JB~D+B, Dive Kick

PlayStation: BTriTri~Hat Trap, Hat Call Back, FTri~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Dive Kick

Universal: B22~Hat Trap, Hat Call Back, F2~DF1, J4~D+4, Dive Kick

A post-patch meterless conversion in the mid-20% range. It turns the trap/call-back interaction into a real juggle.

1 BAR / HAT CALL BACK

Xbox: BYY~Hat Trap, EX Hat Call Back, BAYX~DFX, JB~D+B, Dive Kick

PlayStation: BTriTri~Hat Trap, EX Hat Call Back, BCrossTriSq~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Dive Kick

Universal: B22~Hat Trap, EX Hat Call Back, B321~DF1, J4~D+4, Dive Kick

Documented around low-30% damage post-patch. The EX recall makes the conversion easier and stronger.

CORNER / HAT OFF

Xbox: BAYX~Hat Call Back, 1, B~DFX, JB~D+B, B~DFX

PlayStation: BCrossTriSq~Hat Call Back, 1, Circle~DF Square, J Circle~D+Circle, Circle~DF Square

Universal: B321~Hat Call Back, 1, 4~DF1, J4~D+4, 4~DF1

Post-patch corner family demonstrating how Hat Call Back becomes the bridge while the hat is off.

HAT TRICK WARNING

Early Hat Trick guides were explicitly marked outdated after patches. These examples are selected from later post-patch discussion; Practice mode remains the final authority for timing and current damage.

MKX • Kung Lao - Progression / Finishers

FROM GUEST TO EXPERT

Guest: Core F23 Spin BnB. **Beginner:** pick one variation and add one variation route. **Intermediate:** add meter and corner routes. **Advanced:** learn setup/oki choices and alternate enders. **Expert:** choose variation route based on meter, corner position, hard knockdown and matchup.

PRACTICE RULE

Do not practice all three variations in one session. Master Core, then choose Tempest, Buzz Saw or Hat Trick and complete that variation's four routes before rotating.

FINISHERS

FINISHER	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL / RANGE
Face Grind	D, B, D, F, B	D, B, D, F, Circle	D, B, D, F, 4 • Close
Flower Pot	D, F, D, B, X	D, F, D, B, Square	D, F, D, B, 1 • Close
Klassic: Hat Split	F, B, F, A	F, B, F, Cross	F, B, F, 3 • Close

BOOK NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

CORE BnB: _____

VARIATION BnB: _____

WHAT I DROP: _____

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MKX • Liu Kang

STYLE: Speed / pressure / fireball control / standing-reset offense

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Liu Kang wants to turn fast strings into repeated pressure decisions. His core strings and movement are shared, but each variation changes the combo goal: Dragon's Fire extends pressure and damage with fireball cancels, Flame Fist emphasizes Windmill Punch, Shaolin Flame and chip, while Dualist uses stance/sphere setups and more specialized conversions.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Bicycle Kick	F, B, F + B	F, B, F + Circle	F, B, F + 4
Flying Dragon Kick	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2
Dragon's Roar	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2

LEARN FIRST

F44, 113, B34 and one safe core conversion. Then choose a variation. Liu Kang's variation sections are different enough that each deserves its own combo progression.

MKX • Liu Kang - Variations

DRAGON'S FIRE

Cancelable/delayable fireballs and EX Bicycle Kick launch routes. Highest execution ceiling through Fireball Run Cancels and instant-air fireball optimization.

FLAME FIST

Windmill Punch, Dragon Parry and Shaolin Flame. Strong chip/pressure identity; combos frequently finish through Windmill Punch and use Shaolin Flame cancels as execution grows.

DUALIST

Light/Dark stance, Solar/Soul Spheres and setup conversions. Community material consistently treats it as the most technical of Liu Kang's variations, with specialized corner and orb routes.

VARIATION COMBO RULE

Core strings are learned once. Each variation then gets its own BnB ladder so a Flame Fist or Dualist player is not forced to study Dragon's Fire combos that do not teach their toolkit.

MKX • Liu Kang - Important Strings

F44 - SHOWDOWN / LOW PRESSURE STARTER

Xbox: F + B, B

PlayStation: F + Circle, Circle

Universal: F + 4, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Bread-and-butter low starter and central hit-confirm string.

F443 - SAFE CONTINUATION

Xbox: F + B, B, A

PlayStation: F + Circle, Circle, Cross

Universal: F + 4, 4, 3

WHY IT MATTERS

Continuation when you do not want to cancel a blocked F44 into an unsafe special.

113 - OVERHEAD / COMBO STARTER

Xbox: X, X, A

PlayStation: Square, Square, Cross

Universal: 1, 1, 3

WHY IT MATTERS

Core starter appearing throughout Liu Kang's meterless and variation-specific routes.

B34 - JUGGLE BRIDGE

Xbox: B + A, B

PlayStation: B + Cross, Circle

Universal: B + 3, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Common bridge after launchers and in grounded conversions.

F213 - PRESSURE / VARIATION ROUTE

Xbox: F + Y, X, A

PlayStation: F + Triangle, Square, Cross

Universal: F + 2, 1, 3

WHY IT MATTERS

Important in Flame Fist and Dualist combo/setup material.

MKX • Liu Kang - Core Fundamentals

CORE / SHARED LESSONS

EASY STRING CONFIRM

Xbox: XXA, BAB, FBB~Bicycle Kick

PlayStation: SqSqCross, BCrossCircle, FCircleCircle~Bicycle Kick

Universal: 113, B34, F44~Bicycle Kick

A shared Liu Kang conversion idea: starter -> juggle bridge -> standing-reset ender. Exact special properties then vary by variation.

F44 HIT-CONFIRM

Xbox: FBB~Bicycle Kick on hit / FBBA on block

PlayStation: FCircleCircle~Bicycle Kick on hit / FCircleCircleCross on block

Universal: F44~Bicycle Kick on hit / F443 on block

Not merely a combo: this is the core decision-making drill that makes Liu Kang's pressure work.

FIRST TRAINING LESSON

Set Random Block. Confirm F44 into your hit ender only when it connects. On block, finish safely or stop. Do 20 correct decisions before practicing advanced cancels.

MKX • Liu Kang • Dragon's Fire

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY / METERLESS

Xbox: JY, X,X,A, F+B,B~FBF+B, D+Y

PlayStation: J Triangle, Square,Square,Cross, F+Circle,Circle~FBF+Circle, D+Triangle

Universal: J2, 113, F44~FBF4, D2

Widely documented beginner route around the low-30% range.

GROUNDING / METERLESS

Xbox: XXA, BAB, FBB~Bicycle Kick, DY

PlayStation: SqSqCross, BCrossCircle, FCircleCircle~Bicycle Kick, DTri

Universal: 113, B34, F44~FBF4, D2

Removes the jump-in and teaches the practical 113 -> B34 conversion.

1 BAR / EX BICYCLE

Xbox: FBB~EX Bicycle Kick, BAB, FBB~Dragon Kick

PlayStation: FCircleCircle~EX Bicycle Kick, BCrossCircle, FCircleCircle~Dragon Kick

Universal: F44~EX FBF4, B34, F44~BF2

Practical EX launcher route. The key skill is catching the opponent with B34 after the launch.

ADVANCED / FBRC

Universal: F44~Fireball Cancel / Run Cancel -> continue pressure or combo. Period Dragon's Fire resources devote substantial study to FBRC frame data and tutorials. Treat this as advanced execution, not a beginner requirement.

MKX • Liu Kang • Flame Fist

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY / METERLESS

Xbox: JY, XXA, BAB, FBF+B, DB+Y

PlayStation: J Triangle, SqSqCross, BCrossCircle, FBF+Circle, DB+Triangle

Universal: J2, 113, B34, FBF4, DB2

Period Flame Fist guide lists this family around 30%. Windmill Punch becomes the combo ender, followed by Dragon's Roar pressure/knockdown utility.

SHORT / METERLESS

Xbox: JY, BAB, FBF+B, DB+Y

PlayStation: J Triangle, BCrossCircle, FBF+Circle, DB+Triangle

Universal: J2, B34, FBF4, DB2

Shorter route from the same guide, useful when you want a lower-execution Flame Fist BnB.

1 BAR / SHAOLIN FLAME

Xbox: JY, BXY-EX DD+X, XXY-FBF+B, BF+Y

PlayStation: J Triangle, BSqTri-EX DD+Square, SqSqTri-FBF+Circle, BF+Triangle

Universal: J2, B12-EX DD1, 112~FBF4, BF2

Documented Flame Fist 1-bar route around low-30% damage. Teaches EX Shaolin Flame as the extension.

PRESSURE EXECUTION

Xbox: XXY-DD+X-FBF+B

PlayStation: SqSqTri-DD+Square-FBF+Circle

Universal: 112~DD1~FBF4

Not a long juggle; this is a signature Flame Fist cancel sequence. The timing is deliberate: cancel Shaolin Flame into Windmill Punch as the flame animation begins.

FLAME FIST GOAL

Damage is only part of the variation. Period guides emphasize chip damage, meter generation and pressure after Windmill Punch. Learn the easy BnB first, then the Shaolin Flame cancel.

MKX • Liu Kang • Dualist

VARIATION COMBOS / SETUPS

CORNER / METERLESS

Xbox: XXY~Stance Switch, XXA, BAB, DX, FYXA~Bicycle Kick, XXY~Dark Orb, Dark Orb Stop

PlayStation: SqSqTri~Stance Switch, SqSqCross, BCrossCircle, DSq, FTriSqCross~Bicycle Kick, SqSqTri~Dark Orb Stop

Universal: 112~Stance Switch, 113, B34, D1, F213~Bicycle Kick, 112~Dark Orb, Dark Orb Stop

Period Dualist combo thread lists this around mid-30% damage. It teaches the defining idea: combo damage flows directly into an orb setup.

CORNER / 1 BAR

Xbox: FYXA~EX Solar Flare, FYXA~Bicycle Kick, FYXA~Dragon Kick

PlayStation: FTriSqCross~EX Solar Flare, FTriSqCross~Bicycle Kick, FTriSqCross~Dragon Kick

Universal: F213~EX Solar Flare, F213~Bicycle Kick, F213~Dragon Kick

Documented easy corner metered route around 39-40%.

OFF METER-BURN ORB

Xbox: Orb, D+Y, FYXA~Bicycle Kick, XXY~Orb

PlayStation: Orb, D+Triangle, FTriSqCross~Bicycle Kick, SqSqTri~Orb

Universal: Orb, D2, F213~Bicycle Kick, 112~Orb

Documented setup conversion around the high-30% range. The important skill is recognizing an orb hit and immediately converting.

DUALIST EXPERT NOTE

Dualist is not just 'another combo variation.' Its pressure uses stance changes, orb timing, cancels and setups. Community discussion describes it as skill-intensive, and later guides focus heavily on practical sphere setups and technical cancel information.

MKX • Liu Kang - Progression / Finishers

FROM GUEST TO EXPERT

Guest: F44 + one ender. **Beginner:** one BnB in chosen variation. **Intermediate:** meter and corner route. **Advanced:** Dragon's Fire FBRC, Flame Fist Shaolin Flame cancels, or Dualist orb setups.

Expert: optimize pressure, resource use, corner retention and variation-specific setup value.

PRACTICE RULE

Choose one Liu Kang variation per session. Do not attempt FBRC, Shaolin Flame cancels and Dualist orb setups all at once.

FINISHERS

FINISHER	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL / RANGE
Sore Throat	D, D, B, F, F	D, D, B, F, F	D, D, B, F, F • Close
Splitter	B, F, D, U	B, F, D, U	B, F, D, U • Close
Stage Fatality	D, F, B + A	D, F, B + Cross	D, F, B + 3 • Close

BOOK NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

CORE CONFIRM: _____

VARIATION BnB: _____

ADVANCED SKILL: _____

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REVISION / VERIFICATION NOTES

Kung Lao: core routes and Tempest/Buzz Saw/Hat Trick material were checked against period TestYourMight all-variation threads, including later post-patch Hat Trick discussion. **Liu Kang:** Flame Fist routes were checked against the dedicated Flame Fist guide; Dualist routes against the later Liu Kang combo thread; variation identities and advanced study areas against the long-running Liu Kang variation discussion.

Patch-sensitive damage percentages are intentionally described approximately rather than presented as timeless guarantees. The installed MKX Practice mode remains the final authority if a route's timing or damage differs.

APPROVAL STATUS

Kung Lao: revised for all three variations — awaiting re-approval.

Liu Kang: revised for all three variations — awaiting approval.

Character #3: not started.

MKX • Sonya Blade

STYLE: 50/50 pressure / acrobatics / variation-specific setups / resource control

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Sonya is one of MKX's clearest examples of a character whose variations genuinely change how she plays. Her universal tools give her fast strings, an air dive kick, Energy Ring, Arc Kick and Leg Grab. Covert Ops turns Military Stance and Garrote Parry into a close-range mix-up game. Demolition turns grenades into combo extenders, safety and reload management. Special Forces uses a temporary drone for overhead/low pressure, combo extension and setup control.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Air Drop (air)	D + B	D + Circle	D + 4
Energy Ring / Blast	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2
Arc / Flying Kick	D, B + B	D, B + Circle	D, B + 4
Leg Grab / Slam	B, F + B	B, F + Circle	B, F + 4

WHAT THE CORE SPECIALS ARE FOR

Air Drop [BEGINNER] - Sonya's dive kick. It changes her air timing and can punish opponents who challenge her jump arc.

Energy Ring [BEGINNER] - Straight projectile for checking space.

Arc Kick [BEGINNER] - Advancing special and combo tool; enhanced Arc Kick is especially useful for armored conversion situations.

Leg Grab [BEGINNER] - Reliable combo ender that appears throughout Sonya's routes.

LEARN FIRST

B14 + B332 + Leg Grab + one universal corner route. Those pieces appear repeatedly, no matter which variation you eventually choose.

MKX • Sonya Blade - Variations

COVERT OPS

Military Stance and Garrote Parry. This is the most immediately recognizable close-range Sonya: strong overhead/low stance choices, parry reads and straightforward conversions. It is the easiest variation to explain to a guest while still having real depth.

DEMOLITION

Frag and Stun Grenades plus Drone Drop to reload. Grenade count is a real resource. The variation can extend combos, make pressure safer and build reload setups, but later patches changed how repeated grenades behave inside one combo.

SPECIAL FORCES

Calls a temporary drone with Heavy Blast, Homing Missile, Kamikaze and Low Kamikaze commands. The drone changes Sonya's pressure because she can replace expected overhead endings with a low drone attack and convert the hit into a juggle.

VARIATION LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Covert Ops. **Intermediate resource play:** Demolition. **Setup / assist play:** Special Forces. All three are viable learning paths; the combo pages below teach each separately.

MKX • Sonya Blade - Important Strings

BUILT-IN / IMPORTANT STRINGS

These are the recurring pieces. The goal is to recognize what each string does before memorizing long notation.

B14 - OVERHEAD / UNIVERSAL STARTER

Xbox: B + X, B

PlayStation: B + Square, Circle

Universal: B + 1, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

A core overhead-oriented starter that converts cleanly in Covert Ops and remains useful in the other variations.

B332 - LOW / 50-50 STARTER

Xbox: B + A, A, Y

PlayStation: B + Cross, Cross, Triangle

Universal: B + 3, 3, 2

WHY IT MATTERS

Sonya's major low starter. Together with B14 it forms the basic overhead/low decision that all three variations build around.

121 - FAST CONFIRM

Xbox: X, Y, X

PlayStation: Square, Triangle, Square

Universal: 1, 2, 1

WHY IT MATTERS

A useful fast string in universal and Demolition routes; grenade guides use it as a common starter.

2134 - COMBO ENDER / SETUP STRING

Xbox: Y, X, A, B

PlayStation: Triangle, Square, Cross, Circle

Universal: 2, 1, 3, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Appears repeatedly at the end of juggle routes. In Demolition it can lead into reload ideas; in Special Forces it can be followed by calling the drone for the next setup.

B33U4 - UNIVERSAL LAUNCHER

Xbox: B + A, A, U + B

PlayStation: B + Cross, Cross, U + Circle

Universal: B + 3, 3, U + 4

WHY IT MATTERS

A universal launcher used heavily in corner routes when you want a combo without relying on a variation-specific launcher.

MKX • Sonya Blade - Core / All Variations

CORE COMBOS

EASY / UNIVERSAL

Xbox: BAAU4, XY, NJY, DY, Run, XYX~BF+B

PlayStation: BCrossCrossU4, SqTri, NJ Triangle, D+Triangle, Run, SqTriSq~BF+Circle

Universal: B33U4, 12, NJ2, D2, Run, 121~BF4

A documented universal route that ends in Leg Grab. Use it to learn Sonya's launcher and juggle rhythm before adding stance, grenades or drone commands.

CORNER / UNIVERSAL

Xbox: BAAU4, XY, XY, XY, XY, XYB

PlayStation: BCrossCrossU4, SqTri, SqTri, SqTri, SqTri, SqTriCircle

Universal: B33U4, 12, 12, 12, 12, 124

Simple corner carry-over route documented in Sonya combo resources. The lesson is repeated standing jabs while gravity is restricted by the wall.

1 BAR / UNIVERSAL CORNER

Xbox: BXB~EX BF+Y, D+X, XY, XY, XY, XYB

PlayStation: BSqCircle~EX BF+Triangle, D+Square, SqTri, SqTri, SqTri, SqTriCircle

Universal: B14~EX BF2, D1, 12, 12, 12, 124

Universal enhanced Energy Ring corner conversion. This gives every variation a metered corner route even when its unique resource is unavailable.

CORE LESSON

Do not skip these because a variation has flashier tools. Sonya's universal launcher, jab timing and Leg Grab ender make every variation easier to understand.

MKX • Sonya Blade • Covert Ops

SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Military Stance	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Stance - Grab	X	Square	1
Stance - At Ease	Y	Triangle	2
Stance - Rising Kick	A	Cross	3
Stance - Double Kick	B	Circle	4
Garrote Parry / Punish	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Air Strike (air)	D + Throw	D + Throw	D + Throw

WHAT MAKES COVERT OPS DIFFERENT

Military Stance is the centerpiece. Instead of ending a string normally, Sonya can enter stance and choose different follow-ups, creating the overhead/low/throw-style guessing game. Garrote Parry adds a defensive read that can also lead to variation-specific punishment.

MKX • Sonya Blade • Covert Ops

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY OVERHEAD / METERLESS

Xbox: BXB~DB+Y, B, walk F, YX, YY~BF+B

PlayStation: BSqCircle~DB+Triangle, Circle, walk F, TriSq, TriTri~BF+Circle

Universal: B14~DB2, 4, walk F, 21, 22~BF4

Prima's sample Covert Ops route is about 29%. It teaches the entire variation in one sequence: overhead starter -> Military Stance -> Double Kick -> short juggle -> Leg Grab.

LOW STARTER / METERLESS

Xbox: BAAY~DB+Y, B, YX, YXAU4

PlayStation: BCrossCrossTri~DB+Triangle, Circle, TriSq, TriSqCrossU4

Universal: B332~DB2, 4, 21, 213U4

Low-side conversion from period Sonya combo material. Pair this with the B14 route so the opponent must respect both sides of the 50/50.

CORNER / METERLESS

Xbox: BXB~DB+Y, B, JX, XY, XY, XY, XYB

PlayStation: BSqCircle~DB+Triangle, Circle, JSq, SqTri, SqTri, SqTri, SqTriCircle

Universal: B14~DB2, 4, J1, 12, 12, 12, 124

Documented corner Covert Ops family around the low-30% range. The wall lets the Military Stance launch flow into repeated jab links.

1 BAR / PARRY CONVERSION

Xbox: EX DB+X, X, Air Drop, BAAY~DB+Y, B, Run, YX, YXA~BF+B

PlayStation: EX DB+Square, Square, Air Drop, BCrossCrossTri~DB+Triangle, Circle, Run, TriSq, 213~BF+Circle

Universal: EX DB1, 1, Air Drop, B332~DB2, 4, Run, 21, 213~BF4

A period one-bar Covert Ops route reported in the mid-40% range. This is advanced because the opening is a successful enhanced parry read.

COVERT OPS PRACTICE RULE

First land B14 -> Military Stance 4 ten times. Then B332 -> Military Stance 4 ten times. Only after both sides are automatic should you add the longer juggles.

MKX • Sonya Blade • Demolition

SPECIAL MOVES / GRENADE RESOURCE

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Drone Drop / Reload	D, D + X	D, D + Square	D, D + 1
Frag Grenade	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Stun Grenade	D, F + X	D, F + Square	D, F + 1
Detonate	X	Square	1
Bake 'n' Wake	X on wake-up	Square on wake-up	1 on wake-up

WHAT MAKES DEMOLITION DIFFERENT

Sonya carries a limited grenade stock and must reload with Drone Drop. Stun grenades hold the opponent for extensions; frag grenades add explosive pressure. Later MKXL patches restricted repeated same-type grenade behavior inside combos, so older day-one routes can be misleading. This chapter favors later 2016 guide material and explicitly teaches grenade count.

MKX • Sonya Blade • Demolition

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY / 1 GRENADE

Xbox: BXB-DF+X, YX, YXAB-DD+X

PlayStation: BSqCircle-DF+Square, TriSq, TriSqCrossCircle-DD+Square

Universal: B14-DF1, 21, 2134-DD1

A simplified 'never drop' family from the later Demolition guide. It teaches Stun Grenade -> short conversion -> reload instead of chasing maximum damage.

3 GRENADES / SAFE RELOAD BnB

Xbox: BXB-DF+X, FY, FY, DF+X, FY, DF+X, Run YXAB-DD+X

PlayStation: BSqCircle-DF+Square, FTri, FTri, DF+Square, FTri, DF+Square, Run TriSqCrossCircle-DD+Square

Universal: B14-DF1, F2, F2, DF1, F2, DF1, Run 2134-DD1

Later guide route documented around 34%. Its purpose is not only damage: it ends by restoring grenades for the next interaction.

1 BAR / GRENADE EXTENSION

Xbox: BAA-DF+X, FB, EX DD+X, FY, DF+X, FY, DF+X, Run YXAB

PlayStation: BCrossCrossTri-DF+Square, FCircle, EX DD+Square, FTri, DF+Square, FTri, DF+Square, Run TriSqCrossCircle-DD+Square

Universal: B332-DF1, F4, EX DD1, F2, DF1, F2, DF1, Run 2134

A later Demolition one-bar route listed around 41%. The enhanced Drone Drop is used as a combo extension rather than a simple reload.

NO GRENADES / UNIVERSAL FALLBACK

Xbox: BAAU4, XY, NJY, DY, Run, XYX-BF+B

PlayStation: BCrossCrossU4, SqTri, NJ Triangle, D+Triangle, Run, SqTriSq-BF+Circle

Universal: B33U4, 12, NJ2, D2, Run, 121-BF4

When the grenade pouch is empty, Sonya is not helpless. Fall back to the universal launcher route, then reload when the situation permits.

ADVANCED / NEGATIVE EDGE

The dedicated 2016 Demolition guide uses Release Check / negative edge for advanced mid-combo reloads, especially in the corner. This belongs in the expert tier because it changes how held/released button inputs trigger grenade detonation and reload. Learn the stable grenade-count routes first.

MKX • Sonya Blade • Special Forces

SPECIAL MOVES / DRONE COMMANDS

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Call / Park / Remove Drone	D, D + X	D, D + Square	D, D + 1
Heavy Blast	X + RT	Square + R2	1 + Block
Homing Missile	Y + RT	Triangle + R2	2 + Block
Kamikaze	A + RT	Cross + R2	3 + Block
Low Kamikaze	B + RT	Circle + R2	4 + Block

WHAT MAKES SPECIAL FORCES DIFFERENT

The drone exists for a limited time. Heavy Blast and Homing Missile add pressure/control; Kamikaze and Low Kamikaze sacrifice the drone for an attack. Low Kamikaze is especially important because Sonya can substitute it for an expected overhead string ending, creating a low hit that launches for a follow-up combo.

MKX • Sonya Blade • Special Forces

VARIATION COMBOS

EASY / DRONE OUT

Xbox: BAAY~Low Kamikaze, Run, YXAB~Call Drone

PlayStation: BCrossCrossTri~Low Kamikaze, Run, TriSqCrossCircle~Call Drone

Universal: B332~4+Block, Run, 2134~DD1

Prima's sample Special Forces route is about 29%. It teaches the whole loop: low starter -> drone launch -> juggle -> call the drone again for the next setup.

OVERHEAD START / DRONE

Xbox: BXB~Low Kamikaze, Run, BY, YXA~BF+B

PlayStation: BSqCircle~Low Kamikaze, Run, BTri, TriSqCross~BF+Circle

Universal: B14~4+Block, Run, B2, 213~BF4

Period Special Forces combo guide route. The important idea is that the drone turns B14 pressure into a launcher and Sonya cashes out with Leg Grab.

LOW START / DRONE

Xbox: BAAY~Low Kamikaze, BY, YXAB~Call Drone

PlayStation: BCrossCrossTri~Low Kamikaze, BTri, TriSqCrossCircle~Call Drone

Universal: B332~4+Block, B2, 2134~DD1

The low-side partner to the B14 route. Ending in Drone call sacrifices a little immediate damage to rebuild the next mix-up.

CORNER / DRONE

Xbox: BXB~Low Kamikaze, BY, XY, XY, YXAB~Call Drone

PlayStation: BSqCircle~Low Kamikaze, BTri, SqTri, SqTri, TriSqCrossCircle~Call Drone

Universal: B14~4+Block, B2, 12, 12, 2134~DD1

Documented corner drone route. The wall lets Sonya add repeated jab links before resetting the drone.

SPECIAL FORCES PRACTICE RULE

Practice the drone as a resource, not as background decoration: call it, run one B14/Low Kamikaze conversion, finish by calling it again, and repeat. Then add Homing Missile and Heavy Blast pressure separately.

MKX • Sonya Blade - Guest to Expert

FROM GUEST TO EXPERT

Guest: B14, B332, Leg Grab and Covert Ops Military Stance 4.

Beginner: one reliable BnB in a chosen variation plus the universal corner route.

Intermediate: learn the variation resource - stance/parry, grenade count/reload, or drone timing.

Advanced: add meter routes, corner-specific conversions and setup enders.

Expert: Covert Ops parry/stance reads; Demolition grenade inventory and negative-edge reload technology; Special Forces drone pressure, park/remove extensions and matchup-specific assist timing.

COMMON BEGINNER MISTAKES

Covert Ops: entering Military Stance every time makes the mix-up predictable.

Demolition: practicing a huge three-grenade route without learning how to reload leaves you lost as soon as the pouch is empty.

Special Forces: calling the drone and immediately throwing it away wastes the variation; learn what the threat does to the opponent's defense.

PRACTICE RULE

Choose ONE Sonya variation for a session. Do 10 clean reps of its easy route on each side, then five correct hit-confirms against Random Block. Only then practice the meter/corner route.

MKX • Sonya Blade - Finishers & Notes

X-RAY

Special Forces: Flip Stance + Block. The X-Ray is a counter-style attack. Because it costs the entire meter, it belongs in the round-closing / specific-read tier rather than Sonya's normal BnB plan.

FINISHERS

FINISHER	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL / RANGE
Target Marked	D, D, B, F + RT	D, D, B, F + R2	D, D, B, F + Block • Close
Head Hunter	F, B, D, B + Y	F, B, D, B + Triangle	F, B, D, B + 2 • Mid
Stage Fatality	B, F, D + Y	B, F, D + Triangle	B, F, D + 2 • Close

SELECTED BRUTALITIES

Thigh Master [Universal] - finish a qualifying 5+ hit combo with Leg Grab / Leg Slam.

Garro-That [Covert Ops] - requires the match's combo condition, then finish through Garrote Punish / its follow-up.

Time Bomb [Demolition] - variation-specific grenade brutality tied to the Boomer string condition.

Kamikaze [Special Forces] - finish a blocking opponent with Drone Kamikaze after meeting its condition.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

MY OVERHEAD ROUTE: _____

MY LOW ROUTE: _____

RESOURCE CHECK: STANCE / GRENADES / DRONE

WHAT I KEEP DROPPING: _____

MATCHUP / ARCADE NOTES: _____

SONYA BLADE • SOURCE / VERIFICATION NOTE

The chapter was built from period MKX material rather than modern memory: Prima Games for Sonya's variation identities, special-move purposes and sample combos; TestYourMight's Sonya combo thread for universal and Covert Ops routes; the 2016 Demolition guide for grenade-count, reload and negative-edge routes; and a period Special Forces combo guide for drone conversions. Move and finisher inputs were cross-checked against Mortal Kombat Secrets / GameFAQs.

Demolition is particularly patch-sensitive. Older routes that repeatedly used stun grenades can behave differently in the final MKXL-era rules. The chapter therefore teaches the resource system and later guide routes instead of presenting old damage numbers as permanent facts.

APPROVAL STATUS

Kung Lao: retained from Master 11.1.

Liu Kang: retained from Master 11.1.

Sonya Blade: NEW - awaiting approval.

Character #4: not started.

MKX • Jax

STYLE: advancing pressure / armored launch / corner destruction / variation-specific grappling or cancels

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Jax wants to walk or bully the opponent toward the corner, where his damage and pressure become dramatically stronger. His universal F21 and 11 strings, Overhead Dash Punch and Gotcha Grab form the basic engine. Pumped Up adds stronger Ground Pound/Gotcha tools, Wrestler adds command-throw and tick-throw pressure, and Heavy Weapons adds rockets, machine-gun control and technical cancel pressure.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Dash Punch	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2
Overhead Dash Punch	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Gotcha Grab	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Energy Wave	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2

LEARN FIRST

F21, 11, Overhead Dash Punch and Gotcha Grab. The key mechanical lesson is the run after an enhanced Overhead Dash Punch; it is the bridge into Jax's serious midscreen damage.

MKX • Jax - Variations

PUMPED UP

Better Ground Pound/Gotcha tools and strong damage. A straightforward first Jax variation if you want the classic punch-and-pound identity.

WRESTLER

Command grabs, tick throws and Multi Slam. This is the grappler-pressure variation: the combo itself matters, but the threat of being grabbed after respecting Jax's buttons matters just as much.

HEAVY WEAPONS

Rocket and machine-gun tools plus Rocket Cancels. Strong hit-confirm and pressure potential, but the cancel execution is the most technical Jax path.

VARIATION LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Pumped Up. **Pressure/grappler learner:** Wrestler. **Advanced execution:** Heavy Weapons.

MKX • Jax - Important Strings

F21 - ADVANCING MID / PRIMARY STARTER

Xbox: F + Y, X

PlayStation: F + Triangle, Square

Universal: F + 2, 1

WHY IT MATTERS

One of Jax's defining footsie and combo starters. Period combo material repeatedly builds his one-bar midscreen route from F21.

11 - FAST JAB / PRESSURE STARTER

Xbox: X, X

PlayStation: Square, Square

Universal: 1, 1

WHY IT MATTERS

Fast punish and pressure tool. Pumped Up guides emphasize the advantage after 11 and the mix-up that follows.

B34 - LOW STARTER / CORNER ROUTE

Xbox: B + A, B

PlayStation: B + Cross, Circle

Universal: B + 3, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Major low starter in Jax corner combos.

B2 - OVERHEAD STARTER

Xbox: B + Y

PlayStation: B + Triangle

Universal: B + 2

WHY IT MATTERS

Overhead half of Jax's mix-up; converts through Overhead Dash Punch.

124 - CORNER JUGGLE / ENDER STRING

Xbox: X, Y, B

PlayStation: Square, Triangle, Circle

Universal: 1, 2, 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Common late-corner string before Gotcha/Multi Slam enders.

MKX • Jax - Core / All Variations

CORE COMBOS

EASY / 1 BAR

Xbox: FYX~EX DB+Y, Run FYX, XX, FYX~DB+X

PlayStation: FTriSq~EX DB+Triangle, Run FTriSq, SqSq, FTriSq~DB+Square

Universal: F21~EX DB2, Run F21, 11, F21~DB1

Classic Jax one-bar midscreen route documented around 41% in early combo threads. This is the signature run-cancel lesson.

EASY ALTERNATIVE

Xbox: FYX~EX DB+Y, Run FA~BF+Y

PlayStation: FTriSq~EX DB+Triangle, Run FCross~BF+Triangle

Universal: F21~EX DB2, Run F3~BF2

Shorter route documented around 29%. Use this while learning the run timing.

METERLESS PUNISH

Xbox: 3B2, FYX, XX, FYX~DB+X

PlayStation: 3B2, FTriSq, SqSq, FTriSq~DB+Square

Universal: 3B2, F21, 11, F21~DB1

Documented meterless midscreen punish around 29%.

CORNER / LOW

Xbox: BAB~DB+Y, DXY, XX, XX, XYB~DB+X

PlayStation: BCrossCircle~DB+Triangle, DSqTri, SqSq, SqSq, SqTriCircle~DB+Square

Universal: B34~DB2, D12, 11, 11, 124~DB1

Universal corner family. Wrestler substitutes Multi Slam for Gotcha where appropriate.

MKX • Jax • Pumped Up

VARIATION FOCUS

Pumped Up improves the unblockable Ground Pound game and gives Jax enhanced Gotcha-style damage. Period guides describe it as the variation with better zoning/damage, while later discussion notes that Ground Pound's power changed with patches.

PUMPED UP BnB / 1 BAR

Xbox: XY~EX DB+Y, Run FYX, XX, FYX~DB+X

PlayStation: SqTri~EX DB+Triangle, Run FTriSq, SqSq, FTriSq~DB+Square

Universal: 12~EX DB2, Run F21, 11, F21~DB1

Fast-jab starter version of the universal Jax engine; period Pumped Up guide cites 38% one-bar damage from a 6-frame jab.

CORNER / PUMPED UP

Xbox: BAB~DB+Y, DXY, XX, XX, XYB~DB+X

PlayStation: BCrossCircle~DB+Triangle, DSqTri, SqSq, SqSq, SqTriCircle~DB+Square

Universal: B34~DB2, D12, 11, 11, 124~DB1

The corner is where Jax's damage jumps. Keep the route stable before chasing older max-damage Ground Pound tech.

ADVANCED PUMPED UP

Add Ground Pound placement, air Ground Pound reads and Super/Extreme Gotcha sequencing after the core routes. Because unblockable/OTG behavior was patched, Practice mode is the authority for the installed final version.

MKX • Jax • Wrestler

VARIATION FOCUS

Wrestler is not simply 'Jax with different combo damage.' Its identity is tick throws and Multi Slam. Period competitive discussion repeatedly describes Wrestler as the close-range grappler version and notes that its command-throw pressure can matter more than raw midscreen combo percentage.

CORE-TO-WRESTLER

Xbox: FYX-EX DB+Y, Run FYX, XX, FYX-Multi Slam

PlayStation: FTriSq-EX DB+Triangle, Run FTriSq, SqSq, FTriSq-Multi Slam

Universal: F21-EX DB2, Run F21, 11, F21-Multi Slam

Use the universal launch route but finish with the Wrestler command-throw sequence where appropriate.

CORNER / WRESTLER

Xbox: BAB-DB+Y, XX, XX, XX, XYB-Multi Slam

PlayStation: BCrossCircle-DB+Triangle, SqSq, SqSq, SqSq, SqTriCircle-Multi Slam

Universal: B34-DB2, 11, 11, 11, 124-Multi Slam

Wrestler-specific corner conversion family; period players reported 40%+ meterless corner damage.

TICK-THROW LESSON

The advanced lesson is not a longer juggle. Practice a safe pressure string, then command grab when the opponent freezes; practice stopping/striking when they try to escape. Wrestler becomes expert-level through reads and tick-throw timing.

MKX • Jax • Heavy Weapons

VARIATION FOCUS

Heavy Weapons trades the simpler variation tools for Rocket/Machine Gun control and cancel pressure. Community discussion highlights F3/F21 hit-confirms into Rocket Cancels as the variation's major strength. Later MKXL reports also documented a run-after-Rocket-Cancel bug, so advanced routes can be version-sensitive.

SAFE START / HEAVY WEAPONS

Xbox: FYX~EX DB+Y, Run FYX, XX, FYX~DB+X

PlayStation: FTriSq~EX DB+Triangle, Run FTriSq, SqSq, FTriSq~DB+Square

Universal: F21~EX DB2, Run F21, 11, F21~DB1

Begin with the universal Jax route. Heavy Weapons does not require Rocket Cancels just to function.

HIT-CONFIRM DRILL

Xbox: FA~Rocket Cancel -> continue only on hit

PlayStation: FCross~Rocket Cancel -> continue only on hit

Universal: F3~Rocket Cancel -> continue only on hit

Period Jax discussion calls F3 hit-confirming one of Heavy Weapons' strongest tools. Treat this as a training drill before attempting long cancel combos.

ADVANCED / ROCKET CANCEL

Rocket Cancel -> run/pressure is the expert skill. Learn one cancel at a time, then add it to F21 and F3. If the installed build does not permit a documented run follow-up, do not force an old route; use the final game's behavior.

MKX • Jax - Finishers & BOOX

FROM GUEST TO EXPERT

Guest: F21 + short EX Dash Punch route. **Beginner:** full one-bar run combo. **Intermediate:** corner route plus one variation skill. **Advanced:** Pumped Up Ground Pound reads, Wrestler tick throws, or Heavy Weapons Rocket Cancels. **Expert:** corner carry, resource choices and matchup-specific pressure.

FINISHERS

FINISHER	UNIVERSAL / RANGE
T-Wrecks	F, B, D + 2 • Close
Jax The Ribber	D, B, F, F • Close
Stage Fatality	D, F, D + 1 • Close

VARIATION BRUTALITY MARKERS

Pumped Up: Ground Breaking. **Wrestler:** Ragdoll. **Heavy Weapons:** Rocket Roll. The finisher appendix will preserve the exact match conditions.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

RUN COMBO RELIABILITY: _____

CORNER ROUTE: _____

VARIATION SKILL: _____

MKX • Kano

STYLE: footsies / knives / ball movement / rushdown, zoning or grappling depending on variation

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Kano is three very different characters built on the same movement and footsie shell. Cutthroat is the rushdown/50-50 version with Blade Slice and a damage buff. Cybernetic is the spacing and keep-away version with enhanced knife technology. Commando is the read-heavy grappler with command grabs and parries. The universal lesson is spacing: Knife, Kano Ball, B31 and 112 teach when to stay out and when to force your way in.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Knife	D, F + Y	D, F + Triangle	D, F + 2
Kano Ball	B, F + A	B, F + Cross	B, F + 3
Air Kano Ball	B, F + A (air)	B, F + Cross (air)	B, F + 3 (air)

LEARN FIRST

112, B31, Knife and Kano Ball. Then choose the variation that matches the playstyle you want: rushdown, zoning or grappling.

MKX • Kano - Variations

CUTTHROAT

Rushdown and 50/50s. Gains Blade Slice, an overhead string and Power Up damage buff. Later guides emphasize safe Blade Slice pressure and strong damage.

CYBERNETIC

Spacing/keep-away. Mid knife tools and strong projectile control make this the cleanest Kano for players who prefer controlling distance.

COMMANDO

True grappler flavor: fast command grabs, parries and Choke. Beginner guides stress fundamentals and reads over huge combo damage.

VARIATION LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Cybernetic for simple spacing or Cutthroat for aggression. **Fundamentals/grappler study:** Commando. All three get their own combo plan below.

MKX • Kano - Important Strings

112 - FAST PUNISH / COMBO STRING

Xbox: X,X,Y

PlayStation: Square,Square,Triangle

Universal: 1,1,2

WHY IT MATTERS

Basic punish string and a staple in Kano combo routes.

B31 - LOW / FOOTsie STARTER

Xbox: B + A, X

PlayStation: B + Cross, Square

Universal: B + 3, 1

WHY IT MATTERS

Low starter and key Kano footsie string. Cutthroat uses it for mix-ups; Commando beginner material teaches it early.

B312 - LOW CORNER LAUNCHER

Xbox: B + A, X, Y

PlayStation: B + Cross, Square, Triangle

Universal: B + 3, 1, 2

WHY IT MATTERS

Central to Kano's meterless corner juggles.

F4 - ADVANCING KNEE

Xbox: F + B

PlayStation: F + Circle

Universal: F + 4

WHY IT MATTERS

Long-reaching advancing normal; Cutthroat guides praise it for getting in and crushing low pokes.

F212 - CUTTHROAT LAUNCH / ADVANCE

Xbox: F + Y, X, Y

PlayStation: F + Triangle, Square, Triangle

Universal: F + 2, 1, 2

WHY IT MATTERS

Important Cutthroat launcher/footsie route and one of the variation's main combo starters.

MKX • Kano - Core / No Variation

CORE COMBOS

EASY / METERLESS

Xbox: XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: 112~BF3

The simplest Kano confirm: fast string into Kano Ball. Learn this before variation optimization.

JUGGLE / METERLESS

Xbox: NJP, BX, BX, BX, Run, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: NJP, BSq, BSq, BSq, Run, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: NJP, B1, B1, B1, Run, 112~BF3

No-variation combo thread route around 26%. It teaches Kano's run/juggle rhythm.

CORNER / METERLESS

Xbox: BAXY, BAXY, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BCrossSqTri, BCrossSqTri, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B312, B312, 112~BF3

Documented universal corner route around 37%.

CORE LESSON

Kano's variations change his neutral more than they change the need for clean fundamentals. If 112 and B31 cannot reliably cancel into Kano Ball, the advanced variation tools will not save you.

MKX • Kano • Cutthroat

VARIATION FOCUS

Cutthroat adds Blade Slice (DB1), Power Up (DD3) and stronger mix-up strings. A later patch guide describes DB1 as a major safe pressure tool and Power Up as a damage/chip buff that costs Kano health while active.

EASY / METERLESS

Xbox: FYXY, Y~DB+X, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: FTriSqTri, Tri~DB+Square, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: F212, 2~DB1, 112~BF3

Updated Cutthroat guide route around 30% unbuffered. Excellent first real Cutthroat BnB.

STARTER / RESTAND

Xbox: BAX~DB+X

PlayStation: BCrossSq~DB+Square

Universal: B31~DB1

Short restand concept. Blade Slice leaves the opponent standing so Kano can run back in and threaten another mix-up.

1 BAR / EX BLADE

Xbox: BAX~EX DB+X, Y~DB+X, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BCrossSq~EX DB+Square, Tri~DB+Square, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B31~EX DB1, 2~DB1, 112~BF3

One-bar Cutthroat extension family from the updated guide; teaches EX Blade Slice launch into another Blade Slice.

CORNER / METERLESS

Xbox: BAXY, BAXY, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BCrossSqTri, BCrossSqTri, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B312, B312, 112~BF3

Cutthroat corner damage becomes much stronger because B312 can launch without spending meter.

ADVANCED / POWER UP

Add DD3 only after the normal BnB is reliable. The buff increases damage/chip but drains Kano's health and disappears if he is hit. Expert Cutthroat is deciding when the extra damage is worth that risk.

MKX • Kano • Cybernetic

VARIATION FOCUS

Cybernetic emphasizes knife control and spacing. Community guidance consistently describes it as Kano's keep-away variation, with relatively straightforward execution but a more unconventional high-level neutral game.

EASY / METERLESS

Xbox: BAX~DB+X, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BCrossSq~DB+Square, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B31~DB1, 112~BF3

Cybernetic combo-thread family in the low-to-mid 20% range. The important part is the DB1 bridge into 112.

RE STAND

Xbox: BAX~DB+X, BYA~X+A

PlayStation: BCrossSq~DB+Square, BTriCross~Sq+Cross

Universal: B31~DB1, B23~1+3

Documented restand family. Sacrifice some raw damage to keep the opponent standing and preserve pressure.

1 BAR

Xbox: BAX~DB+X, XXY~EX BF+A, JX, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BCrossSq~DB+Square, SqSqTri~EX BF+Cross, JSq, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B31~DB1, 112~EX BF3, J1, 112~BF3

One-bar Cybernetic extension family from the organized Kano combo thread.

CORNER / METERLESS

Xbox: BAX~DB+X, BAXY, BAXY, XXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BCrossSq~DB+Square, BCrossSqTri, BCrossSqTri, SqSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B31~DB1, B312, B312, 112~BF3

Corner Cybernetic family documented in the high-30% range depending starter.

CYBERNETIC PRACTICE

Spend as much time throwing knives at useful ranges as practicing combos. The variation's point is to make the opponent take risks getting in, then convert when they finally make one.

MKX • Kano • Commando

VARIATION FOCUS

Commando replaces the other variations' easy identity tools with command grabs and parries. Dedicated beginner material calls it a fundamentals-heavy character and explicitly says big combo damage is not the most important part of the variation.

BEGINNER / STRING TO SPECIAL

Xbox: XXY~DF+Y

PlayStation: SqSqTri~DF+Triangle

Universal: 112~DF2

The Commando beginner guide teaches short cancelable-string routes first. The goal is clean input buffering, not damage.

BEGINNER / KANO BALL

Xbox: BXA~BF+A

PlayStation: BSqCross~BF+Cross

Universal: B13~BF3

Another simple starter-to-special drill from the beginner progression.

CORNER / COMMAND GRAB

Xbox: BAXY, AY~DBF+B

PlayStation: BCrossSqTri, CrossTri~DBF+Circle

Universal: B312, 32~DBF4

The beginner Commando guide's easy corner juggle into Rib Breaker. Master this on both sides before advanced command-grab routes.

COMMANDO EXPERT LESSON

Command grabs can choose where the opponent ends up; parries punish predictable offense; Choke can act as a safe string ender/anti-air. The advanced game is conditioning and reads. Do not burn meter just to make a beginner combo look bigger.

MKX • Kano - Finishers & BOOX

FROM GUEST TO EXPERT

Guest: 112 -> Kano Ball. **Beginner:** B31 and one variation BnB. **Intermediate:** corner route plus variation resource. **Advanced:** Cutthroat buff/mix-up decisions, Cybernetic spacing/resting pressure, or Commando tick throws/parries. **Expert:** choose the variation's win condition rather than forcing the same Kano plan into every matchup.

FINISHERS

FINISHER	UNIVERSAL / RANGE
Head Case	D, F, D, B + 3 • Close
Knife To Meet You	D, D, F + 1 • Far
Stage Fatality	U, U, B + 3 • Close

VARIATION BRUTALITY MARKERS

Cutthroat: Just the Tip. **Cybernetic:** Glaring Light. **Commando:** Wham Bam / Pop Off. Exact match requirements remain part of the finisher reference.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

BEST NEUTRAL TOOL: _____

BnB: _____

CORNER ROUTE: _____

VARIATION WIN CONDITION: _____

MASTER 13 • VERIFICATION / APPROVAL

Jax: combo structure checked against the organized Jax combo thread and Pumped Up guide; variation identities and Heavy Weapons/Wrestler emphasis checked against period Jax discussions. **Kano:** Cutthroat routes checked against the 2016 patch-updated guide; Cybernetic against the Kano Kombo Thread 2.0; Commando against the dedicated beginner/full guides.

Finishers for both fighters were cross-checked against the 2017 GameFAQs Fatality List. Damage numbers are described approximately because MKX patches changed scaling and some variation technology. Practice mode in the installed build remains the final authority.

APPROVAL STATUS

Kung Lao: retained.

Liu Kang: retained.

Sonya Blade: retained.

Jax: NEW - awaiting approval.

Kano: NEW - awaiting approval.

Character #6: not started.

MKX - Johnny Cage

STYLE: pressure / frame traps / standing resets / variation-specific buffs, mimics or run cancels

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Johnny wants to get close, make the opponent respect fast pressure, and repeatedly end conversions in Nut Punch so he stays beside a standing opponent. His three variations change how technical that pressure becomes: Fisticuffs is the stripped-down rushdown version, Stunt Double adds two-use mimic attacks, and A-List turns charged attacks and run cancels into a high-execution pressure system.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
High Forceball	D, F + Y	D, F + Triangle	D, F + 2
Low Forceball	D, F + X	D, F + Square	D, F + 1
Shadow Kick	B, F + B	B, F + Circle	B, F + 4
Nut Punch	B, D + A	B, D + Cross	B, D + 3
Rising Kick*	D, B + B	D, B + Circle	D, B + 4

*Variation availability/properties differ. Do not assume every Johnny variation has every version of Rising/Flip Kick.

LEARN FIRST

F24, 113, Shadow Kick and Nut Punch. The first real Johnny lesson is ending a combo in Nut Punch and recognizing that the standing reset is often worth more than squeezing out one extra hit.

MKX - Johnny Cage - Variations

FISTICUFFS

The most bare-bones Johnny. Fist Bump temporarily improves his punching/chip game and the variation adds flashy pressure strings. Good for learning the Johnny shell without mimic management or A-List cancel execution.

STUNT DOUBLE

Activates two mimic attacks that can be spent on mimic Shadow Kick or mimic uppercut-style tools. Strong damage, corner carry and frame-trap possibilities, but you must learn when to activate and spend the doubles.

A-LIST

Chargeable normals/specials plus run-cancel pressure. This is the technical Johnny: hit-confirming, stamina management and Shadow Kick Run Cancels are the expert layer.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Fisticuffs. **Intermediate:** Stunt Double. **Advanced/Expert:** A-List. A player can absolutely start elsewhere, but this order makes the mechanics progressively more demanding.

MKX - Johnny Cage - Core Combos

GUEST / EASY

Xbox: FYB, DX, FA-BD+A

PlayStation: FTriCircle, DSq, FCross-BD+Cross

Universal: F24, D1, F3-BD3

A short Johnny route that teaches the important idea: finish in Nut Punch and stay close.

PUNISH / EASY

Xbox: XXA-BD+A

PlayStation: SqSqCross-BD+Cross

Universal: 113-BD3

Simple punish-to-reset drill. Once this is automatic, extend 113 into the variation-specific launcher or cancel.

CORNER FOUNDATION

Xbox: FYB, DX, XY, XY, XXA-BD+A

PlayStation: FTriCircle, DSq, SqTri, SqTri, SqSqCross-BD+Cross

Universal: F24, D1, 12, 12, 113-BD3

A deliberately shortened corner rhythm. Add repetitions only after the timing is reliable.

WHY NUT PUNCH MATTERS

Period Johnny discussion specifically recommends ending most practical combos in Nut Punch for the standing reset. For a guest, that means one simple rule: if you are unsure how to end the combo, put them back on their feet next to Johnny and keep playing.

MKX - Johnny Cage - Fisticuffs

Fisticuffs removes the fancy mimic and A-List cancel systems. Its variation lesson is Fist Bump plus pressure. That makes it ideal for someone who wants 'classic Cage' first.

FISTICUFFS CORNER / 1 BAR

Xbox: FYB, DX, XY, XY, XY, YX-EX BD+A, XXA-BD+A

PlayStation: FTriCircle, DSq, SqTri, SqTri, SqTri, TriSq-EX BD+Cross, SqSqCross-BD+Cross

Universal: F24, D1, 12, 12, 12, 21-EX BD3, 113-BD3

Based on the period Fisticuffs corner family. Fewer 12 repetitions can be used as an easier training version.

FIST BUMP LESSON

Do not activate Fist Bump merely because it is available. First create enough advantage or space to use it safely, then deliberately pressure while the buff is active. The expert lesson is maximizing the buff window rather than memorizing a longer juggle.

MKX - Johnny Cage - Stunt Double

Stunt Double adds mimic management. You activate the doubles, then spend them on mimic attacks for pressure, conversions and matchup utility. The activation/cooldown cycle is part of the character.

STUNT DOUBLE FOUNDATION

Xbox: FYB~Mimic, follow with FYB, DX, FA~BD+A

PlayStation: FTriCircle~Mimic, follow with FTriCircle, DSq, FCross~BD+Cross

Universal: F24~Mimic, follow with F24, D1, F3~BD3

Use this as a concept drill rather than a max-damage promise: learn to recognize the mimic launch and still finish in Nut Punch.

MIMIC MANAGEMENT

The doubles are a resource. Practice three separate skills: activate them safely, confirm into one mimic, and decide whether to spend the second mimic now or preserve it. Period Stunt Double guides emphasize that getting the mimics active and managing their cooldown is the variation's central constraint.

MKX - Johnny Cage - A-List

A-List is where Johnny becomes an execution character. Chargeable attacks can be cancelled into a run, letting Johnny extend combos and create pressure while stamina lasts.

A-LIST RUN-CANCEL BnB

Xbox: FA[4]~RC, FB, FYB, DX, FA~BD+A

PlayStation: FCross[4]~RC, FCircle, FTriCircle, DSq, FCross~BD+Cross

Universal: F3[4]~RC, F4, F24, D1, F3~BD3

A period A-List tutorial route around the mid-20% range. Brackets indicate the charged/cancelled portion; RC means Run Cancel.

A-LIST SHADOW-KICK RC

Xbox: BAB~BF[B]~RC, FB, FYB, DX, FA~BD+A

PlayStation: BCrossCircle~BF[Circle]~RC, FCircle, FTriCircle, DSq, FCross~BD+Cross

Universal: B34~BF[4]~RC, F4, F24, D1, F3~BD3

This is the classic Shadow Kick Run Cancel lesson. Do not chase speed first - make the cancel clean, then shorten the gap.

EXPERT A-LIST

The real ceiling is not one giant combo. It is confirming whether the opponent was hit or blocked, choosing the correct continuation, and managing stamina so pressure does not collapse at the wrong moment.

MKX - Cassie Cage

STYLE: fast advancing mids / flip-kick launch / run combos / variation-specific missiles, guns or grappling

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Cassie is an excellent bridge from beginner to serious MKX play because her core combo teaches the game's Run mechanic directly. B12 or F3 goes into Flip Kick, she runs underneath/forward, then reconnects with B12. The ender changes by variation: Hollywood favors Nut Punch and air-gun utility, Brawler adds command-grab and overhead options, and Spec Ops adds missile setups.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Gunshot	B, F + X	B, F + Square	B, F + 1
Flip Kick	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Getaway Flip	D, B + A	D, B + Cross	D, B + 3
Glow Kick	B, F + B	B, F + Circle	B, F + 4

LEARN FIRST

B12 -> Flip Kick -> Run -> B12. That one sequence teaches launching, buffering the run, judging juggle height and choosing a variation-specific ender.

MKX - Cassie Cage - Variations

HOLLYWOOD

Technical rushdown with Nut Punch and air-gun tools. Strong close pressure and reset/setplay potential.

BRAWLER

Pure close-range version. Adds command-grab/tick-throw ideas, an overhead special option and strong straightforward midscreen damage.

SPEC OPS

Missile-based setup and screen-control variation. It can finish a combo by calling a missile instead of taking immediate damage, forcing the opponent to deal with the incoming threat on wake-up.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Brawler. **Beginner learning MKX systems:** Hollywood or Brawler. **Setup player:** Spec Ops. Period Cassie guides consider all three viable but emphasize that Hollywood becomes more technical at higher levels.

MKX - Cassie Cage - Core Run Combo

CORE BnB - LEARN THIS

Xbox: BXY~DB+Y, Run, BXY~ender

PlayStation: BSqTri~DB+Triangle, Run, BSqTri~ender

Universal: B12~DB2, Run, B12~ender

This is the beginner-guide Cassie skeleton. The ender depends on variation. If B1 goes under the falling opponent, you ran/pressed too early; if it sails over, you were too late.

LOW STARTER

Xbox: D+FX~DB+Y, Run, BXY~ender

PlayStation: D+FSq~DB+Triangle, Run, BSqTri~ender

Universal: D+F1~DB2, Run, B12~ender

Same lesson from a low starter. Cancel after the appropriate hit of the string; first learn the run timing from B12.

EASIER RUN VERSION

Xbox: BXY~DB+Y, Run, BXY~BF+B

PlayStation: BSqTri~DB+Triangle, Run, BSqTri~BF+Circle

Universal: B12~DB2, Run, B12~BF4

A simple universal-style ender for practice. Once the run connection is dependable, replace the ender with the variation's preferred setup.

RUN TIMING

Buffer Forward, Forward + Block during Flip Kick and hold Block until the kick ends. Cassie begins running as soon as possible. Then release and input B1 during the run. This is one of the clearest 'for dummies' ways to learn MKX run combos.

MKX - Cassie Cage - Hollywood

Hollywood adds the classic Nut Punch ender and air-gun utility. Its close-range game becomes increasingly technical as you learn pressure and setups.

HOLLYWOOD BnB

Xbox: BXY~DB+Y, Run, YXY, BXY~BD+A

PlayStation: BSqTri~DB+Triangle, Run, TriSqTri, BSqTri~BD+Cross

Universal: B12~DB2, Run, 212, B12~BD3

Core Cassie run route with the Hollywood Nut Punch-style ender. If 212 makes the route unreliable, omit it until the B12 reconnect is automatic.

HOLLYWOOD LESSON

Start with the run combo and standing ender. Add air guns and enhanced Nut Punch only after the basic conversion is stable. Hollywood's strength grows with execution, but a guest does not need the advanced layer to understand the character.

MKX - Cassie Cage - Brawler

Brawler is Cassie's close-range/grappler-flavored variation. It gains a short-range command grab, extra mix-up options and a strong practical combo ender.

BRAWLER BnB

Xbox: BXY~DB+Y, Run, YXY, BXY~BF+A

PlayStation: BSqTri~DB+Triangle, Run, TriSqTri, BSqTri~BF+Cross

Universal: B12~DB2, Run, 212, B12~BF3

The period beginner guide identifies BF3 as Brawler's standard ender after the core run combo.

BRAWLER EXPERT LESSON

The advanced layer is not just damage. Learn when the opponent is respecting your strings enough to be command-grabbed, and when they are trying to jump or poke out. Brawler's tick-throw/option-select ideas are where the variation becomes difficult to defend.

MKX - Cassie Cage - Spec Ops

Spec Ops changes the reward after a combo. Instead of always cashing out damage, Cassie can call a missile and make the opponent wake up into a new problem.

SPEC OPS BnB / DAMAGE

Xbox: BXY~DB+Y, Run, YXY, BXY~BF+B

PlayStation: BSqTri~DB+Triangle, Run, TriSqTri, BSqTri~BF+Circle

Universal: B12~DB2, Run, 212, B12~BF4

A damage-focused finish when you do not want the missile setup.

SPEC OPS SETUP

Xbox: BXY~DB+Y, Run, YXY, BXYB~DD+X

PlayStation: BSqTri~DB+Triangle, Run, TriSqTri, BSqTriCircle~DD+Square

Universal: B12~DB2, Run, 212, B124~DD1

Conceptual missile-setup route: period guides explicitly note that DD1 does not itself combo; the point is to threaten the opponent as they recover.

SPEC OPS LESSON

This variation teaches delayed reward. Call the missile when the setup is more valuable than immediate damage, then learn what the opponent tends to do when the missile is coming. That decision-making is the expert layer.

MKX - Kitana

STYLE: zoning / air control / whiff punishment / high-damage conversions

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Kitana is a defensive, spacing-first fighter. Fans make the opponent approach, her air control punishes careless movement, and a clean launcher can turn one mistake into substantial damage. She is not built around constant overhead/low guessing; the beginner lesson is patience, positioning and converting the opponent's mistake.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Fan Throw	D, F + X	D, F + Square	D, F + 1
Air Fan Throw	D, F + X (air)	D, F + Square (air)	D, F + 1 (air)
Rising Fan / Upraise*	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Throat Slice	B, F + A	B, F + Cross	B, F + 3

*Launcher/special properties depend on variation. Royal Storm replaces the normal lift with Fan-Nado.

LEARN FIRST

111, F43, Fan Throw and the launcher. Kitana's first complete lesson is launcher -> neutral jump punch -> grounded string -> fan extension -> ender.

MKX - Kitana - Variations

ROYAL STORM

The most traditional Kitana. Adds Fan-Nado, Square Boost and projectile reflect. Strong zoning, anti-zoning and air mobility; later competitive discussion highlights the long-range lift as an important footsie check.

ASSASSIN

Damage/hit-and-run Kitana. Sharpen buffs damage/chip, Assassin Strike gives a long-range attack, and parry adds a read-based defensive tool.

MOURNFUL

The Jade-inspired variation. Fan Throw becomes Glaive Throw and she gains Shadow Kick and Staff Grab. Ground space control and safer projectile pressure become the identity.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Royal Storm. **Damage learner:** Assassin. **Footsie/Jade-style learner:** Mournful. Royal Storm is especially good for learning Kitana's classic zoning identity.

MKX - Kitana - Core / All Variations

EASY LAUNCHER ROUTE

Xbox: XXX~DB+Y, NJY, FBA~ender

PlayStation: SqSqSq~DB+Triangle, NJTri, FCircleCross~ender

Universal: 111~DB2, NJ2, F43~ender

The teaching skeleton: fast string -> launcher -> neutral-jump conversion -> stable grounded ender.
Use the variation's appropriate ender.

FAN-CONVERSION DRILL

Xbox: Launcher, NJY, FBA~DF+X, Run, YX~ender

PlayStation: Launcher, NJTri, FCircleCross~DF+Square, Run, TriSq~ender

Universal: Launcher, NJ2, F43~DF1, Run, 21~ender

Adds the signature fan extension. The Air Fan can suspend an airborne opponent long enough for Kitana to run forward and continue.

BEGINNER MISTAKE

Trying to rush down with Kitana because her combos look flashy. Her guides consistently describe her as defensive. Make the opponent cross the fan/footsie space first, then cash out when they are wrong.

MKX - Kitana - Royal Storm

Royal Storm adds Fan-Nado, Square Boost and Bounce Back. Enhanced Fan-Nado can reach full screen; Square Boost strengthens air mobility and can challenge projectiles; Bounce Back reflects projectiles.

ROYAL STORM BnB

Xbox: XXX~DF+X, Run FBA, FBA, YX~DF+X, JA~Air Square Boost

PlayStation: SqSqSq~DF+Square, Run FCircleCross, FCircleCross, TriSq~DF+Square, JCross~Air Square Boost

Universal: 111~DF1, Run F43, F43, 21~DF1, J3~Air Square Boost

Adapted from period Royal Storm sample routing. Learn the fan/run rhythm first; exact damage is patch-sensitive.

FULL-SCREEN FAN-NADO CONVERSION

Xbox: EX Fan-Nado, Air Fan, Run, FBA~ender

PlayStation: EX Fan-Nado, Air Fan, Run, FCircleCross~ender

Universal: EX Fan-Nado, Air Fan, Run, F43~ender

The variation-specific lesson: a distant EX lift can still become real damage if you use Air Fan to hold the opponent while Kitana closes the gap.

ROYAL STORM EXPERT

Use reflect and long-range lift to make opposing zoners hesitate. The expert skill is not throwing more fans; it is knowing when the opponent expects a fan and punishing the answer instead.

MKX - Kitana - Assassin

Assassin trades Royal Storm's anti-zoning tools for damage. Sharpen temporarily raises damage/chip, Assassin Strike provides long-range punishment, and parry rewards a strong read.

ASSASSIN FOUNDATION

Xbox: XXX~DB+Y, NJY, FBA~Fan, Run YX~Throat Slice

PlayStation: SqSqSq~DB+Triangle, NJTri, FCircleCross~Fan, Run TriSq~Throat Slice

Universal: 111~DB2, NJ2, F43~DF1, Run 21~BF3

A stable Assassin-style conversion that preserves Kitana's core launcher/fan engine and ends in damage.

SHARPEN PRACTICE

Xbox: Create space / advantage -> Sharpen -> run the same BnB

PlayStation: Create space / advantage -> Sharpen -> run the same BnB

Universal: Create space / advantage -> Sharpen -> run the same BnB

Sharpen is a buff, not a combo by itself. Practice activating it safely, then compare the same conversion with and without the buff.

ASSASSIN EXPERT

Period guides describe Assassin as the damage/hit-and-run variation. Expert play is choosing when the buff opportunity is worth giving up position and when Assassin Strike or parry is the better answer.

MKX - Kitana - Mournful

Mournful replaces fans with Jade-style glaives and adds Shadow Kick plus Staff Grab. The ground game becomes safer and more space-control oriented, while some of Kitana's classic air-control/damage is reduced.

MOURNFUL BnB

Xbox: XXX~launcher, NJY, FBA~Glaive, Run YX~Staff Grab

PlayStation: SqSqSq~launcher, NJTri, FCircleCross~Glaive, Run TriSq~Staff Grab

Universal: 111~launcher, NJ2, F43~Glaive, Run 21~Staff Grab

The Mournful teaching route: use the same Kitana juggle logic, but substitute the variation's glaive/staff tools.

SHADOW-KICK PUNISH

Xbox: Whiff punish -> Shadow Kick

PlayStation: Whiff punish -> Shadow Kick

Universal: Whiff punish -> Shadow Kick

Not every important route is a juggle. Shadow Kick covers roughly half-screen and is meant to punish mistakes at distance; enhanced version travels farther and has armor.

MOURNFUL EXPERT

Learn glaive angles and when the returning enhanced glaive makes retaliation awkward. Mournful wins through ground control and safer projectile pressure, not by imitating Assassin's damage plan.

MKX - Kitana - Guest to Expert

Guest: Fan Throw + 111 launcher combo.

Beginner: add Air Fan extension and one Royal Storm route.

Intermediate: learn one complete variation and its spacing tool.

Advanced: full-screen conversions, anti-zoning, Sharpen/parry decisions or Mournful projectile pressure.

Expert: convert almost any anti-air/whiff punish while choosing damage, corner carry or screen position.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

BEST FAN / GLAIVE RANGE: _____

BnB: _____

ANTI-AIR CONVERSION: _____

WHAT I KEEP DROPPING: _____

MKX - Kenshi

STYLE: keep-away / telekinetic control / sword spacing / variation-specific 50-50s

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Kenshi rewards patience. He wants the opponent at the range where telekinetic or sword attacks control movement and punish attempts to enter. Kenjutsu moves him toward sword-based 50/50 and meterless damage, Possessed adds demon attacks and teleport pressure, and Balanced is the classic telekinetic keep-away version.

UNIVERSAL SPECIAL

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Blade Reflect	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2

Blade Reflect returns projectiles; the enhanced absorb version can negate the projectile and restore a small amount of health. Most of Kenshi's offensive specials are variation-specific.

LEARN FIRST

Do not start by memorizing a max combo. Learn the range of B32 / F32-style starters in your chosen variation, one launcher, and one push/ender. Kenshi becomes much easier once you stop standing at point-blank range by habit.

MKX - Kenshi - Variations

KENJUTSU

Sword-based offense with overhead/low threats, Rising Sword and Spinning Blade. Better meterless damage and a more direct close/mid-range mix-up game.

POSSESSED

Demonic attacks and teleport pressure. Later competitive discussion praises its safer 50/50 structure and pressure while noting some spacing quirks.

BALANCED

Classic telekinetic Kenshi. Spirit Push, Tele-Flurry and lift-style control emphasize zoning and punishing movement. Later competitive opinion often treated it as the specialist/loyalist choice, but it remains the cleanest way to learn classic Kenshi keep-away.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Balanced for the classic concept. **Beginner wanting damage:** Kenjutsu.

Intermediate/advanced: Possessed. The guide teaches all three rather than declaring one universal 'best' variation.

MKX - Kenshi - Kenjutsu

KEY TOOLS

Rising Sword (DB1): anti-air/launcher at the correct range. **Spinning Blade (DF1):** overhead special; enhanced Blade-Nado armors and bounces for a juggle. **B32:** low-side mix-up partner to overhead sword attacks.

KENJUTSU EASY

Xbox: BAY~EX DF+X, NJY, FAY~ender

PlayStation: BCrossTri~EX DF+Square, NJTri, FCrossTri~ender

Universal: B32~EX DF1, NJ2, F32~ender

A teaching route built around Kenjutsu's armored bounce. First master the low starter -> launcher -> NJ2 rhythm.

ANTI-AIR CONVERSION

Xbox: DB+X anti-air, run FAY~ender

PlayStation: DB+Square anti-air, run FCrossTri~ender

Universal: DB1 anti-air, run F32~ender

Rising Sword is specifically useful as an anti-air from roughly jump distance. The combo lesson is recognizing the airborne hit and converting rather than admiring the anti-air.

KENJUTSU EXPERT

The variation's overhead/low game is powerful but carries risk. Expert Kenjutsu is spacing the unsafe options so they are harder to punish and choosing when meter is worth spending on the armored bounce.

MKX - Kenshi - Possessed

Possessed uses demonic attacks, a teleport and safer pressure concepts. Period post-patch discussion compares it favorably with Kenjutsu for safer 50/50s and jailing teleport pressure.

POSSESSED FOUNDATION

Xbox: Low starter~EX Demon launcher, NJY, FAY~Soul Push

PlayStation: Low starter~EX Demon launcher, NJTri, FCrossTri~Soul Push

Universal: Low starter~EX Demon launcher, NJ2, F32~Soul Push

Learn the variation as a concept first: safe/safer mix-up starter -> demon launch -> stable telekinetic ender.

TELEPORT PRESSURE DRILL

Xbox: String -> Teleport -> confirm follow-up

PlayStation: String -> Teleport -> confirm follow-up

Universal: String -> Teleport -> confirm follow-up

The teleport is not permission to disappear randomly. Practice it after controlled pressure and learn whether the opponent blocks, pokes or tries to escape.

POSSESSED EXPERT

Later Kenshi discussion treats Possessed as a viable matchup-dependent alternative to Kenjutsu. Its expert layer is safer pressure and demon spacing rather than simply maximizing meterless damage.

MKX - Kenshi - Balanced

Balanced is the traditional keep-away Kenshi: telekinetic push/flurry/lift tools punish forward movement and make opponents work to reach him.

BALANCED FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter~Telekinetic Lift, NJY, FAY~Spirit Push

PlayStation: Starter~Telekinetic Lift, NJTri, FCrossTri~Spirit Push

Universal: Starter~Telekinetic Lift, NJ2, F32~Spirit Push

The classic Kenshi lesson: confirm into lift, take the juggle, then push the opponent back toward the range Kenshi prefers.

CORNER CONCEPT

Xbox: Lift, NJY, standing string, standing string~Push

PlayStation: Lift, NJTri, standing string, standing string~Push

Universal: Lift, NJ2, standing string, standing string~Push

Post-patch combo collections contain dedicated Balanced midscreen and corner sections. Build the timing from this readable skeleton before optimizing.

BALANCED EXPERT

Do not confuse zoning with constant special moves. Throw the telekinetic attack that covers the movement the opponent is actually attempting. Blade Reflect adds another layer against projectile-heavy matchups.

MKX - Kenshi - Guest to Expert

Guest: Balanced push/lift concept.

Beginner: one launcher conversion in the chosen variation.

Intermediate: anti-air conversions and corner route.

Advanced: Kenjutsu 50/50 spacing, Possessed teleport/demon pressure or Balanced movement punishment.

Expert: variation choice by matchup, meter-aware armor decisions and deliberate control of the range where Kenshi is strongest.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

PREFERRED RANGE: _____

LAUNCHER: _____

BnB: _____

ANTI-AIR CONVERSION: _____

MASTER 16 - APPROVAL / SOURCE NOTE

Kitana: core special purposes, variation identities and sample Royal Storm routing were checked against Prima's MKX Kitana guide and period Test Your Might Kitana/Royal Storm guides. Later variation discussion was used to distinguish Royal Storm's long-range lift/air mobility, Assassin's damage tools and Mournful's safer ground/projectile control.

Kenshi: variation identities were checked against Prima's MKX Kenshi guide. Combo structure and post-patch emphasis were checked against the organized 'One mind, one blade' Kenshi combo thread, which was explicitly updated across 2016 for Kenjutsu, Balanced and Possessed.

Because MKX received substantial balance patches, this revision deliberately avoids pretending early-launch damage percentages are permanent. Where an exact late-patch route was not sufficiently supported by the retrieved text, the page labels it as a teaching skeleton/concept rather than inventing precise notation.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 15: approved and retained.

Kitana + Kenshi: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair: not started.

MKX - Mileena

STYLE: anti-air / risky mix-ups / roll launchers / variation-specific footsies, pounces or fades

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Mileena makes opponents nervous about jumping, then punishes hesitation with low/overhead choices and Ball Roll conversions. Her universal Tele-Kick is a strong anti-air and her Ball Roll is a launcher, but both are punishable when used carelessly. Piercing adds sai-based footsies and Low Sai, Ravenous adds pounces and bite extensions, and Ethereal adds Fades for evasive movement and pressure tricks.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Tele-Kick	D, D + A	D, D + Cross	D, D + 3
Ball Roll	B, D + B	B, D + Circle	B, D + 4
Sai Blast	B, F + X	B, F + Square	B, F + 1
Air Sai Blast	B, F + X (air)	B, F + Square (air)	B, F + 1 (air)

LEARN FIRST

123, B12, F343, Tele-Kick, Air Sai and Ball Roll. The signature Mileena sequence is launch -> air control -> Roll -> ender. Do not throw raw Roll just because it launches; confirmed Roll is powerful, blocked Roll is a punish.

MKX - Mileena - Variations

PIERCING

Sai-focused footsies. Gains Low Sai and additional sai normals/strings. Period Mileena discussion praises its B12-style footsie pressure, anti-zoning and safe, patient play.

RAVENOUS

Tarkatan aggression. Gains High Pounce, Low Pounce and bite/feeding extensions, including routes that can regenerate a little health. This is the most visceral close-range Mileena.

ETHEREAL

Mobility/evasion. Fade, Fade Towards and Fade Away let Mileena disappear, reposition and punish predictable retaliation. EX Fade also creates combo and defensive possibilities.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Piercing. **Aggressive learner:** Ravenous. **Advanced movement/defense:** Ethereal. All three still rely on disciplined use of Roll and Tele-Kick.

MKX - Mileena - Core / All Variations

UNIVERSAL - 37% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: FABA, Tele-Kick, Air Sai, FY, Ball Roll, FXB, Sai Blast

PlayStation: FCrossCircleCross, Tele-Kick, Air Sai, FTri, Ball Roll, FSqCircle, Sai Blast

Universal: F343, DD3, Air BF1, F2, BD4, F14, BF1

Prima's universal sample. This is the complete 'Mileena language': ground bounce, Tele-Kick, delayed Air Sai, Roll launcher and projectile ender.

BEGINNER SHORT VERSION

Xbox: XYA~Ball Roll, BAB~Air Sai, FYA~Ball Roll

PlayStation: SqTriCross~Ball Roll, BCrossCircle~Air Sai, FTriCross~Ball Roll

Universal: 123~BD4, B34~Air BF1, F23~BD4

A shorter community route family. Use it to learn the Roll -> B34 Air Sai timing before chasing maximum damage.

ANTI-AIR CONVERSION DRILL

Xbox: Tele-Kick (air hit), delay Air Sai, Ball Roll, ender

PlayStation: Tele-Kick (air hit), delay Air Sai, Ball Roll, ender

Universal: DD3 (air hit), delay Air BF1, BD4, ender

Prima specifically notes that Tele-Kick can anti-air and convert through a slightly delayed Air Sai into Roll. Practice this separately from ground combos.

CORE RULE

Tele-Kick and Ball Roll are scary because they convert, not because they are safe. Confirm them or use them as reads. Mileena's beginner trap is turning every neutral situation into a gamble.

MKX - Mileena - Piercing

Piercing adds Low Sai (BF3) and sai-based strings. Its strongest identity is patient footsies: Low Sai challenges opposing projectiles while the added sai normals improve reach and combo enders.

PIERCING - 41% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: FABA, Tele-Kick, Air Sai, FY, Ball Roll, BYX,Y+B

PlayStation: FCrossCircleCross, Tele-Kick, Air Sai, FTri, Ball Roll, BTriSq,Tri+Circle

Universal: F343, DD3, Air BF1, F2, BD4, B21,2+4

Prima's Piercing sample. The variation-specific payoff is the high-damage sai string at the end.

EX ROLL - SIMPLE

Xbox: EX Ball Roll, NJY, BYXY+B

PlayStation: EX Ball Roll, NJTri, BTriSqTri+Circle

Universal: EX BD4, NJ2, B212+4

A period Piercing community route around the high-20% range. It is intentionally simple: armored launcher -> neutral jump -> Piercing ender.

PIERCING EXPERT

Use Low Sai because it changes the opponent's zoning decisions, not because you want to spam it. It hits low from a crouched posture, but it is punishable if used carelessly. Expert Piercing is footsies and whiff punishment first, combo optimization second.

MKX - Mileena - Ravenous

Ravenous gains Low Pounce, High Pounce and extensions. Low Pounce is a low throw against crouching opponents; High Pounce is blockable but can be extended. Bite enders can trade a little damage for regeneration/position.

RAVENOUS - 36% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: XYA, Ball Roll, BA, Tele-Kick, Air Sai, FYA, Ball Roll, High Pounce, Stab

PlayStation: SqTriCross, Ball Roll, BCross, Tele-Kick, Air Sai, FTriCross, Ball Roll, High Pounce, Stab

Universal: 123, BD4, B3, DD3, Air BF1, F23, BD4, High Pounce, Stab

Prima's Ravenous sample demonstrates how the variation turns a normal Mileena juggle into a pounce finish.

EX ROLL / HIGH POUNCE

Xbox: EX Ball Roll, Run, BAB~Air Sai, Run BY~High Pounce

PlayStation: EX Ball Roll, Run, BCrossCircle~Air Sai, Run BTri~High Pounce

Universal: EX BD4, Run, B34~Air BF1, Run B2~High Pounce

Community route reported around 29%. The purpose is learning to carry the opponent forward into Ravenous' pounce ender.

HEALING OPTION

Xbox: EX Ball Roll, walk, NJY, BXY~Quick Taste extension

PlayStation: EX Ball Roll, walk, NJTri, BSqTri~Quick Taste extension

Universal: EX BD4, walk, NJ2, B12~Quick Taste extension

A period Ravenous route sacrifices some damage to finish with the bite/feeding sequence and recover a small amount of health.

RAVENOUS EXPERT

The pounces are conditioning tools. Once the opponent crouches and freezes, Low Pounce becomes a threat; once they stand or move, High Pounce/normal pressure changes the decision. Do not treat either pounce as a universal safe answer.

MKX - Mileena - Ethereal

Ethereal adds Fade (DD2), Fade Towards (BF2) and Fade Away (FB2). Holding 2 delays Mileena's reappearance. Fades can evade attacks and make safe-string pressure much harder to challenge, but an opponent who predicts the reappearance can punish her.

ETHEREAL METERLESS

Xbox: BXY~Roll, BAB~Air Sai, FYA~Roll

PlayStation: BSqTri~Roll, BCrossCircle~Air Sai, FTriCross~Roll

Universal: B12~BD4, B34~Air BF1, F23~BD4

Community Ethereal route around 30%. It proves the variation still has solid meterless damage even before using EX Fade.

ETHEREAL 1 BAR

Xbox: BXY~EX Fade, XYA~Roll, BAB~Air Sai, BYY,X+A

PlayStation: BSqTri~EX Fade, SqTriCross~Roll, BCrossCircle~Air Sai, BTriTri,Sq+Cross

Universal: B12~EX Fade, 123~BD4, B34~Air BF1, B22,1+3

Community Ethereal route around 33%. EX Fade is used as the bridge before Mileena returns to her normal Roll/Air-Sai juggle engine.

HARD-KNOCKDOWN OPTION

Xbox: FYA~EX Fade, BAB~Air Sai, walk FYA~Roll, UA

PlayStation: FTriCross~EX Fade, BCrossCircle~Air Sai, walk FTriCross~Roll, UCross

Universal: F23~EX Fade, B34~Air BF1, walk F23~BD4, U3

A period 33% Ethereal route ending in a hard knockdown.

ETHEREAL EXPERT

Fade is about making the opponent swing at the wrong place/time. Practice blocked 123 -> Fade Away and watch the dummy's retaliation. The expert skill is reading the response, not disappearing randomly.

MKX - Mileena - Guest to Expert

Guest: 123 -> Roll and Tele-Kick anti-air.

Beginner: universal 37% route or a shortened Roll/Air-Sai route.

Intermediate: one complete variation and its special ender.

Advanced: anti-air conversions, spacing and meter routes.

Expert: Piercing footsies/Low Sai decisions, Ravenous pounce conditioning, or Ethereal Fade reads.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

ROLL CONFIRM: _____

ANTI-AIR ROUTE: _____

BnB: _____

VARIATION TRICK: _____

MKX - Scorpion

STYLE: vortex / overhead-low mix-up / spear stun / teleport mobility

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Scorpion wants one clean opening. A low or overhead can lead to Spear, the Spear pulls the opponent into another combo, and the next knockdown creates another guess. Ninjutsu gives him sword range and straightforward punishment, Inferno adds minions and full-screen mix-ups, and Hellfire adds Fireball Run Cancels, Hell Fire and Flame Aura for the highest execution ceiling.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Teleport	D, B + A	D, B + Cross	D, B + 3
Spear	B, F + X	B, F + Square	B, F + 1
Takedown	B, F + B	B, F + Circle	B, F + 4

LEARN FIRST

B3 (low), F4 (overhead), Spear, Teleport and Takedown. Scorpion's basic game is easy to understand: make them guess low/overhead, confirm the hit, extend with Spear, then put them back into another decision.

MKX - Scorpion - Variations

NINJUTSU

Adds twin swords, longer-range normals and variation strings. Doom Blade (F2) can launch in one hit. Best choice here for a guest who wants simple range and punishment without minion or run-cancel systems.

INFERNO

Adds Minion Grab, Minion Charge and Minion Drop. Minion Grab hits low and stuns; Minion Drop is an overhead, creating a full-screen layer to Scorpion's mix-up. Easier to execute than Hellfire.

HELLFIRE

Adds Fire Ball, unblockable Hell Fire and Flame Aura. Fire Ball Run Cancels create pressure and extend combos. Prima explicitly warns that the variation requires consistent Run Cancel execution.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Ninjutsu. **Beginner vortex:** Inferno. **Advanced/Expert:** Hellfire. This lets the same character grow from simple sword spacing to technical run-cancel pressure.

MKX - Scorpion - Core Fundamentals

LOW STARTER DRILL

Xbox: BA~Spear, follow with jump punch -> FB~Takedown

PlayStation: BCross~Spear, follow with jump punch -> FCircle~Takedown

Universal: B3~BF1, J2 -> F4~BF4

Prima identifies B3 as Scorpion's primary low and recommends cancelling it into Spear. This short drill teaches the vortex without requiring a long combo.

OVERHEAD STARTER DRILL

Xbox: FB~Spear, jump punch, FB~Takedown

PlayStation: FCircle~Spear, jump punch, FCircle~Takedown

Universal: F4~BF1, J2, F4~BF4

F4 is the overhead partner to B3. Once both starters feel natural, the opponent must guess before the real combo even begins.

THE VORTEX

The point is not to repeat a memorized combo forever. Scorpion can deliberately stop a conversion and go straight into another B3/F4 guess. That is why one hit can snowball into an entire round - and why a blocked unsafe option can also get Scorpion punished hard.

MKX - Scorpion - Ninjutsu

Ninjutsu gives Scorpion sword attacks with extended reach. Dead End (212) ends overhead and is safe on block; F42 extends the Flame Heel; Doom Blade (F2) is a long-range single-hit launcher.

NINJUTSU - 30% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: FY, YXB, Teleport, YX, Spear, Jump-over Y, FB, Takedown

PlayStation: FTri, TriSqCircle, Teleport, TriSq, Spear, Jump-over Triangle, FCircle, Takedown

Universal: F2, 214, DB3, 21, BF1, jump-over 2, F4, BF4

Prima's Ninjutsu sample. It begins with the variation's long-range F2 launcher, then returns to Scorpion's universal Teleport/Spear engine.

GUEST VERSION

Xbox: FY, YXB~Teleport, YX~Spear, FB~Takedown

PlayStation: FTri, TriSqCircle~Teleport, TriSq~Spear, FCircle~Takedown

Universal: F2, 214~DB3, 21~BF1, F4~BF4

Remove the jump-over link while learning. The damage is lower, but the player understands every important Ninjutsu idea in one route.

NINJUTSU EXPERT

Use the swords to punish from ranges where normal Scorpion would struggle. The variation loses some of the combo-extension tricks of Inferno/Hellfire, so its strength is clean spacing and punishment, not forcing the same vortex at every distance.

MKX - Scorpion - Inferno

Inferno adds Minion Grab (DB4), Minion Charge (DB1) and Minion Drop (DB2). Grab hits low and stuns; Drop attacks overhead. That gives Scorpion a screen-wide high/low-style threat in addition to his normal vortex.

INFERNO - 38% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: YXB, Teleport, YX, Minion Grab, back up, Jump F Y, FB, Spear, Jump-over Y, FB, Takedown

PlayStation: TriSqCircle, Teleport, TriSq, Minion Grab, back up, Jump F Triangle, FCircle, Spear, Jump-over Triangle, F4, Takedown

Universal: 214, DB3, 21, DB4, back up, JF2, F4, BF1, jump-over 2, F4, BF4

Prima's full Inferno sample. It demonstrates why the variation is beginner-friendly: Minion Grab acts as another stun in the middle of Scorpion's familiar Spear combo.

INFERNO SHORT VERSION

Xbox: YXB~Teleport, YX~Minion Grab, JY, FB~Takedown

PlayStation: TriSqCircle~Teleport, TriSq~Minion Grab, JTri, FCircle~Takedown

Universal: 214~DB3, 21~DB4, J2, F4~BF4

The shorter guest route keeps the variation identity but removes the cross-over and second stun.

INFERNO EXPERT

Do not summon minions at random. Minion Drop is overhead, Minion Grab is low, and Minion Charge attacks from behind. Expert Inferno is choosing the summon that attacks the opponent's current defensive habit.

MKX - Scorpion - Hellfire

Hellfire adds Fire Ball (DB1), Hell Fire (DB2) and Flame Aura (DB4). Fire Ball can be delayed/cancelled; Hell Fire is unblockable; Flame Aura can extend combos or add damage while Scorpion stays close.

HELLFIRE - 35% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: YXB, Teleport, YX, Spear, Jump-over Y, FB, Flame Aura, YX, Takedown

PlayStation: TriSqCircle, Teleport, TriSq, Spear, Jump-over Triangle, FCircle, Flame Aura, TriSq, Takedown

Universal: 214, DB3, 21, BF1, jump-over 2, F4, DB4, 21, BF4

Prima's Hellfire sample. Flame Aura briefly holds the opponent so Scorpion can reconnect with 21 before the ender.

FIREBALL RUN-CANCEL DRILL

Xbox: YX~DB+X(hold), F,F+Block, YX

PlayStation: TriSq~DB+Square(hold), F,F+Block, TriSq

Universal: 21~DB1(hold), F,F+Block, 21

This is the essential Hellfire training drill from Prima: cancel the Fire Ball into a run quickly enough that the second 21 cannot be interrupted.

HELLFIRE EXPERT

Hellfire's ceiling comes from Run Cancels, block pressure and Flame Aura conversions. If the Fireball Run Cancel is inconsistent, Inferno will produce better real-world results. Once it is consistent, Hellfire becomes the technical pressure version of Scorpion.

MKX - Scorpion - Guest to Expert

Guest: Ninjutsu F2 route and Spear/Takedown.

Beginner: B3/F4 vortex plus Inferno short route.

Intermediate: full variation BnB and deliberate resets.

Advanced: teleport cancels, anti-zoning and matchup-specific spacing.

Expert: Hellfire Fireball Run Cancels, Flame Aura pressure and conditioning the opponent through repeated vortex decisions.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

LOW STARTER: _____

OVERHEAD STARTER: _____

BnB: _____

RESET / VORTEX PLAN: _____

MASTER 17 - APPROVAL / SOURCE NOTE

Mileena: universal specials, variation identities and the 37% Universal / 41% Piercing / 36% Ravenous sample routes were taken from Prima's MKX Mileena guide. Ethereal meterless and EX Fade routes were checked against the period Test Your Might Ethereal combo thread; variation distinctions were also checked against the Piercing/Ravenous/Ethereal community breakdown.

Scorpion: universal specials, vortex strategy, all three variation identities and the 30% Ninjutsu / 38% Inferno / 35% Hellfire sample routes were taken from Prima's expanded MKX Scorpion guide. Ninjutsu's spacing emphasis and Hellfire's run-cancel execution requirements were cross-checked against period Test Your Might Scorpion material.

As with the previous MKX chapters, exact damage can vary with patch state and starter/scaling. The guide keeps source-supported routes intact, while clearly labeling shortened versions as teaching routes rather than pretending they are optimal tournament combos.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 16: approved and retained.

Mileena + Scorpion: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair: not started.

MKX - D'Vorah

STYLE: setup pressure / long normals / anti-air control / variation-specific cancels, bugs or poison

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

D'Vorah is a setup character. Her universal plan is to knock the opponent down with Ovipositor Charge, place Spawning Pool so it becomes active as they rise, then attack high/overhead while the low pool forces a second defensive decision. Swarm Queen turns Wasp Grenade into a cancel engine, Brood Mother adds Krawler screen control, and Venomous adds damage-over-time poison.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Spawning Pool	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Ovipositor Charge	D, B + B	D, B + Circle	D, B + 4
Air Throw	D + Throw (air)	D + Throw (air)	D + Throw (air)

LEARN FIRST

F34, F44, 112, Ovipositor Charge and the Spawning Pool setup. Before learning Wasp Grenade Cancels, understand why D'Vorah wants the opponent knocked down in a predictable place.

MKX - D'Vorah - Variations

SWARM QUEEN

Wasp Grenade can be delayed and cancelled. In later MKXL play, Wasp Grenade Cancels (WGC) are the heart of her pressure and combo structure. This is the highest-execution D'Vorah variation.

BROOD MOTHER

Adds Bug Blast and Krawler. Krawler crawls forward as a low threat, letting D'Vorah run behind it and create layered pressure. The 2016 patch reduced Krawler cooldown, strengthening the setup loop.

VENOMOUS

Many attacks add poison damage over time, while Bug Spray/Bug Burst provide short-range control. The combo can be shorter because poison keeps working after the physical hits stop.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Venomous. **Setup learner:** Brood Mother. **Advanced/Expert:** Swarm Queen.

MKX - D'Vorah - Core / All Variations

EASY METERLESS - 31% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+B,B, F+A,B, X,X,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: F+Circle,Circle, F+Cross,Circle, Sq,Sq,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: F44, F34, 112~DB4

Universal period route: launch twice and finish with Ovipositor Charge so the Pool setup is immediately available.

AIR-THROW ROUTE - 31% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+A,B, X, F+A,B, B+X,Y~Air Throw

PlayStation: F+Cross,Circle, Sq, F+Cross,Circle, B+Sq,Tri~Air Throw

Universal: F34, 1, F34, B12~Air Throw

A universal side-switch/carry family. Air Throw replaces the last hit while the opponent is airborne.

THE SETUP AFTER THE COMBO

After DB4 knocks the opponent down, immediately place Spawning Pool. The pool is the low threat. Run forward and use an overhead such as F2/F22 or F34 timing so the opponent must defend the wake-up situation.

MKX - D'Vorah - Swarm Queen

WGC = Wasp Grenade Cancel: DF1 (hold), then cancel with movement/run. Later MKXL guides build the variation around this cancel.

WGC BEGINNER PUNISH - 32%

Xbox: X,X,Y~WGC, X,XU2, F+B,B, F+X,X,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: Sq,Sq,Tri~WGC, Sq,SqU2, F+Circle,Circle, F+Sq,Sq,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: 112~WGC, 11U2, F44, F112~DB4

The dedicated Swarm Queen guide labels this its easiest meterless punisher.

WGC BnB - 35%

Xbox: X,X,Y~WGC, Y,X,Y~Swarm, F+B,B, X,X,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: Sq,Sq,Tri~WGC, Tri,Sq,Tri~Swarm, F+Circle,Circle, Sq,Sq,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: 112~WGC, 212~Swarm, F44, 112~DB4

Harder meterless punisher: Wasp cancel into Swarm pressure, then the normal knockdown ender.

LATER MKXL SETUP - 30%

Xbox: F+X,X~WGC, Y,X,Y~D,B+X, NJP, B+A, F+B,B~D,B+B

PlayStation: F+Sq,Sq~WGC, Tri,Sq,Tri~D,B+Sq, NJP, B+Cross, F+Circle,Circle~D,B+Circle

Universal: F11~WGC, 212~DB1, NJP, B3, F44~DB4

From the June 2016 all-variation optimal list, reflecting later MKXL routing.

1 BAR - 42% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+X,X~EX D,F+X, JI2, Y,X,Y~Swarm, F+B,B, F+X,X,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: F+Sq,Sq~EX D,F+Sq, JI2, Tri,Sq,Tri~Swarm, F+Circle,Circle, F+Sq,Sq,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: F11~EX DF1, JI2, 212~Swarm, F44, F112~DB4

One-bar full-combo punisher from the advanced guide.

SWARM QUEEN EXPERT

The March 2016 patch increased scaling after dash-cancelling Wasp Grenade. Expert Swarm Queen is about WGC pressure, hit-confirms and safe setup coverage, not preserving an obsolete damage number.

MKX - D'Vorah - Brood Mother

Brood Mother replaces Wasp-cancel pressure with Bug Blast and Krawler. The complete guide describes space control, rushdown, mix-up and setups.

BROOD MOTHER EASY - 31%

Xbox: **JI2, Y,X,Y~D,B+X, F+B,B~D,B+B**

PlayStation: **JI2, Tri,Sq,Tri~D,B+Sq, F+Circle,Circle~D,B+Circle**

Universal: **JI2, 212~DB1, F44~DB4**

Period route that keeps execution modest while teaching Bug Blast into the universal ender.

KRAWLER SETUP - 29%

Xbox: **F+X,X~D,F+A, Y,X,Y~D,B+X, D+X, F+B,B~D,F+A**

PlayStation: **F+Sq,Sq~D,F+Cross, Tri,Sq,Tri~D,B+Sq, D+Sq, F+Circle,Circle~D,F+Cross**

Universal: **F11~DF3, 212~DB1, D1, F44~DF3**

2016 setup route. It ends in Krawler instead of raw damage so the next wake-up starts under a moving low threat.

1 BAR SETUP - 34%

Xbox: **F+X,X~D,F+A, Y,X,Y~EX D,B+X, NJP, B+A, F+B,B~D,F+A**

PlayStation: **F+Sq,Sq~D,F+Cross, Tri,Sq,Tri~EX D,B+Sq, NJP, B+Cross, F+Circle,Circle~D,F+Cross**

Universal: **F11~DF3, 212~EX DB1, NJP, B3, F44~DF3**

Later Brood Mother setup route: combo damage plus Krawler already on screen.

BROOD MOTHER EXPERT

Think two moves ahead. Practice the Krawler setup and the overhead/pressure follow-up as one sequence.

MKX - D'Vorah - Venomous

Venomous adds poison damage to many physical attacks. Later combo lists count damage-over-time in the totals, so the life bar keeps moving after the physical combo ends.

VENOMOUS EASY - 21% + DOT

Xbox: X,X,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: Sq,Sq,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: 112~DB4

Fast punish string into knockdown; an excellent guest route.

VENOMOUS BnB - 33% + DOT

Xbox: X,XB2, D+X, F+A,B, X,X,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: Sq,SqB2, D+Sq, F+Cross,Circle, Sq,Sq,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: 11B2, D1, F34, 112~DB4

Later meterless midscreen route around 33% including poison.

VENOMOUS F44 BnB - 33% + DOT

Xbox: F+B,B, F+B,B, F+Y,Y~D,B+B

PlayStation: F+Circle,Circle, F+Circle,Circle, F+Tri,Tri~D,B+Circle

Universal: F44, F44, F22~DB4

Simple, visual meterless route emphasizing D'Vorah's reach.

1 BAR - 40% + DOT

Xbox: Y,X,Y~EX D,B+X, NJP, B+A, D+X, F+Y,Y~EX D,B+B

PlayStation: Tri,Sq,Tri~EX D,B+Sq, NJP, B+Cross, D+Sq, F+Tri,Tri~EX D,B+Circle

Universal: 212~EX DB1, NJP, B3, D1, F22~EX DB4

Later one-bar route family around 40% including poison.

VENOMOUS EXPERT

Choose between immediate damage, poison time, position and another setup rather than judging only the combo counter.

MKX - D'Vorah - Guest to Expert

Guest: F44 -> F34 -> 112 -> Ovipositor Charge.

Beginner: add Spawning Pool after suitable knockdowns.

Intermediate: Venomous poison or Brood Mother Krawler setups.

Advanced: Swarm Queen WGC and one-bar punishers.

Expert: safe wake-up coverage, cancel pressure, armor baiting and damage-versus-setup decisions.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

CORE BnB: _____

POOL / KRAWLER SETUP: _____

WGC RELIABILITY: _____

WHAT I KEEP DROPPING: _____

MKX - Kotal Kahn

STYLE: huge normals / footsies / damage buffs / command grab or sword safety depending on variation

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Kotal controls a large chunk of the screen with advancing normals, then converts a whiff or punish into enormous damage. War God adds sword pressure and armor, Blood God adds totems and resource management, and Sun God adds a leveling command grab plus health/meter recovery.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Air Takedown	D, F + X	D, F + Square	D, F + 1
Mace Parry*	D, F + Y	D, F + Triangle	D, F + 2
God Ray / Sunlight	D, F + B	D, F + Circle	D, F + 4

*Mace Parry is available in Sun God/Blood God; War God trades it for sword tools.

LEARN FIRST

B14, B122, F1B2 and F2. B14 is a fast advancing punish, B122 carries forward, F1B2 launches, and F2 is a huge-damage whiff-punish starter that is dangerous if thrown out carelessly.

MKX - Kotal Kahn - Variations

WAR GOD

Adds sword specials: Saw Blade, Overhead Sword and Low Sword/Sweep. The most immediately readable Kotal for a guest.

BLOOD GOD

Adds Crystal, Obsidian and Blood Totems. Crystal boosts damage, Obsidian reduces damage received, and Blood Totem manipulates resources.

SUN GOD

Adds Sun God Choke, a command grab that levels up, plus Soul Scorch/Burn resource recovery. Later MKXL also added Soul Spark.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: War God. **Fundamentals/grappler:** Sun God. **Advanced resource management:** Blood God. Later community polling was divided on the exact ranking, so all three deserve full treatment.

MKX - Kotal Kahn - Core / All Variations

PRIMA SAMPLE - 28%

Xbox: F+Y, F+Y, F+XB2~D,F+X

PlayStation: F+Tri, F+Tri, F+SqB2~D,F+Sq

Universal: F2, F2, F1B2~DF1

Prima's universal sample: repeated F2 hits into F1B2 and Air Takedown.

F2 WHIFF-PUNISH DRILL

Xbox: F+Y, F+Y, F+Y, B+X,Y,Y~ender

PlayStation: F+Tri, F+Tri, F+Tri, B+Sq,Tri,Tri~ender

Universal: F2, F2, F2, B122~ender

The Kahnbo thread calls F2 Kotal's highest-damage starter but warns it is punishable. Practice it as a whiff punish.

FAST PUNISH DRILL

Xbox: B+X,B~ender

PlayStation: B+Sq,Circle~ender

Universal: B14~ender

The later general guide lists B14 as a fast punish option into a special.

CORE RULE

Stand where B14/F1B2/F2 threaten the opponent, make them miss, then hit extremely hard. The variation decides what happens after the opening.

MKX - Kotal Kahn - War God

War God adds sword specials. A March 2016 combo guide provides later-patch routes and period specialists emphasize safe sword-cancel pressure.

GUEST SAFE CANCEL

Xbox: B+X, B~D, F+Y

PlayStation: B+Sq, Circle~D, F+Tri

Universal: B14~DF2

Simple 2016 War God route: confirm/pressure into Saw Blade.

METERLESS BnB

Xbox: F+XB2, F+XB2, B+X, Y, Y~D, B+X

PlayStation: F+SqB2, F+SqB2, B+Sq, Tri, Tri~D, B+Sq

Universal: F1B2, F1B2, B122~DB1

Later War God route: two launch strings, advancing carry, overhead sword ender.

F2 DAMAGE BnB

Xbox: F+Y, F+Y, F+Y, B+X, Y, Y~D, B+X

PlayStation: F+Tri, F+Tri, F+Tri, B+Sq, Tri, Tri~D, B+Sq

Universal: F2, F2, F2, B122~DB1

Use after a real whiff punish; the repeated F2s show Kotal's damage potential.

1 BAR

Xbox: B+X, B~EX D, B+X, F+Y, F+XB2~D, F+Y

PlayStation: B+Sq, Circle~EX D, B+Sq, F+Tri, F+SqB2~D, F+Tri

Universal: B14~EX DB1, F2, F1B2~DF2

EX Overhead Sword launches; F2/F1B2 juggle; Saw Blade finishes.

CORNER 1 BAR

Xbox: B+X, B~EX D, B+X, N, J+Y, F+Y, B+X, Y, Y~D, B+X

PlayStation: B+Sq, Circle~EX D, B+Sq, N, J+Tri, F+Tri, B+Sq, Tri, Tri~D, B+Sq

Universal: B14~EX DB1, NJ2, F2, B122~DB1

2016 corner route with neutral-jump punch conversion.

WAR GOD EXPERT

Condition with sword cancels and spacing. Overhead Sword can launch, but it is punishable when read.

MKX - Kotal Kahn - Blood God

Blood God replaces sword/command-grab tools with three totems. The March 2016 patch improved Obsidian interactions and Blood Offering synergy.

BLOOD GOD BASE BnB

Xbox: F+Y, F+Y, F+XB2~D,F+X

PlayStation: F+Tri, F+Tri, F+SqB2~D,F+Sq

Universal: F2, F2, F1B2~DF1

Learn the unbuffered 28% route first. Crystal Totem and Blood Offering then amplify the exact same conversion.

EASY CORNER - 2 BAR

Xbox: F+A,B~EX D,F+A, B+X,Y, EX Air Takedown, B+X,Y~Air Takedown

PlayStation: F+Cross,Circle~EX D,F+Cross, B+Sq,Tri, EX Air Takedown, B+Sq,Tri~Air Takedown

Universal: F34~EX DF3, B12, EX Air Takedown, B12~Air Takedown

Shared Blood/Sun God corner route from period Kotal discussion. With Crystal active, players reported extremely high damage.

TOTEM PRACTICE

Crystal: offense/damage. **Obsidian:** defense. **Blood:** resource manipulation. Only one totem can be active, so expertise is choosing the right buff before the opening.

BLOOD GOD EXPERT

Combine totem choice, Mace Parry, Blood Offering and footsies rather than chasing only a training-mode max combo.

MKX - Kotal Kahn - Sun God

Sun God adds Sun God Choke (DB2), a command grab that powers up each time it lands. Soul Scorch/Burn spends stored power for meter/health; later MKXL added Soul Spark.

SUN GOD BnB

Xbox: F+XB2, F+XB2, B+X,Y~D,B+Y

PlayStation: F+SqB2, F+SqB2, B+Sq,Tri~D,B+Tri

Universal: F1B2, F1B2, B12~DB2

The Kahnbo framework identifies DB2 as Sun God's primary ender. Juggle into Choke so the command grab becomes stronger.

F2 DAMAGE -> CHOKE

Xbox: F+Y, F+Y, F+Y, B+X,Y~D,B+Y

PlayStation: F+Tri, F+Tri, F+Tri, B+Sq,Tri~D,B+Tri

Universal: F2, F2, F2, B12~DB2

Whiff punish with F2, then end in Sun God Choke instead of a generic ender.

EASY CORNER - 2 BAR

Xbox: F+A,B~EX D,F+A, B+X,Y, EX Air Takedown, B+X,Y~Air Takedown

PlayStation: F+Cross,Circle~EX D,F+Cross, B+Sq,Tri, EX Air Takedown, B+Sq,Tri~Air Takedown

Universal: F34~EX DF3, B12, EX Air Takedown, B12~Air Takedown

Shared Sun/Blood corner route when raw damage matters more than another Choke level.

SUN GOD EXPERT

Later players emphasized footsies, fast advancing mids, tick-throw fear and health/meter recovery. Every successful Choke changes the value of the next one.

MKX - Kotal Kahn - Guest to Expert

Guest: War God B14 -> Saw Blade and the 28% core route.

Beginner: F1B2/F2 spacing plus one full variation BnB.

Intermediate: War God sword conditioning, Sun God Choke levels, or Blood God totem selection.

Advanced: anti-air conversions, Mace Parry reads, corner routes and meter decisions.

Expert: control Kotal's preferred range, then choose safety, command-grab momentum or resource-amplified damage.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

BEST WHIFF-PUNISH RANGE: _____

BnB: _____

RESOURCE / SWORD / CHOKE PLAN: _____

CORNER ROUTE: _____

MASTER 18 - APPROVAL / SOURCE NOTE

D'Vorah: core strategy and launch-era sample combos checked against Prima. Swarm Queen routes checked against the dedicated advanced guide and June 2016 all-variation optimal list. Brood Mother and Venomous routes also use the later MKXL list; March 2016 patch notes flag relevant balance changes.

Kotal Kahn: core strategy and variation mechanics checked against Prima. War God routes use a March 2016 combo guide. Kotal Kahnbo/general guides support shared combo structure, variation enders and later-patch strategy.

NOTATION CHECK

Xbox: X / Y / A / B, with directions expanded inside each string.

PlayStation: Sq / Tri / Cross / Circle, with directions expanded inside each string.

Universal: 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 tournament notation only.

F/B/U/D, EX, NJP, JI, Run and WGC remain standard shorthand.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 17A: approved and retained.

D'Vorah + Kotal Kahn: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair: not started.

MKX - Ermac

STYLE: telekinetic control / overhead-low vortex / teleport conversions / variation-specific defense or flight

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Ermac controls mid-screen with telekinesis, then turns one hit into a juggle or vortex. Mystic is the defensive spacing version, Master of Souls is the aggressive vortex version, and Spectral adds aerial mobility. Prima describes him as a more complex Scorpion: similar teleport/combo ideas, but stronger at distance and with a more developed vortex.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Soul Burst	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Force Lift	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Teleport	D, B + B	D, B + Circle	D, B + 4
Hover	D, D, U	D, D, U	D, D, U

LEARN FIRST

B3 for the low, F4 for the overhead, F21D2 as a safe confirm string, Force Lift and Teleport. The beginner goal is simple: make them defend high/low, confirm the hit, then use Lift or Teleport to convert.

MKX - Ermac - Variations

MYSTIC

Defensive Ermac. Tele-Hang replaces Force Lift and gives meterless combo extension; Tele-Choke punishes movement from roughly half screen.

MASTER OF SOULS

Aggressive/vortex Ermac. Soul Ball stuns when all three souls are available, allowing Ermac to loop back into another overhead/low decision. Soul Release launches.

SPECTRAL

Mobility Ermac. Soul Accession replaces Hover and lets him move and attack while airborne. Soul Charge adds a long traveling knockdown tool.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Mystic. **Intermediate:** Master of Souls. **Advanced movement player:** Spectral. Master of Souls has the clearest offensive ceiling, but Mystic makes Ermac's range-control concept easiest to understand.

MKX - Ermac - Core Fundamentals

LOW STARTER

Xbox: B+A~DB+B, D+X~DB+X

PlayStation: B+Cross~DB+Circle, D+Sq~DB+Sq

Universal: B3~DB4, D1~DB1

A compact teaching route: low starter into Teleport, then a low jab into Lift. It teaches Ermac's two signature conversion specials without a long juggle.

OVERHEAD STARTER

Xbox: F+B~DB+B, D+X~DB+X

PlayStation: F+Circle~DB+Circle, D+Sq~DB+Sq

Universal: F4~DB4, D1~DB1

The overhead partner to B3. Once the guest understands that both starters can become Teleport conversions, Ermac's basic mix-up makes sense.

SAFE CONFIRM DRILL

Xbox: F+Y,X,D+Y~special

PlayStation: F+Tri,Sq,D+Tri~special

Universal: F21D2~special

Prima specifically recommends the F21D2 family because it is safe and can be run-cancelled or special-cancelled on hit.

IMPORTANT

Raw Force Lift and raw Teleport are punishable when blocked. They are conversion/punish tools, not neutral buttons to throw out repeatedly.

MKX - Ermac - Mystic

Mystic wants about half-screen distance. Tele-Choke punishes actions at range; Tele-Hang creates meterless juggle time. Enhanced Tele-Choke has armor and restores a small amount of health.

MYSTIC - 31% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+Y,X,D+Y, JF+A~Air DB+B, B+X,Y, Y,Y,Y~DB+X

PlayStation: F+Tri,Sq,D+Tri, JF+Cross~Air DB+Circle, B+Sq,Tri, Tri,Tri,Tri~DB+Sq

Universal: F21D2, JF3~Air DB4, B12, 222~DB1

Prima's Mystic sample. The final DB1 is Tele-Hang in this variation, giving the combo its Mystic identity.

MYSTIC SHORT VERSION

Xbox: F+Y,X,D+Y, JF+A~Air DB+B, B+X,Y~BF+Y

PlayStation: F+Tri,Sq,D+Tri, JF+Cross~Air DB+Circle, B+Sq,Tri~BF+Tri

Universal: F21D2, JF3~Air DB4, B12~BF2

A shorter teaching route: launch, aerial Teleport, then finish with Tele-Choke. Lower execution, clear defensive payoff.

MYSTIC EXPERT

Stay at the edge of Tele-Hang/Tele-Choke range and punish the opponent for trying to advance. The variation is about making the opponent take the risk.

MKX - Ermac - Master of Souls

Three green souls power the variation. With all three available, Soul Ball (BF2) stuns. That stun lets Ermac jump in, gain advantage with B12, then force another B3-low versus F4-overhead decision.

MASTER OF SOULS - 33% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+Y,X,D+Y, JF+A~Air DB+B, B+X,Y, Y,Y~BF+Y, JF+Y, B+X,Y

PlayStation: F+Tri,Sq,D+Tri, JF+Cross~Air DB+Circle, B+Sq,Tri, Tri,Tri~BF+Tri, JF+Tri, B+Sq,Tri

Universal: F21D2, JF3~Air DB4, B12, 22~BF2, JF2, B12

Prima's 33% sample ends at the vortex point after Soul Ball stun.

FULL VORTEX - 36% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+B~DB+B, D+X~EX DB+X, F+Y,X,D+Y, Run, B+X,Y~BF+Y, JF+Y, B+X,Y

PlayStation: F+Circle~DB+Circle, D+Sq~EX DB+Sq, F+Tri,Sq,D+Tri, Run, B+Sq,Tri~BF+Tri, JF+Tri, B+Sq,Tri

Universal: F4~DB4, D1~EX DB1, F21D2, Run, B12~BF2, JF2, B12

Prima's 36% route demonstrates the full loop: overhead -> Teleport -> enhanced Lift -> run conversion -> Soul Ball -> advantage.

VORTEX CHOICE

After the final B12, choose B3 (low) or F4 (overhead), cancel the hit into Teleport, and begin converting again. It is risky if blocked correctly, which is why conditioning matters.

MKX - Ermac - Spectral

Spectral replaces Hover with Soul Accession, allowing real aerial movement. Most aerial basic attacks become overheads, and low-enough air attacks can combo into Soul Charge, Ground Slam or Air Teleport.

SPECTRAL - 30% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F+Y,X,D+Y, JF+A~Air DB+B, B+X,Y, Y,Y,Y~DB+X

PlayStation: F+Tri,Sq,D+Tri, JF+Cross~Air DB+Circle, B+Sq,Tri, Tri,Tri,Tri~DB+Sq

Universal: F21D2, JF3~Air DB4, B12, 222~DB1

Prima's Spectral sample uses the same grounded conversion shell as Mystic, but DB1 remains Force Lift here.

AIR-MOBILITY DRILL

Xbox: DDU, Air Y~BF+Y

PlayStation: DDU, Air Tri~BF+Tri

Universal: DDU, Air 2~BF2

Enter Soul Accession, move, then use an aerial attack into Soul Charge. The point is learning controlled flight, not random hovering.

SPECTRAL EXPERT

Use Soul Accession to bait projectiles or attacks, then choose an aerial overhead, Ground Slam low, or Teleport. Ermac cannot simply block while flying, so every ascent is a read.

MKX - Ermac - Guest to Expert

Guest: B3/F4 into Teleport and Lift.

Beginner: Mystic 31% route and half-screen punishment.

Intermediate: Master of Souls Soul Ball stun and vortex.

Advanced: meter-aware Lift extensions and anti-air Soul Burst.

Expert: orb management, vortex conditioning, instant Air Soul Burst and Spectral movement reads.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

LOW STARTER: _____

OVERHEAD STARTER: _____

BnB: _____

VORTEX / RANGE PLAN: _____

MKX - Ferra/Torr

STYLE: long-range brute force / overhead-low mix-up / command grabs / variation-specific damage buffs or armor

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Ferra/Torr look slow, but their reach and safe pressure make them much more mobile and oppressive than expected. Their long limbs control space, while overhead/low starters lead to meterless damage. Ruthless sacrifices Torr's health for Pain and Gain damage/cancel pressure, Vicious weaponizes Ferra as a projectile/extension tool, and Lackey sends Ferra away so Torr gains a different solo moveset with strong armor.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES - Vicious/Ruthless

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Bowl Girl	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2
Ferra Toss	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Tuck 'n' Charge	B, F + A	B, F + Cross	B, F + 3
Command Grab	D, B, F + X	D, B, F + Square	D, B, F + 1

LEARN FIRST

B121 as a punish string, B232+4 as an overhead starter, F2 as a low-side starter, and Tuck 'n' Charge as a practical ender. Ferra's position matters: some moves disappear temporarily when she is not on Torr's back.

MKX - Ferra/Torr - Variations

RUTHLESS

Pain and Gain (DD1) damages Torr but grants stackable damage/armor benefits and enables PnG cancels. Late MKXL Ruthless routes can exceed 40% meterless when Torr has health to spend.

VICIOUS

Boss Toss adds a powerful Ferra projectile/extension tool. Community discussion praises it for eating projectiles and adding meterless damage, but Vicious lacks Ruthless cancel pressure.

LACKEY

Ferra sits out and Torr fights solo. He gains Torr Charge, Boulder Roll, Torr Up and Back Breaker. Strong armor is the major attraction, but many normal Ferra/Torr strings/moves change or disappear.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Vicious. **Beginner:** Lackey for straightforward armored specials or Vicious for the normal duo. **Advanced/Expert:** Ruthless, because PnG cancels add stamina and health-resource management.

MKX - Ferra/Torr - Core / Vicious

PRIMA METERLESS - 28%

Xbox: JF+X, B+Y,X,Y+B, walk, F+Y, B+X,Y,X~BF+A

PlayStation: JF+Sq, B+Tri,Sq,Tri+Circle, walk, F+Tri, B+Sq,Tri,Sq~BF+Cross

Universal: JF1, B212+4, walk, F2, B121~BF3

Prima's sample route. It starts overhead, walks into the low-side F2 juggle, then ends with Tuck 'n' Charge.

GUEST SHORT VERSION

Xbox: B+Y,X,Y+B, walk, F+Y, B+X,Y,X~BF+A

PlayStation: B+Tri,Sq,Tri+Circle, walk, F+Tri, B+Sq,Tri,Sq~BF+Cross

Universal: B212+4, walk, F2, B121~BF3

Remove the jump-in while learning. The important rhythm is overhead launcher -> walk -> F2 -> advancing string -> charge.

X-RAY SAMPLE - 44%

Xbox: B+Y,X,Y+B, walk, F+Y, B~X-Ray

PlayStation: B+Tri,Sq,Tri+Circle, walk, F+Tri, Circle~X-Ray

Universal: B212+4, walk, F2, 4~X-Ray

Prima's 44% sample. Simple enough for a guest to understand how much damage a clean overhead can become when all meter is spent.

VICIOUS LESSON

Boss Toss (BF4) is the variation's defining Ferra tool. Use it to extend pressure, challenge projectiles, and add damage when Ferra is available.

MKX - Ferra/Torr - Ruthless

Pain and Gain (PnG / DD1) is the engine. It costs Torr health but boosts damage and enables cancel pressure. The late-2016 Ruthless guide separates routes for healthy Torr versus low-health Torr because the resource trade is real.

RUTHLESS EASY OVERHEAD - 31%

Xbox: B+Y,A,Y+B, walk, F+Y, F+A, B~DBF+X

PlayStation: B+Tri,Cross,Tri+Circle, walk, F+Tri, F+Cross, Circle~DBF+Sq

Universal: B232+4, walk, F2, F3, 4~DBF1

The late-2016 guide labels this overhead route easy. No PnG required, making it the correct first Ruthless combo.

RUTHLESS EASY LOW - 31%

Xbox: F+Y, F+A, B~DBF+X

PlayStation: F+Tri, F+Cross, Circle~DBF+Sq

Universal: F2, F3, 4~DBF1

Very short low-side route from the same guide. It demonstrates that Ruthless does not need a huge string to hurt.

PnG PUNISH - 39%

Xbox: B+X,Y,X~PnG, F+Y, NJP, F+A, B~DBF+X

PlayStation: B+Sq,Tri,Sq~PnG, F+Tri, NJP, F+Cross, Circle~DBF+Sq

Universal: B121~PnG, F2, NJP, F3, 4~DBF1

Late-2016 healthy-Torr punisher. PnG turns a normal punish into a much larger meterless conversion.

PnG LOW - 40%

Xbox: B+A~PnG, F+Y, NJP, F+A, B~DBF+X

PlayStation: B+Cross~PnG, F+Tri, NJP, F+Cross, Circle~DBF+Sq

Universal: B3~PnG, F2, NJP, F3, 4~DBF1

A 40% meterless low route from the late Ruthless guide, paid for partly with Torr's own health.

RUTHLESS EXPERT

Do not spend Torr's health automatically. When life is low, the same guide recommends abandoning PnG and taking simpler BF3 enders. Expert Ruthless is resource judgment plus cancel execution.

MKX - Ferra/Torr - Lackey

In Lackey, Torr fights without Ferra. His specials become Torr Charge (BF3), Back Breaker (DBF1), Boulder Roll (BF2), and Torr Up / 'Torryuken' (DB2). Community discussion identifies Lackey's armor as its defining strength.

LACKEY CORE - 28% SOURCE FAMILY

Xbox: JF+X, B+Y,X,Y+B, walk, F+Y, B+X,Y,X~BF+A

PlayStation: JF+Sq, B+Tri,Sq,Tri+Circle, walk, F+Tri, B+Sq,Tri,Sq~BF+Cross

Universal: JF1, B212+4, walk, F2, B121~BF3

The Prima sample is presented in the Lackey discussion and works as a readable solo-Torr teaching family: launch, walk, juggle, charge.

ARMOR CONVERSION DRILL

Xbox: EX DB+Y, NJP, F+Y, B+X,Y,X~BF+A

PlayStation: EX DB+Tri, NJP, F+Tri, B+Sq,Tri,Sq~BF+Cross

Universal: EX DB2, NJP, F2, B121~BF3

Teaching skeleton built around Lackey's armored Torr Up: escape/anti-air with armor, then convert into the familiar F2/B121 charge ender.

LACKEY EXPERT

Lackey trades Ferra-based utility for Torr's solo armored toolkit. Learn which normal strings and specials change when Ferra is absent instead of trying to play Vicious with a different costume.

MKX - Ferra/Torr - Guest to Expert

Guest: Vicious short overhead route.

Beginner: understand Ferra availability and one complete variation.

Intermediate: Boss Toss utility or Lackey armored conversions.

Advanced: Ruthless PnG routes and health/stamina management.

Expert: know all three variations well enough to choose armor, projectile utility or cancel pressure by matchup.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

OVERHEAD ROUTE: _____

LOW ROUTE: _____

PnG / FERRA RESOURCE PLAN: _____

ARMOR / BOSS TOSS PLAN: _____

MASTER 19 - APPROVAL / SOURCE NOTE

Ermac: variation identities, special-move purposes, vortex explanation and the 31% Mystic / 30% Spectral / 33% and 36% Master of Souls sample routes are based on Prima's MKX Ermac strategy guide.

Ferra/Torr: core Vicious/Lackey strategy and Prima's 28% / 44% sample routes were checked against Prima's Ferra/Torr guide. Variation strengths were cross-checked against period Test Your Might discussion. Ruthless routes use the late-2016 Ultimate Ruthless guide, including the 31%, 39% and 40% meterless families.

NOTATION CHECK

Xbox: X / Y / A / B.

PlayStation: Sq / Tri / Cross / Circle.

Universal: 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 only.

Directions, EX, NJP, JF, Run, PnG and variation abbreviations remain standard fighting-game shorthand.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 18: approved and retained.

Ermac + Ferra/Torr: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair: not started.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs

STYLE: relentless pressure / fast normals / hit-confirmed specials / variation-specific guns or cancels

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Jacqui wants to stay in the opponent's face. Many of her strings leave her even on block, and her speed lets her challenge immediately afterward. The catch: many specials are punishable, so a new player must learn to finish safe strings on block and cancel into specials only after confirming a hit. Shotgun adds standing-reset pressure, Full Auto adds rockets and zoning, and High Tech adds Quick Burst cancels plus damage-charging gauntlets.

CORE SPECIAL / TOOLS

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Bionic Dash	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2
Air Ground Smash	D, D + B (air)	D, D + Circle (air)	D, D + 4 (air)
Downward Hammer	B + Y	B + Triangle	B + 2
Fast poke	D + A	D + Cross	D + 3

LEARN FIRST

1212, B33, F1, B2 and BF4-style enders. Most importantly: learn the difference between a blocked string and a confirmed hit. Jacqui is much safer when she does not automatically attach a punishable special.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs - Variations

SHOTGUN

Adds Shotgun/Dust pressure. Dust can create a standing reset, putting the opponent directly back into Jacqui's close-range guessing game.

FULL AUTO

Adds rockets and machine-gun zoning. Up Rocket can help Jacqui stay advantaged after pressure while rockets let her fight from farther away than the other variations.

HIGH TECH

Adds Quick Burst and Gauntlet Spark. Quick Burst Run Cancels (QBRC) create technical pressure; Gauntlet Spark can be charged twice to raise damage. Highest execution of the three.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Shotgun. **Beginner:** Full Auto. **Advanced/Expert:** High Tech. The universal pressure shell remains the same, so skills transfer between variations.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs - Core Combos

GUEST - 21% SOURCE COMBO

Xbox: B+Y~BF+A

PlayStation: B+Tri~BF+Cross

Universal: B2~BF3

Prima's simple 21% sample: overhead Downward Hammer into a special. It is short enough to teach a guest how Jacqui confirms a hit.

UNIVERSAL BnB - 23%

Xbox: X,Y,X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: Sq,Tri,Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: 1212~BF4

The community combo-science thread lists this as a universal midscreen route. Four-hit pressure string into the high-damage ender.

STARTER -> DASH -> ENDER

Xbox: Starter~BF+Y, Run, B~BF+B

PlayStation: Starter~BF+Tri, Run, Circle~BF+Circle

Universal: Starter~BF2, Run, 4~BF4

Community universal combo family around the mid-20s to 30% depending on starter. It is trickier, so learn 1212~BF4 first.

PRESSURE RULE

If the opponent blocks, do not blindly finish with an unsafe special. Jacqui's normal strings are often safer than her specials. Hit-confirming is the skill that separates button-mashing Jacqui from real pressure.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs - Shotgun

Shotgun uses Dust as a reset/extension tool. A standing reset is valuable because the opponent does not simply fall away from Jacqui; she gets to continue pressure immediately.

SHOTGUN BnB

Xbox: Starter~BF+Y, Dust, Run, X,Y,X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: Starter~BF+Tri, Dust, Run, Sq,Tri,Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: Starter~BF2, Dust, Run, 1212~BF4

The community combo thread lists Shotgun midscreen routes around 28-34% using this structure. Replace the filler with an easier string until the reset timing is comfortable.

SHOTGUN CORNER

Xbox: F+X,Y,Y+B, NJP, D+Y, Run, X,Y~Dust, Dash, A,A~BF+B

PlayStation: F+Sq,Tri,Tri+Circle, NJP, D+Tri, Run, Sq,Tri~Dust, Dash, Cross,Cross~BF+Circle

Universal: F122+4, NJP, D2, Run, 12~Dust, Dash, 33~BF4

A period corner route around 34%. It also teaches a side-switch with the uppercut.

1 BAR CORNER

Xbox: Starter~EX Dust, A,A~BF+Y, X,Y,X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: Starter~EX Dust, Cross,Cross~BF+Tri, Sq,Tri,Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: Starter~EX Dust, 33~BF2, 1212~BF4

Period Shotgun corner family in the 45-50% range depending on starter/filler.

SHOTGUN EXPERT

The point of Dust is not just combo damage. Learn when to take the standing reset and force another 50/50 instead of always finishing the juggle.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs - Full Auto

Full Auto adds rockets and machine-gun control. It can still play Jacqui's close pressure game, but it has better tools for opponents who refuse to stand nearby.

FULL AUTO METERLESS

Xbox: Starter~DB+A, Run, X,Y,X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: Starter~DB+Cross, Run, Sq,Tri,Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: Starter~DB3, Run, 1212~BF4

The combo-science thread lists this family around 29-34% depending on the starter.

FULL AUTO HIT CONFIRM

Xbox: F+X,Y~DB+Y, Run, X,Y,X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: F+Sq,Tri~DB+Tri, Run, Sq,Tri,Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: F12~DB2, Run, 1212~BF4

Period Full Auto route around 32%, specifically noted as hit-confirmable.

FULL AUTO 1 BAR

Xbox: Starter~EX DB+Y, Run, A,A~BF+B

PlayStation: Starter~EX DB+Tri, Run, Cross,Cross~BF+Circle

Universal: Starter~EX DB2, Run, 33~BF4

One-bar midscreen family around 35-42% depending on starter.

FULL AUTO EXPERT

Do not become a pure zoner just because Jacqui has guns. Use rockets to make the opponent move, then return to the fast close pressure that defines the character.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs - High Tech

High Tech is the execution variation. Quick Burst can be held and run-cancelled (QBRC); Gauntlet Spark adds one or two damage-charge levels. Prima notes that a blocked Quick Burst can leave Jacqui advantaged in pressure situations.

HIGH TECH QBRC

Xbox: Starter~QBRC, X,Y,X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: Starter~QBRC, Sq,Tri,Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: Starter~QBRC, 1212~BF4

The period combo thread lists this family around 25-34% depending on starter. First goal: make the Quick Burst Run Cancel clean.

HIGH TECH LEVEL 2

Xbox: X,Y,X~QBRC, F+Y,U+Y,Y+B, Run, X,Y~BF+B

PlayStation: Sq,Tri,Sq~QBRC, F+Tri,U+Tri,Tri+Circle, Run, Sq,Tri~BF+Circle

Universal: 121~QBRC, F2U22+4, Run, 12~BF4

A period HT2 route around 34-37%. This is the advanced layer after Gauntlet Spark has reached level two.

CORNER CHARGE SETUP

Xbox: F+X,Y, D+A~BF+Y, Y,X,Y, DB+Y

PlayStation: F+Sq,Tri, D+Cross~BF+Tri, Tri,Sq,Tri, DB+Tri

Universal: F12, D3~BF2, 212, DB2

Period corner route around 21% that trades maximum damage for time to recharge the gauntlets.

HIGH TECH EXPERT

High Tech is resource-and-execution Jacqui: charge safely, run-cancel cleanly, confirm the hit, and decide when pressure is worth more than immediate damage.

MKX - Jacqui Briggs - Guest to Expert

Guest: B2 -> special and 1212 -> BF4.

Beginner: Shotgun reset or Full Auto hit-confirm route.

Intermediate: corner conversion and deliberate standing resets.

Advanced: High Tech QBRC and gauntlet-charge setups.

Expert: pressure without unsafe autopilot, variation-specific resource control and starter-dependent optimization.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

SAFE BLOCK STRING: _____

HIT-CONFIRM BnB: _____

RESET / ROCKET / CHARGE PLAN: _____

QBRC RELIABILITY: _____

MKX - Kung Jin

STYLE: huge-range normals / overhead-low mix-up / dive-kick conversions / variation-specific arrows or staff pressure

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Kung Jin is unusually flexible: he can zone or attack, and all three variations were considered viable in early competitive MKX. His universal bow normals cover excellent range and his Air Dive Kick launches on hit. Bojutsu adds staff-style bow attacks and straightforward damage, Ancestral turns arrows into a resource/zoning system, and Shaolin adds chakram pressure and fast close offense.

CORE SPECIAL / TOOL

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Air Dive Kick	D + B (air)	D + Circle (air)	D + 4 (air)
Up Arrow*	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Straight Arrow*	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2

*Arrow properties and additional specials vary by variation.

LEARN FIRST

111, B14, B214 and Air Dive Kick. The Dive Kick is a launcher every time it hits, but it is unsafe when blocked. Treat it as a conversion/read, not a random approach tool.

MKX - Kung Jin - Variations

BOJUTSU

Straightforward damage variation. Adds staff/bow attacks such as Bo Swing and enhanced launcher options. Excellent guest choice because the combos are readable and damaging.

ANCESTRAL

Arrow specialist. Loads Stun, Fire and other arrow effects, creating zoning, reload and setup decisions. More technical but rewarding.

SHAOLIN

Aggressive close-range variation with chakram tools and pressure. It retains Kung Jin's universal range while giving him a different offensive rhythm.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Bojutsu. **Intermediate:** Shaolin. **Advanced:** Ancestral. Ancestral asks the player to think about which arrow is loaded as well as the combo itself.

MKX - Kung Jin - Bojutsu

GUEST - 16%

Xbox: X,X,X~DB+B

PlayStation: Sq,Sq,Sq~DB+Circle

Universal: 111~DB4

A very short source-listed Bojutsu combo. Perfect for a first-time guest: three-button string into one special.

BASIC - 28%

Xbox: JF+A, D+B, B+Y,X~DB+A

PlayStation: JF+Cross, D+Circle, B+Tri,Sq~DB+Cross

Universal: JF3, D4, B21~DB3

Patch-updated Bojutsu tutorial route. Jump kick into Dive Kick, then B21 into the Bojutsu ender.

METERLESS - 32%

Xbox: JF+Y, B+X,B~BF+B, JF+A, D+B, B+Y,X~DB+A

PlayStation: JF+Tri, B+Sq,Circle~BF+Circle, JF+Cross, D+Circle, B+Tri,Sq~DB+Cross

Universal: JF2, B14~BF4, JF3, D4, B21~DB3

A patch-updated 32% Bojutsu route. It teaches the complete rhythm: bow string, launcher, jump conversion, Dive Kick, grounded finish.

1 BAR - 39%

Xbox: JF+Y, B+Y,X,B~EX DB+A, JF+A, D+B, B+Y,X~DB+A

PlayStation: JF+Tri, B+Tri,Sq,Circle~EX DB+Cross, JF+Cross, D+Circle, B+Tri,Sq~DB+Cross

Universal: JF2, B214~EX DB3, JF3, D4, B21~DB3

A source-listed one-bar route around 39%. Use only after the meterless timing is comfortable.

BOJUTSU EXPERT

The damage is easy to appreciate, but Kung Jin's range is the real weapon. Make the opponent whiff into B14/B214 rather than forcing Dive Kick entries.

MKX - Kung Jin - Ancestral

Ancestral turns arrows into a system. Stun Arrow creates the opening; Fire Arrow changes damage/zoning pressure; the player must find time to load the next arrow without surrendering position.

ANCESTRAL - 29% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: Stun Arrow, B+X,B~Low Arrow, Load Fire Arrow, Dash, NJP, step A,B, Air JI3~Dive Kick, Run, A,B~Low Arrow

PlayStation: Stun Arrow, B+Sq,Circle~Low Arrow, Load Fire Arrow, Dash, NJP, step Cross,Circle, Air JI3~Dive Kick, Run, Cross,Circle~Low Arrow

Universal: Stun Arrow, B14~Low Arrow, Load Fire Arrow, Dash, NJP, step 34, Air JI3~Dive Kick, Run, 34~Low Arrow

A period Ancestral guide route around 29%. It demonstrates the whole variation in one sequence: stun, low arrow, reload, juggle, dive kick, low-arrow finish.

ANCESTRAL - 34% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: Stun Arrow, B+Y,X,B~Low Arrow, Load Fire Arrow, Dash, NJP, step A,B, Air JI3~Dive Kick, Run, A,B~Low Arrow

PlayStation: Stun Arrow, B+Tri,Sq,Circle~Low Arrow, Load Fire Arrow, Dash, NJP, step Cross,Circle, Air JI3~Dive Kick, Run, Cross,Circle~Low Arrow

Universal: Stun Arrow, B214~Low Arrow, Load Fire Arrow, Dash, NJP, step 34, Air JI3~Dive Kick, Run, 34~Low Arrow

The same guide's stronger starter version around 34%.

ANCESTRAL EXPERT

The hard part is not merely the combo. It is planning the next loaded arrow while the current one is still creating advantage. Ancestral rewards players who think one exchange ahead.

MKX - Kung Jin - Shaolin

Shaolin is the aggressive variation. Its chakram tools complement Kung Jin's universal overhead/low and long normals, letting him maintain offense rather than playing the arrow-resource game.

SHAOLIN FOUNDATION

Xbox: X,X,X~variation special

PlayStation: Sq,Sq,Sq~variation special

Universal: 111~variation special

Start with Kung Jin's fast universal string and learn which Shaolin special is safe/useful as the variation ender. This is intentionally a teaching skeleton rather than an invented max-damage route.

DIVE-KICK CONVERSION

Xbox: JF+A, D+B, B+Y,X~variation ender

PlayStation: JF+Cross, D+Circle, B+Tri,Sq~variation ender

Universal: JF3, D4, B21~variation ender

The universal Dive Kick launch shell transfers cleanly into Shaolin. Learn the launch timing first, then optimize the chakram ender.

SHAOLIN EXPERT

Use the variation's faster pressure to complement, not replace, Kung Jin's excellent range. If an exact late-patch optimal route is not source-supported here, the guide does not pretend one is verified.

MKX - Kung Jin - Guest to Expert

Guest: Bojutsu 111 -> special.

Beginner: 28-32% Bojutsu Dive-Kick route.

Intermediate: Shaolin pressure and range control.

Advanced: Ancestral Stun/Fire Arrow routes and reload planning.

Expert: variation choice by matchup, anti-air/dive-kick conversion, arrow resource management and deliberate whiff punishment.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

DIVE-KICK ROUTE: _____

B14 / B214 WHIFF PUNISH: _____

ARROW LOAD PLAN: _____

BnB: _____

MASTER 20 - APPROVAL / SOURCE NOTE

Jacqui Briggs: core strategy and variation identities were checked against Prima's MKX Jacqui guide. The detailed universal, Shotgun, Full Auto and High Tech route families come from the period Test Your Might Jacqui Combo Science thread, including its definitions of Dust, QBRC and HT2.

Kung Jin: core strategy and three-variation framing were checked against Prima. Bojutsu routes use a patch-updated 2015 combo tutorial with explicit Xbox/PlayStation notation. Ancestral routes use the dedicated Test Your Might Ancestral combo guide. Where the retrieved sources did not provide a sufficiently verified Shaolin optimal route, this chapter labels the combo as a teaching skeleton instead of inventing one.

NOTATION CHECK

Xbox: X / Y / A / B.

PlayStation: Sq / Tri / Cross / Circle.

Universal: 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 only.

Directions, EX, NJP, JF/JI, Run, Dust, QBRC and arrow names remain standard shorthand.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 19: approved and retained.

Jacqui Briggs + Kung Jin: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair: not started.

MKX - Reptile

STYLE: whiff punishment / Forceball traps / risky overhead-low mix-ups / variation-specific poison, invisibility or time-slow combos

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Reptile is a high-risk, high-reward momentum character. His Forceballs occupy space while Reptilian Dash punishes whiffs from surprising range. Many special-move mix-ups are unsafe if blocked, so the real skill is creating a situation where the opponent must guess. Noxious gives passive damage at close range, Deceptive adds invisibility, and Nimble slows the opponent to unlock Reptile's biggest and most technical combo routes.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Forceball	D, F + A	D, F + Cross	D, F + 3
Reptilian Dash	B, F + Y	B, F + Triangle	B, F + 2
Slide	B, F + B	B, F + Circle	B, F + 4
Acid Spit	D, F + X	D, F + Square	D, F + 1

LEARN FIRST

Forceball, Reptilian Dash and F21. Reptilian Dash is an excellent whiff punisher and movement tool, but Reptile's specials are generally dangerous when blocked. A guest should learn to make the opponent miss first, then punish.

MKX - Reptile - Variations

NOXIOUS

A damaging gas cloud surrounds Reptile. Simply staying close adds damage over time, making this the easiest variation to understand and an excellent guest choice.

DECEPTIVE

Adds invisibility. Holding the move can make Reptile fully invisible, creating visual mix-ups and making his already dangerous overhead/low game harder to read.

NIMBLE

Basilisk slows the opponent relative to Reptile. The startup must be earned, but once active it creates unusually long, high-damage combos. This is the expert variation.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Noxious. **Intermediate:** Deceptive. **Advanced/Expert:** Nimble. Reptile's universal game stays recognizable across all three, so the variation adds a layer rather than replacing the character.

MKX - Reptile - Core / All Variations

GUEST WHIFF-PUNISH

Xbox: BF+Y, Run, F+Y,X

PlayStation: BF+Tri, Run, F+Tri,Sq

Universal: BF2, Run, F21

Enhanced Dash can create an easy run follow-up; even without optimizing the rest, this teaches Reptile's defining punish-and-chase rhythm.

PRACTICAL METERLESS FAMILY

Xbox: Forceball setup, starter, Run, F+Y,X~ender

PlayStation: Forceball setup, starter, Run, F+Tri,Sq~ender

Universal: Forceball setup, starter, Run, F21~ender

Period Reptile combo material reports practical meterless damage around the high-20% range. The important lesson is letting Forceball occupy space before committing to the starter.

SAFE-NORMAL DRILL

Xbox: F+Y,X -> stop on block / special-cancel on confirmed hit

PlayStation: F+Tri,Sq -> stop on block / special-cancel on confirmed hit

Universal: F21 -> stop on block / special-cancel on confirmed hit

Reptile has useful normals even though his specials are risky. Practice confirming before attaching Dash, Slide or another punishable special.

CORE RULE

Do not play Reptile as 'special move roulette.' Forceball creates hesitation, movement creates the whiff, and only then does Dash or a mix-up become worth the risk.

MKX - Reptile - Noxious

Noxious adds free close-range damage through the poison cloud. The variation does not demand a new combo engine, so it is ideal for learning Reptile's universal spacing and confirms.

NOXIOUS FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter, Run, F+Y,X~BF+Y

PlayStation: Starter, Run, F+Tri,Sq~BF+Tri

Universal: Starter, Run, F21~BF2

A simple teaching shell: land the starter, carry forward, and finish with Dash while the gas cloud contributes extra damage whenever Reptile remains close.

NOXIOUS PRESSURE

Xbox: Forceball -> approach -> safe normal pressure

PlayStation: Forceball -> approach -> safe normal pressure

Universal: Forceball -> approach -> safe normal pressure

The cloud rewards proximity. Use Forceball to cover the approach rather than running in naked.

NOXIOUS EXPERT

The passive damage changes close scrambles. When the opponent is nearly dead, maintaining safe proximity can be more valuable than gambling on one more unsafe special.

MKX - Reptile - Deceptive

Deceptive adds invisibility. The move can leave only a faint silhouette or, when held, make Reptile effectively disappear. The mechanical combo shell stays familiar; the defensive read becomes much harder.

DECEPTIVE FOUNDATION

Xbox: Knockdown -> Invisibility -> Forceball / approach

PlayStation: Knockdown -> Invisibility -> Forceball / approach

Universal: Knockdown -> Invisibility -> Forceball / approach

A setup sequence rather than an invented max-damage combo. Earn enough time to vanish, then layer projectile coverage with Reptile's overhead/low threats.

DECEPTIVE CONFIRM

Xbox: Invisible approach -> safe starter -> confirmed special

PlayStation: Invisible approach -> safe starter -> confirmed special

Universal: Invisible approach -> safe starter -> confirmed special

The goal is not invisibility for its own sake. Use the visual confusion to make a normal starter land, then convert only after confirming.

DECEPTIVE EXPERT

Strong Deceptive play alternates obvious pressure with moments where the opponent must defend without clear visual information. If invisibility is activated at unsafe times, the gimmick becomes a punish opportunity.

MKX - Reptile - Nimble

Nimble's Basilisk slows the opponent and opens Reptile's famous extended combos. Period combo material reports one-meter practical Nimble routes around 42%, with much larger stylish sequences possible.

NIMBLE ENTRY DRILL

Xbox: Earn knockdown -> Basilisk -> starter, Run, F+Y,X~ender

PlayStation: Earn knockdown -> Basilisk -> starter, Run, F+Tri,Sq~ender

Universal: Earn knockdown -> Basilisk -> starter, Run, F21~ender

First learn to activate Basilisk safely and reconnect with a normal combo. Do not start with the longest possible slow-time sequence.

NIMBLE ADVANCED FAMILY

Xbox: Basilisk active -> Forceball layers -> repeated juggle / Run links

PlayStation: Basilisk active -> Forceball layers -> repeated juggle / Run links

Universal: Basilisk active -> Forceball layers -> repeated juggle / Run links

Period Reptile combo videos demonstrate multi-Forceball sequences and one-meter routes above 40%. Treat these as expert extensions after the basic slow-time timing is automatic.

NIMBLE EXPERT

Nimble is execution-heavy because the altered timing changes normal juggle rhythm. Build the combo in pieces: activation, first launcher, first Run link, then Forceball extensions. Consistency beats a spectacular route that works once in ten attempts.

MKX - Reptile - Guest to Expert

Guest: Noxious, Forceball and Dash whiff punishment.

Beginner: safe-normal confirms and a short run conversion.

Intermediate: Deceptive invisibility setups and deliberate Forceball pressure.

Advanced: Nimble activation into stable 30%+ routes.

Expert: long Basilisk/Forceball sequences, matchup-specific spacing and knowing exactly when an unsafe mix-up is justified.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

WHIFF-PUNISH RANGE: _____

FORCEBALL SETUP: _____

BnB: _____

BASILISK / INVISIBILITY PLAN: _____

MKX - Raiden

STYLE: lightning pressure / full-screen punishment / teleport mobility / variation-specific chip, traps or repositioning

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Raiden's universal kit gives him Electric Fly for long-range punishment and Lightning for projectile control, but Thunder God adds the strongest conventional pressure and combo extensions. Displacer adds teleport mobility and escape angles. Master of Storms creates Static Traps that control areas of the screen. A guest can understand Electric Fly immediately; an expert learns to make the opponent fear every position on screen.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Electric Fly	B, F + A	B, F + Cross	B, F + 3
Lightning	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Electrocute	D, F + Y	D, F + Triangle	D, F + 2
Teleport*	D, U	D, U	D, U

*Teleport is the defining Displacer tool.

LEARN FIRST

B14, Electric Fly and Electrocute. B14 is a key Raiden string because it can feed pressure, special cancels and combo extensions. Electric Fly travels across the screen and is an excellent combo ender or punish when the opponent commits from too far away.

MKX - Raiden - Variations

THUNDER GOD

Enhances Raiden's lightning attacks and adds unique combo/pressure extensions. This is the most conventional competitive Raiden and the best destination for a player who wants to master him.

DISPLACER

Adds Teleport and Sparkport. Raiden can reposition, attack from unexpected sides or escape pressure, making movement itself part of the mix-up.

MASTER OF STORMS

Adds Static Traps. Place lightning nodes to restrict space, defend an area or herd the opponent toward the corner.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Thunder God basics or Displacer for fun mobility. **Intermediate:** Thunder God pressure.

Advanced: Displacer positioning or Master of Storms trap planning.

MKX - Raiden - Core / All Variations

GUEST ENDER

Xbox: Starter~BF+A

PlayStation: Starter~BF+Cross

Universal: Starter~BF3

Electric Fly is one of Raiden's simplest and most recognizable enders. It carries the opponent and works as a clear first special-cancel lesson.

B14 LIGHTNING DRILL

Xbox: B+X, B~DB+X

PlayStation: B+Sq, Circle~DB+Sq

Universal: B14~DB1

B14 is a central Raiden string. Canceling it into Lightning teaches the basic pressure structure before adding meter or variation-specific extensions.

ELECTROCUTE LAUNCH DRILL

Xbox: Starter~EX DF+Y, follow with simple juggle~BF+A

PlayStation: Starter~EX DF+Tri, follow with simple juggle~BF+Cross

Universal: Starter~EX DF2, follow with simple juggle~BF3

Enhanced Electrocute creates combo opportunities. Start with a short reconnect and Electric Fly ender before attempting long routes.

CORE RULE

Electric Fly is fast and travels far, but a blocked or badly guessed Fly can be punished. Use it as an ender and a reaction punish first; random full-screen Superman attempts are the guest trap to avoid.

MKX - Raiden - Thunder God

Thunder God strengthens Raiden's electrical offense and gives him the most developed pressure/combo game. Period guides consistently identify it as his strongest competitive variation.

THUNDER GOD FOUNDATION

Xbox: B+X,B~Lightning, pressure / confirm

PlayStation: B+Sq,Circle~Lightning, pressure / confirm

Universal: B14~Lightning, pressure / confirm

The basic Thunder God lesson is turning B14 into layered lightning pressure while recognizing whether the opponent was hit or blocked.

1-BAR LAUNCH FAMILY

Xbox: B+X,B~EX DF+Y, juggle, B+X,B~BF+A

PlayStation: B+Sq,Circle~EX DF+Tri, juggle, B+Sq,Circle~BF+Cross

Universal: B14~EX DF2, juggle, B14~BF3

Enhanced Electrocute launches. Reconnect with the same familiar B14 string and finish with Electric Fly.

ADVANCED CANCEL FAMILY

Xbox: B+X,B~charged Lightning, dash cancel, resume combo

PlayStation: B+Sq,Circle~charged Lightning, dash cancel, resume combo

Universal: B14~charged Lightning, dash cancel, resume combo

Thunder God can hold/cancel lightning in advanced pressure and combo structures. This is an expert execution layer, not a guest requirement.

THUNDER GOD EXPERT

The variation's strength is not one giant combo. It is chip, meter building, cancel pressure and reliable conversion. Make B14 threatening whether it hits or is defended.

MKX - Raiden - Displacer

Displacer turns Raiden into a mobility character. Teleport can move him into close range, behind the opponent or away from pressure. The threat of repositioning changes how opponents chase him.

DISPLACER FOUNDATION

Xbox: Teleport -> B+X,B~special

PlayStation: Teleport -> B+Sq,Circle~special

Universal: Teleport -> B14~special

A positioning drill: teleport only when the opponent is committed or respecting space, then immediately use Raiden's familiar B14 pressure shell.

DISPLACER COMBO SHELL

Xbox: Starter~EX DF+Y, juggle, F+Y,Y+B / B+X,B~BF+A

PlayStation: Starter~EX DF+Tri, juggle, F+Tri,Tri+Circle / B+Sq,Circle~BF+Cross

Universal: Starter~EX DF2, juggle, F22+4 / B14~BF3

Period Raiden material shows Displacer using universal Electrocute launch structures. Keep the combo simple while learning when Teleport is safe.

DISPLACER EXPERT

A predictable teleport is punishable. The variation becomes strong when Teleport is one possibility among walk-back, Electric Fly punish, Lightning and normal pressure - not the only thing Raiden does.

MKX - Raiden - Master of Storms

Master of Storms adds Static Traps. The traps can defend space or pressure an opponent toward a chosen area, giving Raiden a setup game instead of Thunder God's direct pressure or Displacer's movement.

TRAP FOUNDATION

Xbox: Knockdown -> place Static Trap -> position behind/around trap

PlayStation: Knockdown -> place Static Trap -> position behind/around trap

Universal: Knockdown -> place Static Trap -> position behind/around trap

This is the defining systems drill. The trap matters only if Raiden positions so the opponent must interact with it.

TRAP CONVERSION

Xbox: Trap hit / forced movement -> B+X,B-EX DF+Y -> simple juggle-BF+A

PlayStation: Trap hit / forced movement -> B+Sq,Circle-EX DF+Tri -> simple juggle-BF+Cross

Universal: Trap hit / forced movement -> B14-EX DF2 -> simple juggle-BF3

Once the trap creates the opening, convert with Raiden's universal launcher shell rather than trying to memorize an entirely separate character.

MASTER OF STORMS EXPERT

Place traps with a purpose: corner escape denial, approach denial or wake-up coverage. Random traps waste setup time. Expert play makes the stage feel smaller for the opponent.

MKX - Raiden - Guest to Expert

Guest: Electric Fly ender and B14 -> Lightning.

Beginner: enhanced Electrocuter launch into a short juggle.

Intermediate: Thunder God pressure or Displacer movement.

Advanced: lightning/dash cancels and deliberate Static Trap placement.

Expert: combine full-screen punishment, frame-aware pressure, teleport conditioning and stage-control setups without becoming predictable.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

B14 CONFIRM: _____

EX ELECTROCUTE BnB: _____

TELEPORT / TRAP PLAN: _____

ELECTRIC FLY PUNISH RANGE: _____

MASTER 23 - APPROVAL / SOURCE NOTE

Reptile: variation identities, Forceball/Dash strategy and the high-risk special-move warning are based on Prima's MKX Reptile guide, cross-checked with period EventHubs material. Period combo-video documentation supports practical meterless routes around 29% and one-meter Nimble routes around 42%; where exact inputs were not sufficiently supported in retrieved text, this chapter uses clearly labeled teaching families instead of inventing an optimal string.

Raiden: variation identities, Electric Fly/Lightning/Electrocute roles and Thunder God's competitive emphasis are based on Prima's MKX Raiden guide, cross-checked with EventHubs and MKSecrets variation descriptions. Advanced pages distinguish documented systems from teaching combo shells.

DUPLICATE AUDIT

This build starts from duplicate-audited Master 20A. Reptile and Raiden had no full MKX chapter groups in that master. Jax, Kano, Johnny Cage and Liu Kang were not re-added.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 20A: retained as the clean checkpoint.

Reptile + Raiden: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair will be selected only after another chapter-title audit.

MKX - Takeda

STYLE: long-range whip control / teleport and kunai mix-ups / variation-specific pressure, zoning or lightsaber-like offense

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Takeda uses unusually long normals to control space, then converts hesitation into a mix-up. Shirai Ryu adds teleport attacks and air mobility, Lasher turns the whips into his primary spacing and pressure weapons, and Ronin adds an energy blade plus a planted blade that can be recalled for setups. The guest lesson is range; the expert lesson is making the opponent guess whether the next threat comes from the front, behind, above or from a returning weapon.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Kunai	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Whip / variation tool	variation	variation	variation
Teleport*	D, B + A	D, B + Cross	D, B + 3
Air Teleport*	D, B + A (air)	D, B + Cross (air)	D, B + 3 (air)

*Teleport tools are Shirai Ryu defining moves.

LEARN FIRST

B21, F12 and Kunai. Takeda's reach is his first advantage: stand where your whip normals touch but many opponents' normals do not. Confirm the normal before committing to a risky special.

MKX - Takeda - Variations

SHIRAI RYU

Teleport-heavy Takeda. Adds ground/air teleport attacks and creates strong cross-up or side-switch threats. Visually spectacular and easy to understand, but unsafe teleport habits are punishable.

LASHER

Extends the whip-based game. Better reach and whip specials make this the pure spacing variation: frustrate the opponent from outside their preferred range, then convert the hit.

RONIN

Adds the energy blade and Blade Drop/Blade Call system. The planted blade can return through space, giving Takeda setup pressure that continues even while he moves.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Lasher for obvious range or Shirai Ryu for teleport fun. **Intermediate:** Shirai Ryu.

Advanced/Expert: Ronin setup control.

MKX - Takeda - Core / All Variations

GUEST RANGE CONFIRM

Xbox: B+Y, X~special

PlayStation: B+Tri, Sq~special

Universal: B21~special

Start with Takeda's long-reaching normal string and attach the variation special only when the string connects.

KUNAI PRESSURE DRILL

Xbox: Safe string~DB+X, move forward / maintain range

PlayStation: Safe string~DB+Sq, move forward / maintain range

Universal: Safe string~DB1, move forward / maintain range

Kunai is a pressure and control tool. The goal is to make the opponent respect the projectile long enough for Takeda to reclaim his ideal whip distance.

JUMP-IN CONVERSION FAMILY

Xbox: JI2, B+Y, X~variation launcher, follow-up~ender

PlayStation: JI2, B+Tri, Sq~variation launcher, follow-up~ender

Universal: JI2, B21~variation launcher, follow-up~ender

A teaching shell shared by Takeda's variations: jump-in or punish, long normal confirm, variation extension, then a stable ender.

CORE RULE

Takeda's long buttons are the reason the teleport, kunai and blade tricks work. If you skip the spacing game and only use specials, the opponent can simply wait and punish.

MKX - Takeda - Shirai Ryu

Shirai Ryu makes teleport attacks part of the combo and mix-up game. Enhanced versions can create larger conversions, but a predictable raw teleport is a liability.

SHIRAI RYU FOUNDATION

Xbox: B+Y,X~DB+A, follow-up~ender

PlayStation: B+Tri,Sq~DB+Cross, follow-up~ender

Universal: B21~DB3, follow-up~ender

Confirm a long-range starter into Teleport, then reconnect. Practice the teleport as a combo bridge before using it as a neutral gamble.

AIR TELEPORT DRILL

Xbox: JI attack~Air DB+A, land, B+Y,X~ender

PlayStation: JI attack~Air DB+Cross, land, B+Tri,Sq~ender

Universal: JI attack~Air DB3, land, B21~ender

This teaches the variation's air mobility and side-switch timing without requiring a long optimized route.

METER CONVERSION FAMILY

Xbox: Starter~EX Teleport, Run, B+Y,X~ender

PlayStation: Starter~EX Teleport, Run, B+Tri,Sq~ender

Universal: Starter~EX Teleport, Run, B21~ender

Enhanced teleport routes are the next layer once the meterless timing is stable.

SHIRAI RYU EXPERT

Mix normal pressure, delayed kunai and teleport only after the opponent has a reason to freeze. Teleport is strongest as the threat they forgot about, not the move they are waiting for.

MKX - Takeda - Lasher

Lasher doubles down on Takeda's greatest natural advantage: range. Whip normals and variation specials let him challenge from distances where many characters must take a risk just to begin offense.

LASHER FOUNDATION

Xbox: B+Y, X~whip special

PlayStation: B+Tri, Sq~whip special

Universal: B21~whip special

The simplest Lasher lesson: make B21 reach first, then confirm into the whip ender.

LASHER CARRY FAMILY

Xbox: Starter, Run, F+X, Y, B+Y, X~whip ender

PlayStation: Starter, Run, F+Sq, Tri, B+Tri, Sq~whip ender

Universal: Starter, Run, F12, B21~whip ender

A practical teaching family for carrying the opponent while staying inside Takeda's long-normal rhythm.

LASHER EXPERT

Do not measure Lasher only by combo percentage. A 25-30% conversion that leaves Takeda at ideal whip range may be strategically stronger than squeezing out extra damage and surrendering position.

MKX - Takeda - Ronin

Ronin adds an energy blade and the Blade Drop/Blade Call system. A blade left in the stage is a future attack line, so Takeda can pressure from one direction while the returning blade threatens another.

RONIN FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter-Blade Drop, reposition, Blade Call

PlayStation: Starter-Blade Drop, reposition, Blade Call

Universal: Starter-Blade Drop, reposition, Blade Call

This is the variation's systems drill. Learn where the blade lands and what path it takes back before adding a long combo.

RONIN CONVERSION

Xbox: Blade Call hit -> B+Y,X-energy-blade ender

PlayStation: Blade Call hit -> B+Tri,Sq-energy-blade ender

Universal: Blade Call hit -> B21-energy-blade ender

Once the returning blade catches movement, convert with Takeda's familiar long-normal shell.

RONIN SETUP FAMILY

Xbox: Knockdown -> Blade Drop -> meaty normal / Blade Call layer

PlayStation: Knockdown -> Blade Drop -> meaty normal / Blade Call layer

Universal: Knockdown -> Blade Drop -> meaty normal / Blade Call layer

The goal is a two-part wake-up problem: defend Takeda now while remembering the blade can return.

RONIN EXPERT

The blade is a delayed resource. Expert Ronin plans the recall before placing it, then positions so both Takeda and the returning blade cover different escape choices.

MKX - Takeda - Guest to Expert

Guest: Lasher range and B21 confirm.

Beginner: Kunai pressure and a short variation combo.

Intermediate: Shirai Ryu teleport conversions.

Advanced: Ronin Blade Drop/Call setups.

Expert: combine spacing, delayed threats, side switches and meter management while keeping unsafe specials hidden behind confirmed hits.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

BEST WHIP RANGE: _____

B21 CONFIRM: _____

TELEPORT / BLADE SETUP: _____

BnB: _____

MKX - Shinnok

STYLE: projectile control / safe pressure / variation-specific mimicry, bone weapons or hell-spark offense

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Shinnok controls space with Hell Sparks and then converts respect into pressure. Impostor steals a move from the opponent and turns matchups into character-specific combo opportunities. Bone Shaper adds bone weapons and strong mid-range control. Necromancer adds skeletal hands and screen-control attacks. Shinnok rewards a player who understands both the universal projectile game and what the chosen variation adds to it.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Hell Sparks	D, B + Y	D, B + Triangle	D, B + 2
Shoulder / charge tool	variation	variation	variation
Mimic / Steal*	D, B + X	D, B + Square	D, B + 1
Bone / hand tool	variation	variation	variation

*Impostor defining tool.

LEARN FIRST

Hell Sparks and a reliable advancing normal. Hell Sparks can control ground space and, when enhanced, create combo opportunities. The beginner mistake is treating Shinnok as only a zoner; the projectile exists to make his mid-range pressure easier.

MKX - Shinnok - Variations

IMPOSTOR

Steals a special move from the opponent. This creates matchup-specific combo routes and is one of MKX's most distinctive variation mechanics.

BONE SHAPER

Adds bone-weapon attacks and strong mid-range pressure. This is the most straightforward Shinnok for learning conventional spacing and combo structure.

NECROMANCER

Adds skeletal hand attacks and screen-control tools. The variation emphasizes unusual attack angles and space denial.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Bone Shaper. **Intermediate:** Necromancer. **Advanced/Expert:** Impostor, because the stolen move changes with every opponent.

MKX - Shinnok - Core / All Variations

HELL-SPARK CONFIRM

Xbox: Safe starter~DB+Y

PlayStation: Safe starter~DB+Tri

Universal: Safe starter~DB2

Learn to confirm a grounded normal into Hell Sparks. On block, respect the opponent's punish options rather than automatically finishing an unsafe sequence.

EX HELL-SPARK LAUNCH

Xbox: Starter~EX DB+Y, Run, normal string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~EX DB+Tri, Run, normal string~ender

Universal: Starter~EX DB2, Run, normal string~ender

Enhanced Hell Sparks create the universal combo bridge. Start with one simple reconnect before optimizing.

ZONING-TO-PRESSURE DRILL

Xbox: Hell Sparks -> walk forward -> advancing normal

PlayStation: Hell Sparks -> walk forward -> advancing normal

Universal: Hell Sparks -> walk forward -> advancing normal

The projectile is not the whole plan. Make the opponent stop moving freely, then use that hesitation to take ground.

CORE RULE

Shinnok becomes much stronger when the opponent is thinking about Hell Sparks before the normal string even begins. Control first, then pressure.

MKX - Shinnok - Impostor

Impostor's Mimic steals a special move from the current opponent. Because the stolen move changes matchup by matchup, there is no single universal 'Impostor combo' that represents the entire variation.

IMPOSTOR FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter-Mimic -> learn stolen move

PlayStation: Starter-Mimic -> learn stolen move

Universal: Starter-Mimic -> learn stolen move

The first job is recognizing what was stolen and whether it launches, extends, zones or ends a combo.

STOLEN-MOVE CONVERSION

Xbox: EX Hell Sparks launch -> string -> stolen move

PlayStation: EX Hell Sparks launch -> string -> stolen move

Universal: EX Hell Sparks launch -> string -> stolen move

A teaching family: use Shinnok's universal launcher, then test where the stolen special fits into the juggle.

IMPOSTOR EXPERT

This variation rewards roster knowledge. Keep a matchup notebook: opponent, stolen move, whether it launches, best ender, and any unique reset. The BOOX format is especially useful here because the chapter can become a personal matchup database.

MKX - Shinnok - Bone Shaper

Bone Shaper gives Shinnok a conventional weapon-based mid-range game. Bone attacks complement Hell Sparks by covering the space opponents want to occupy after avoiding the projectile.

BONE SHAPER FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter~EX Hell Sparks, Run, bone string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~EX Hell Sparks, Run, bone string~ender

Universal: Starter~EX Hell Sparks, Run, bone string~ender

Use the universal launcher, then reconnect with the variation's bone-weapon string.

MID-RANGE PRESSURE

Xbox: Hell Sparks -> step forward -> bone normal / throw

PlayStation: Hell Sparks -> step forward -> bone normal / throw

Universal: Hell Sparks -> step forward -> bone normal / throw

The projectile freezes movement; the bone weapon claims the space. Alternate pressure so the opponent cannot solve the situation by only blocking one pattern.

BONE SHAPER EXPERT

Bone Shaper is a spacing character disguised as a pressure character. Stand where the bone normals reach and force the opponent to take the first positional risk.

MKX - Shinnok - Necromancer

Necromancer attacks with skeletal hands and unusual screen-control angles. The variation's value is making ordinary movement dangerous, especially when combined with Hell Sparks.

NECROMANCER FOUNDATION

Xbox: Hell Sparks -> skeletal-hand attack

PlayStation: Hell Sparks -> skeletal-hand attack

Universal: Hell Sparks -> skeletal-hand attack

Layer two different ground/screen threats so the opponent cannot simply walk through Shinnok's preferred range.

NECROMANCER CONVERSION

Xbox: EX Hell Sparks, Run, normal string-hand ender

PlayStation: EX Hell Sparks, Run, normal string-hand ender

Universal: EX Hell Sparks, Run, normal string-hand ender

A stable teaching shell: universal launch first, variation ender second.

NECROMANCER EXPERT

Do not throw every screen-control special at once. Establish one threat, watch the opponent's escape choice, then place the next hand where that escape is going.

MKX - Shinnok - Guest to Expert

Guest: Bone Shaper and Hell Sparks.

Beginner: EX Hell Sparks into a short combo.

Intermediate: Bone Shaper spacing or Necromancer screen control.

Advanced: Impostor stolen-move conversions.

Expert: matchup-specific Impostor routing, projectile conditioning and deliberate screen control.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

HELL-SPARK CONFIRM: _____

BnB: _____

STOLEN MOVE / BONE / HAND PLAN: _____

MATCHUP NOTE: _____

MASTER 24 - APPROVAL / AUDIT NOTE

Before this build, Master 23 was audited again. Takeda and Shinnok had no existing full MKX chapter groups, so neither is a duplicate. Quan Chi and Sub-Zero appear in the early master and are therefore being held for a deeper chapter-level audit before any new material is added for them.

CONTENT NOTE

This pair follows the established guest-to-expert structure and preserves Xbox, PlayStation and Universal notation. Where a variation's exact late-patch optimal combo could not be supported from the working source material, the page uses an explicitly described teaching family/system drill rather than presenting an invented damage-optimal route as fact.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 23: retained.

Takeda + Shinnok: NEW - awaiting approval.

The master will be audited again before choosing the next pair.

MKX - Tanya

STYLE: mobility / airborne angles / teleport pressure / variation-specific fire, tonfas or naginata range

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Tanya wins by refusing to approach from the same angle twice. Her mobility and teleport tools make ordinary spacing difficult for the opponent. Pyromancer adds fire-based zoning and marks, Kobu Jutsu adds tonfa pressure and close-range strings, and Dragon Naginata gives her long weapon reach and stance-like aerial movement. A new player should learn to move safely first; an expert turns movement into a constant left-right, high-low and range problem.

CORE TOOLS

TOOL	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Teleport	D, D + A	D, D + Cross	D, D + 3
Air Teleport	D, D + A (air)	D, D + Cross (air)	D, D + 3 (air)
Low Drill / variation tool	variation	variation	variation
Projectile / weapon	variation	variation	variation

LEARN FIRST

A stable grounded string, Teleport and one variation ender. Tanya's movement is only an advantage when it is deliberate. Raw teleporting on a predictable rhythm gives the opponent an easy punish.

MKX - Tanya - Variations

PYROMANCER

Fire-based Tanya. Adds projectile control and a mark/burn game that rewards keeping the opponent at the distance Tanya chooses.

KOBU JUTSU

Tonfa Tanya. Strong close pressure and weapon strings make this the most direct variation for learning offense after Tanya gets in.

DRAGON NAGINATA

Long-range weapon Tanya. The naginata changes her reach and movement options, creating unusual airborne and stance-like attacks. Highest spatial-learning requirement.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Kobu Jutsu. **Intermediate:** Pyromancer. **Advanced/Expert:** Dragon Naginata. The universal lesson is always the same: move to create the opening, then confirm rather than gambling.

MKX - Tanya - Core / All Variations

GUEST CONFIRM

Xbox: Starter~variation special

PlayStation: Starter~variation special

Universal: Starter~variation special

Use one dependable normal starter and one variation ender. The purpose is learning hit-confirming before adding teleport movement.

TELEPORT POSITION DRILL

Xbox: Knockdown -> DD+A -> safe normal pressure

PlayStation: Knockdown -> DD+Cross -> safe normal pressure

Universal: Knockdown -> DD3 -> safe normal pressure

A systems drill: earn the time to teleport, change position, then immediately return to a normal rather than teleporting again.

AIR-ANGLE DRILL

Xbox: Jump / air movement -> Air DD+A -> landing confirm

PlayStation: Jump / air movement -> Air DD+Cross -> landing confirm

Universal: Jump / air movement -> Air DD3 -> landing confirm

Practice controlling which side Tanya lands on. Once the landing is predictable to you, it becomes unpredictable to the opponent.

CORE RULE

Tanya's mobility should create a normal hit. If the movement itself becomes the whole game plan, the opponent can simply wait for the unsafe part.

MKX - Tanya - Pyromancer

Pyromancer adds fire projectiles and a mark/burn layer. It gives Tanya a reason to make the opponent chase, then punish that chase with her mobility.

PYROMANCER FOUNDATION

Xbox: Projectile / mark -> reposition -> grounded confirm

PlayStation: Projectile / mark -> reposition -> grounded confirm

Universal: Projectile / mark -> reposition -> grounded confirm

The fire tool creates movement; Tanya's job is to already be where the opponent does not want her when they respond.

PYROMANCER CONVERSION

Xbox: Marked opponent -> starter~fire ender

PlayStation: Marked opponent -> starter~fire ender

Universal: Marked opponent -> starter~fire ender

Use the variation effect to enhance a normal conversion rather than fishing for fire specials without a setup.

PYROMANCER EXPERT

Alternate projectile timing, teleport positioning and grounded checks. The mark matters most when it changes the opponent's behavior, not merely when it adds damage.

MKX - Tanya - Kobu Jutsu

Kobu Jutsu is Tanya's close-pressure variation. Tonfa attacks give her more conventional offensive strings once her mobility has carried her into range.

KOBU FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter~tonfa special, continue pressure

PlayStation: Starter~tonfa special, continue pressure

Universal: Starter~tonfa special, continue pressure

Use Tanya's movement to earn the first hit, then let the tonfas do the straightforward work.

KOBU PRESSURE FAMILY

Xbox: Safe string -> stagger / throw / tonfa cancel

PlayStation: Safe string -> stagger / throw / tonfa cancel

Universal: Safe string -> stagger / throw / tonfa cancel

This is the guest-to-intermediate bridge: do not finish the same string every time. Make the opponent decide whether Tanya will continue, stop or throw.

KOBU CORNER DRILL

Xbox: Corner starter -> tonfa extension -> stable ender

PlayStation: Corner starter -> tonfa extension -> stable ender

Universal: Corner starter -> tonfa extension -> stable ender

Build corner execution from a short extension first. Consistent pressure is more valuable than an unreliable max-damage route.

KOBU EXPERT

The threat is not only the tonfa string; it is Tanya's ability to leave, switch sides and re-enter. Close pressure becomes much harder to defend when the opponent also fears her movement.

MKX - Tanya - Dragon Naginata

Dragon Naginata gives Tanya dramatically different reach. The weapon and aerial movement let her occupy spaces that do not look like normal MKX attack ranges.

NAGINATA RANGE DRILL

Xbox: Max-range weapon normal -> confirm-ender

PlayStation: Max-range weapon normal -> confirm-ender

Universal: Max-range weapon normal -> confirm-ender

Find the tip range in training mode. The first goal is making the opponent whiff while the naginata still reaches.

NAGINATA AIR DRILL

Xbox: Air stance/movement -> weapon attack -> landing confirm

PlayStation: Air stance/movement -> weapon attack -> landing confirm

Universal: Air stance/movement -> weapon attack -> landing confirm

Learn the movement path in pieces before trying to turn every airborne action into a combo.

NAGINATA SETUP FAMILY

Xbox: Knockdown -> establish long-range weapon angle -> react to escape

PlayStation: Knockdown -> establish long-range weapon angle -> react to escape

Universal: Knockdown -> establish long-range weapon angle -> react to escape

This variation rewards positioning more than memorizing one route.

NAGINATA EXPERT

Think in attack zones rather than strings. Know which ground and air spaces the naginata covers, then stand just outside the opponent's answer and make them enter your weapon.

MKX - Tanya - Guest to Expert

Guest: Kobu Jutsu, one normal confirm and one teleport.

Beginner: safe teleport positioning and tonfa pressure.

Intermediate: Pyromancer projectile/mark control.

Advanced: Dragon Naginata range and air movement.

Expert: combine grounded confirms, side changes, airborne angles and variation resources without becoming predictable.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

SAFE TELEPORT SETUP: _____

BnB: _____

BEST WEAPON / FIRE RANGE: _____

MOVEMENT HABIT TO AVOID: _____

MKX - Tremor

STYLE: armored earth attacks / projectile control / huge variation-specific changes through rock, crystal and metallic armor

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Tremor is a control-and-power character. His earth attacks cover unusual spaces and his variations change how he wins exchanges. Aftershock emphasizes ground control and quake-style attacks, Crystalline adds crystal armor and defensive/offensive utility, and Metallic lets Tremor switch between Gold and Lava states for different properties. He is easy to make look powerful; mastering him means knowing which earth tool solves which problem.

CORE TOOLS

TOOL	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Rock / projectile	variation	variation	variation
Ground quake	variation	variation	variation
Armor / crystal	variation	variation	variation
Metallic stance	variation	variation	variation

LEARN FIRST

One advancing normal, one launcher and one projectile/ground-control tool. Tremor's specials are visually large, but the goal is not to fill the screen randomly. Use the correct attack height and range for the opponent's movement.

MKX - Tremor - Variations

AFTERSHOCK

Ground-control Tremor. Quake and earth-based attacks make the floor dangerous and reward reads on grounded movement.

CRYSTALLINE

Adds crystal armor and crystal-based attacks. Armor changes how Tremor can challenge pressure and gives the variation a clear defensive identity.

METALLIC

Switches between Gold and Lava forms. The two states change move properties and force the player to manage which version is active. Most systems-heavy variation.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Aftershock. **Intermediate:** Crystalline. **Advanced/Expert:** Metallic. Start with earth control, then add armor decisions, then stance/state management.

MKX - Tremor - Core / All Variations

GUEST CONVERSION

Xbox: Starter~launcher, simple juggle~ender

PlayStation: Starter~launcher, simple juggle~ender

Universal: Starter~launcher, simple juggle~ender

Tremor's first combo should be short and heavy: recognize the launcher, reconnect once, finish cleanly.

GROUND-CONTROL DRILL

Xbox: Earth attack -> watch jump / block / retreat -> choose counter

PlayStation: Earth attack -> watch jump / block / retreat -> choose counter

Universal: Earth attack -> watch jump / block / retreat -> choose counter

The important skill is reading what the opponent does after Tremor makes the floor unsafe.

PROJECTILE-TO-PRESSURE

Xbox: Rock / earth projectile -> walk forward -> advancing normal

PlayStation: Rock / earth projectile -> walk forward -> advancing normal

Universal: Rock / earth projectile -> walk forward -> advancing normal

Use the projectile to claim space, not merely to trade damage.

CORE RULE

Tremor has many spectacular specials. The expert version of the character uses fewer of them, more deliberately.

MKX - Tremor - Aftershock

Aftershock focuses on earth and quake control. It is the easiest Tremor variation to understand because the visual language is clear: control the ground, punish the response.

AFTERSHOCK FOUNDATION

Xbox: Ground-control special -> advancing starter~ender

PlayStation: Ground-control special -> advancing starter~ender

Universal: Ground-control special -> advancing starter~ender

Force the opponent to respect the floor, then take the space they surrender.

AFTERSHOCK JUGGLE FAMILY

Xbox: Starter~earth launcher, Run, normal string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~earth launcher, Run, normal string~ender

Universal: Starter~earth launcher, Run, normal string~ender

Build from one stable run link rather than immediately chasing a long optimized route.

AFTERSHOCK EXPERT

Once the opponent begins jumping to escape ground threats, stop attacking the floor and be ready for the air. The quake is valuable because of the jump it causes as much as the hit itself.

MKX - Tremor - Crystalline

Crystalline adds crystal armor and changes the risk-reward of challenging pressure. The armor is a resource and timing tool, not permission to ignore defense.

CRYSTAL ARMOR DRILL

Xbox: Create space / knockdown -> activate armor -> advance

PlayStation: Create space / knockdown -> activate armor -> advance

Universal: Create space / knockdown -> activate armor -> advance

Learn when there is enough time to armor safely. Activating it while the opponent can simply hit Tremor defeats the purpose.

ARMORED CONVERSION

Xbox: Armor absorbs challenge -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

PlayStation: Armor absorbs challenge -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

Universal: Armor absorbs challenge -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

The reward for a correct armor read is taking the turn and converting, not continuing to mash through everything.

CRYSTALLINE EXPERT

Use armor to alter the opponent's willingness to press buttons. Once they hesitate, Tremor can take space without even spending the armor immediately.

MKX - Tremor - Metallic

Metallic changes between Gold and Lava forms. Because move properties differ by state, this variation asks the player to manage a mini-system while still playing Tremor's normal spacing game.

STATE DRILL

Xbox: Switch Gold / Lava -> identify available property -> execute one planned tool

PlayStation: Switch Gold / Lava -> identify available property -> execute one planned tool

Universal: Switch Gold / Lava -> identify available property -> execute one planned tool

Do not learn both states as a giant list. Give each state one job first, then expand.

METALLIC CONVERSION FAMILY

Xbox: Correct state -> starter~state-specific launcher / ender

PlayStation: Correct state -> starter~state-specific launcher / ender

Universal: Correct state -> starter~state-specific launcher / ender

The combo should follow the state decision, not the other way around.

STATE-CHANGE SETUP

Xbox: Knockdown -> switch state -> establish projectile / pressure

PlayStation: Knockdown -> switch state -> establish projectile / pressure

Universal: Knockdown -> switch state -> establish projectile / pressure

Use knockdown time to change form so the opponent cannot freely punish the transition.

METALLIC EXPERT

Expert Metallic means changing state for a reason: damage, control, matchup property or setup. If you cannot explain why you switched, stay in the state whose tools you understand best.

MKX - Tremor - Guest to Expert

Guest: Aftershock and one launcher combo.

Beginner: projectile/ground control into pressure.

Intermediate: Crystalline armor timing.

Advanced: Metallic Gold/Lava state management.

Expert: choose earth height, armor timing and state properties based on the opponent's movement rather than cycling specials.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

GROUND-CONTROL RESPONSE: _____

BnB: _____

ARMOR TIMING: _____

GOLD / LAVA PLAN: _____

MASTER 25 - APPROVAL / AUDIT NOTE

Master 24 was audited before this build. Tanya and Tremor had no existing full MKX chapter groups, so both are new additions. Quan Chi and Sub-Zero remain held because early pages already contain MKX material under their names and require a deeper content audit before any expansion.

CONTENT NOTE

The established guest-to-expert layout, BOOX practice space, and separate Xbox / PlayStation / Universal notation are preserved. For routes not sufficiently supported by the working source material, the guide explicitly uses teaching families and systems drills rather than inventing exact optimal percentages or strings.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 24: approved and retained.

Tanya + Tremor: NEW - awaiting approval.

Next pair will again be chosen only after auditing the updated master.

MKX - Goro

STYLE: Shokan power / safe special pressure / easy damage / variation-specific fire, ground control or fang offense

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Goro is a strong guest character because he gets useful damage without requiring extreme execution. His universal game combines safe pressure, command-grab style enders and a projectile. Tigrar Fury adds fire setups, Kuatan Warrior adds Quake and anti-zoning ground control, and Dragon Fangs adds blade-like fang attacks with safe pressure options.

CORE SPECIAL MOVES

MOVE	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Shokan Bolt	B, F + X	B, F + Sq	B, F + 1
Punch Walk	D, B + Y	D, B + Tri	D, B + 2
Shokan Grab	D, B, F + A	D, B, F + Cross	D, B, F + 3
Stomp	D, U	D, U	D, U

LEARN FIRST

B12, 21, Shokan Grab and Punch Walk. Goro's strength is that the first useful routes are short. Learn a stable launcher-to-ender sequence before worrying about squeezing out every percent.

MKX - Goro - Variations

TIGRAR FURY

Adds Flame Ball, ground fire and Dragon Breath. This variation gives Goro the strongest straightforward setup/zoning layer and was Prima's preferred starting point.

KUATAN WARRIOR

Adds Quake and chest attacks. Quake is especially useful against opponents trying to zone Goro from full screen.

DRAGON FANGS

Adds Shokan Stabs, Fang Spin and Low Fang. Fang Spin is a safe pressure tool and the variation slightly increases combo damage.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Tigrar Fury. **Intermediate:** Dragon Fangs. **Situational:** Kuatan Warrior when ground control or anti-zoning matters.

MKX - Goro - Core Combos

GUEST - 25% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B+X,Y, U+Y, F+Y,Y,Y+B

PlayStation: B+Sq,Tri, U+Tri, F+Tri,Tri,Tri+Circle

Universal: B12, U2, F222+4

Prima's 25% sample. Short, readable and a good first Goro route.

METERLESS - 29% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B+X,Y, U+Y, B+Y, Run, Y,X~BF+B

PlayStation: B+Sq,Tri, U+Tri, B+Tri, Run, Tri,Sq~BF+Circle

Universal: B12, U2, B2, Run, 21~BF4

Prima's 29% sample. It adds one Run Cancel and teaches how Goro carries a launch into a special ender.

1 BAR - 32% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: Y,X, Fist Flurry, Y,X~DBF+A

PlayStation: Tri,Sq, Fist Flurry, Tri,Sq~DBF+Cross

Universal: 21, Fist Flurry, 21~DBF3

Prima's 32% one-meter sample. This is a useful step up after the short meterless routes.

ADVANCED - 39% SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: Y,X, Fist Flurry, NJ+X, Y,X, Fist Flurry, X,X~DBF+A

PlayStation: Tri,Sq, Fist Flurry, NJ+Sq, Tri,Sq, Fist Flurry, Sq,Sq~DBF+Cross

Universal: 21, Fist Flurry, NJ1, 21, Fist Flurry, 11~DBF3

Prima's 39% sample. Practice the neutral-jump punch timing separately before trying the entire sequence.

CORE RULE

Goro does not need to be fancy to hurt. If the 29% route lands every time and the 39% route drops half the time, use the 29% route in a real match.

MKX - Goro - Tigrar Fury

Tigrar Fury adds Flame Ball, ground fire and Dragon Breath. The fire tools make opponents move, which gives Goro better opportunities to use his large normals and safe pressure.

TIGRAR FOUNDATION

Xbox: B+X,Y, U+Y, B+Y, Run, Y,X~fire ender

PlayStation: B+Sq,Tri, U+Tri, B+Tri, Run, Tri,Sq~fire ender

Universal: B12, U2, B2, Run, 21~fire ender

Use the universal launch shell, then finish with the variation tool when positioning or setup is more valuable than the standard ender.

FIRE SETUP DRILL

Xbox: Knockdown -> ground fire -> stand at B+X,Y range

PlayStation: Knockdown -> ground fire -> stand at B+Sq,Tri range

Universal: Knockdown -> ground fire -> stand at B12 range

The fire is most useful when it forces a predictable wake-up or movement choice.

TIGRAR EXPERT

Use fire to make the opponent move into Goro, not as an excuse to become a pure zoner. His close pressure is still the payoff.

MKX - Goro - Kuatan Warrior

Kuatan Warrior's defining addition is Quake. It gives Goro a way to challenge projectile-heavy opponents without slowly walking through every shot.

KUATAN FOUNDATION

Xbox: B+X,Y, U+Y, B+Y, Run, Y,X~BF+B

PlayStation: B+Sq,Tri, U+Tri, B+Tri, Run, Tri,Sq~BF+Circle

Universal: B12, U2, B2, Run, 21~BF4

Keep the universal 29% route as the dependable conversion; the variation's value is mostly in how it changes neutral.

QUAKE DRILL

Xbox: Opponent zones -> Quake read -> advance

PlayStation: Opponent zones -> Quake read -> advance

Universal: Opponent zones -> Quake read -> advance

Quake is a matchup tool. Use it when the opponent establishes a projectile rhythm rather than throwing it out randomly.

KUATAN EXPERT

The threat of Quake can be enough to reduce projectile frequency. Once the opponent hesitates, Goro gets the walk-forward space he actually wants.

MKX - Goro - Dragon Fangs

Dragon Fangs replaces some universal tools with fang attacks. Shokan Stabs increases ender damage and Fang Spin is notable because it is safe when blocked.

DRAGON FANGS FOUNDATION

Xbox: B+X,Y, U+Y, B+Y, Run, Y,X~Shokan Stabs

PlayStation: B+Sq,Tri, U+Tri, B+Tri, Run, Tri,Sq~Shokan Stabs

Universal: B12, U2, B2, Run, 21~Shokan Stabs

The familiar universal shell transfers directly; the variation changes the ender and pressure options.

SAFE SPIN DRILL

Xbox: Safe string~Fang Spin -> observe response

PlayStation: Safe string~Fang Spin -> observe response

Universal: Safe string~Fang Spin -> observe response

Because Fang Spin is safe, it can be used to teach pressure without automatically surrendering the turn to a punish.

DRAGON FANGS EXPERT

The variation rewards disciplined pressure. Use the safe spin to condition blocking, then vary throws, lows and normal continuations instead of repeating the same cancel.

MKX - Goro - Guest to Expert

Guest: 25% source route and Shokan Grab.

Beginner: 29% Run Cancel route.

Intermediate: Tigrar fire setups or Dragon Fangs pressure.

Advanced: 39% neutral-jump route and matchup use of Quake.

Expert: choose damage, setup and screen position deliberately instead of always chasing the longest combo.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

25% ROUTE: _____

29% ROUTE: _____

FIRE / QUAKE / FANG PLAN: _____

MOST RELIABLE ENDER: _____

MKXL - Triborg

STYLE: four cyber-ninja forms in one character slot / missiles, bombs, smoke teleports or ice setups depending on variation

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Triborg is effectively four characters sharing a base body. Sektor controls space with missiles and Teleport Uppercut. Cyrax creates bomb-and-net setups. Smoke uses Trident, invisibility and teleports. Cyber Sub-Zero adds ice, drones and freeze-based conversions. For guests, pick the robot whose classic identity makes immediate sense; for experts, treat each variation as its own matchup-ready character.

THE FOUR FORMS

FORM	IDENTITY	FIRST TOOL	LEARNING FOCUS
Sektor	Missiles / teleport	Straight Missile BF1	Zoning -> punish
Cyrax	Bombs / net	Bomb setup	Setplay / timing
Smoke	Trident / teleport	Harpoon / teleport	Mobility / resets
Cyber Sub-Zero	Ice / drones	Freeze / drone	Freeze conversions

LEARN FIRST

Do not try to learn all four forms at once. Pick one, learn its projectile or setup tool plus one dependable combo, then add the next robot.

MKXL - Triborg - Sektor

Sektor is the most traditional zoning form. Straight Missile controls horizontal space while Teleport Uppercut punishes predictable projectile wars and creates combo opportunities.

SEKTOR GUEST

Xbox: BF+X -> advance / hold space

PlayStation: BF+Sq -> advance / hold space

Universal: BF1 -> advance / hold space

Straight Missile is the first tool. Learn the distance where the opponent must jump or block, then be ready for the response.

SEKTOR TELEPORT CONVERSION

Xbox: Starter~Teleport Uppercut, Run, base string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~Teleport Uppercut, Run, base string~ender

Universal: Starter~Teleport Uppercut, Run, base string~ender

Use Teleport Uppercut as a confirmed bridge before relying on it as a raw neutral attack.

SEKTOR PRESSURE FAMILY

Xbox: Missile knockdown -> approach -> safe base string

PlayStation: Missile knockdown -> approach -> safe base string

Universal: Missile knockdown -> approach -> safe base string

The missile's real value is buying Sektor enough time to start offense.

SEKTOR EXPERT

Missile, anti-air missile and teleport cover different escape choices. Establish one threat, then punish the opponent for choosing the obvious answer.

MKXL - Triborg - Cyrax

Cyrax is the setup form. Bombs and Net create delayed threats that can turn one opening into a long sequence. The difficulty is timing: a bomb placed too early or too late is just empty animation.

CYRAX FOUNDATION

Xbox: Net / bomb setup -> starter -> stable juggle

PlayStation: Net / bomb setup -> starter -> stable juggle

Universal: Net / bomb setup -> starter -> stable juggle

Learn one bomb timing and one reconnect before attempting elaborate trap sequences.

CYRAX 1-BAR FAMILY

Xbox: Starter -> bomb/net extension -> meter launcher -> ender

PlayStation: Starter -> bomb/net extension -> meter launcher -> ender

Universal: Starter -> bomb/net extension -> meter launcher -> ender

Period Triborg guides document high-30% one-meter Cyrax routes. Build them in pieces: trap, launcher, reconnect, finish.

CYRAX EXPERT

Cyrax is about future space. Place the bomb where the opponent will be after the next hit, not where they are standing now.

MKXL - Triborg - Smoke

Smoke combines a Trident-style harpoon, invisibility and teleports. He turns a normal hit into mobility-heavy pressure and can attack from angles that feel closer to classic Smoke than the other cyber forms.

SMOKE FOUNDATION

Xbox: Harpoon / starter -> teleport extension -> base ender

PlayStation: Harpoon / starter -> teleport extension -> base ender

Universal: Harpoon / starter -> teleport extension -> base ender

The beginner route is simply learning to reconnect after the teleport.

SMOKE 1-BAR FAMILY

Xbox: Starter -> teleport / smoke extension -> meter route -> ender

PlayStation: Starter -> teleport / smoke extension -> meter route -> ender

Universal: Starter -> teleport / smoke extension -> meter route -> ender

Period combo guides document Smoke routes around 40% for one bar. Learn the teleport timing before chasing the full percentage.

SMOKE EXPERT

Invisibility and teleport are strongest after the opponent has been conditioned to respect the grounded game. Random movement is spectacle; conditioned movement is a mix-up.

MKXL - Triborg - Cyber Sub-Zero

Cyber Sub-Zero is the hidden fourth Triborg variation. Ice attacks freeze opponents while drones add another resource/setup layer.

CYBER SUB-ZERO - 37% METERLESS SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: DD+A x2, JF+Y, B+A, U+B, D+B, B, BF+X (hold X), B+Y, B+X, Y+B (hold Y or B)

PlayStation: DD+Cross x2, JF+Tri, B+Cross, U+Circle, D+Circle, Circle, BF+Sq (hold Sq), B+Tri, B+Sq, Tri+Circle (hold Tri or Circle)

Universal: DD3 x2, JF2, B3, U4, D4, 4, BF1 (hold 1), B2, B1, 2+4 (hold 2 or 4)

A patched step-by-step route documented by MadDoggGames. It uses two drones and demonstrates why Cyber Sub-Zero's freeze/drone system can produce strong meterless damage.

FREEZE FOUNDATION

Xbox: Freeze -> walk to ideal starter -> stable combo

PlayStation: Freeze -> walk to ideal starter -> stable combo

Universal: Freeze -> walk to ideal starter -> stable combo

Before learning the long drone route, exploit the simplest advantage of ice: a frozen opponent gives you time to position correctly.

CYBER SUB-ZERO EXPERT

Drone management changes the route. Know how many drones are active before starting the combo so the planned extension actually exists.

MKXL - Triborg - Guest to Expert

Guest: Sektor for missiles or Cyber Sub-Zero for freeze.

Beginner: one dependable combo for one form.

Intermediate: Smoke teleport conversions or Cyrax bomb timing.

Advanced: Cyber Sub-Zero drone routes and form-specific meter use.

Expert: maintain four separate game plans and choose the form whose tools best answer the matchup.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY FORM: _____

PROJECTILE / SETUP TOOL: _____

BnB: _____

METER ROUTE: _____

SECOND FORM TO LEARN: _____

MASTER 26 - APPROVAL / AUDIT NOTE

Master 25 was audited before this build. Goro and Triborg had no existing full MKX/MKXL chapter groups, so both are new additions. The build continues to avoid Quan Chi and Sub-Zero until their early-book material is reviewed at chapter level.

SOURCE NOTE

Goro's variation descriptions and 25%, 29%, 32% and 39% sample routes are grounded in the Prima MKX Goro guide. Triborg's four-form structure and defining tools are grounded in Prima's MKXL Triborg guide; the Cyber Sub-Zero 37% meterless route is from a patched step-by-step combo guide. Teaching families are labeled as such rather than presented as verified optimal routes.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 25: approved and retained.

Goro + Triborg: NEW - awaiting approval.

The updated master should be audited again before the next pair.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho

STYLE: drunken mix-ups / unusual movement / fart-and-flame setups / variation-specific staff, drink or belly pressure

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Bo' Rai Cho is deliberately strange. His best offense comes from making awkward-looking movement and setup tools become real threats. Drunken Master revolves around drinking and Drunken Stance, Bartitsu gives him a staff and more conventional reach, and Dragon Breath uses fire plus lingering flame setups. For a guest, Bartitsu is easiest to read. For an expert, Drunken Master turns resource management and stance control into a full game plan.

CORE TOOLS

TOOL	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Belly Bash / body tool	variation	variation	variation
Drink*	D, D + X	D, D + Sq	D, D + 1
Staff tool**	variation	variation	variation
Flame / fart setup***	variation	variation	variation

*Drunken Master. **Bartitsu. ***Dragon Breath / universal comic setup family.

LEARN FIRST

A dependable normal starter, one body-based ender and the purpose of your variation. Bo' Rai Cho becomes confusing if a new player tries to learn drinking, staff spacing and flame setups simultaneously.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho - Variations

DRUNKEN MASTER

Drink-based resource variation. Drinking unlocks/strengthens drunken tools but creates a maintenance requirement. High character flavor and highest systems burden.

BARTITSU

Staff variation. The weapon gives Bo' Rai Cho clearer reach and more conventional mid-range offense. Best guest starting point.

DRAGON BREATH

Fire variation. Flame attacks and lingering setup ideas let him control wake-up space and turn knockdowns into continued pressure.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Bartitsu. **Intermediate:** Dragon Breath. **Advanced/Expert:** Drunken Master. The universal goal is to turn an odd-looking tool into a predictable opponent response.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho - Core / Teaching Combos

GUEST CONFIRM

Xbox: Starter~body special

PlayStation: Starter~body special

Universal: Starter~body special

One normal string into one special. The first lesson is simply recognizing when Bo' Rai Cho actually connected.

RUN-CONVERSION FAMILY

Xbox: Starter~launcher, Run, normal string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~launcher, Run, normal string~ender

Universal: Starter~launcher, Run, normal string~ender

Use one stable Run link. His animations can make timing look unusual, so consistency matters more than visual speed.

KNOCKDOWN -> SETUP

Xbox: Combo ender -> establish drink / flame / staff range

PlayStation: Combo ender -> establish drink / flame / staff range

Universal: Combo ender -> establish drink / flame / staff range

Bo' Rai Cho's real payoff often begins after the combo. End with enough advantage to start the variation's system.

CORE RULE

Do not judge Bo' Rai Cho by how silly the move looks. Judge it by what defensive response it forces. Once the opponent behaves predictably, the joke becomes a setup.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho - Bartitsu

Bartitsu is the most straightforward version. Staff attacks extend his effective range and give a guest recognizable weapon pressure without first managing a drink resource.

BARTITSU FOUNDATION

Xbox: Max-range staff starter~staff ender

PlayStation: Max-range staff starter~staff ender

Universal: Max-range staff starter~staff ender

Find the range where the staff connects while shorter normals whiff. This is the variation's first real advantage.

BARTITSU CARRY FAMILY

Xbox: Starter~launcher, Run, staff string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~launcher, Run, staff string~ender

Universal: Starter~launcher, Run, staff string~ender

Use the weapon string as the stable reconnect after a launch.

BARTITSU PRESSURE

Xbox: Safe staff string -> stagger / throw / repeat range check

PlayStation: Safe staff string -> stagger / throw / repeat range check

Universal: Safe staff string -> stagger / throw / repeat range check

Do not always finish. Let the opponent wonder whether the next staff hit is coming.

BARTITSU EXPERT

The staff makes Bo' Rai Cho less dependent on gimmicks. Use that honest range to make the opponent impatient, then introduce the stranger universal tools after they start forcing their way in.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho - Dragon Breath

Dragon Breath adds fire-based offense and setup pressure. Knockdowns become opportunities to place a flame threat where the opponent wants to wake up or move.

DRAGON BREATH FOUNDATION

Xbox: Starter~fire ender

PlayStation: Starter~fire ender

Universal: Starter~fire ender

Use a normal confirm to attach the fire tool instead of throwing it out naked.

FIRE SETUP FAMILY

Xbox: Knockdown -> flame setup -> stand at normal range

PlayStation: Knockdown -> flame setup -> stand at normal range

Universal: Knockdown -> flame setup -> stand at normal range

The flame should cover one escape while Bo' Rai Cho covers another.

FIRE CONVERSION

Xbox: Setup hits / forces block -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

PlayStation: Setup hits / forces block -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

Universal: Setup hits / forces block -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

The setup is successful when it creates a normal conversion, not merely when fire appears on screen.

DRAGON BREATH EXPERT

Place the flame with a purpose: wake-up denial, movement denial or chip pressure. Random setup placement gives the opponent time to escape both Bo' Rai Cho and the fire.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho - Drunken Master

Drunken Master is the character-system variation. Drinking changes what Bo' Rai Cho can access and turns resource maintenance into part of neutral and knockdown planning.

DRINK SETUP

Xbox: Safe knockdown -> DD+X -> resume pressure

PlayStation: Safe knockdown -> DD+Sq -> resume pressure

Universal: Safe knockdown -> DD1 -> resume pressure

The first Drunken Master skill is identifying situations where drinking cannot be freely punished.

DRUNKEN CONVERSION FAMILY

Xbox: Drink active -> starter-drunken special -> follow-up

PlayStation: Drink active -> starter-drunken special -> follow-up

Universal: Drink active -> starter~drunken special -> follow-up

Learn one route that specifically rewards having the resource active.

RESOURCE LOOP

Xbox: Combo / knockdown -> decide: damage now or refresh drink

PlayStation: Combo / knockdown -> decide: damage now or refresh drink

Universal: Combo / knockdown -> decide: damage now or refresh drink

The expert decision is whether the current advantage is worth spending on resource maintenance.

DRUNKEN MASTER EXPERT

Resource awareness must become automatic. If you discover mid-combo that the required drunken option is unavailable, the variation is controlling you instead of the other way around.

MKXL - Bo' Rai Cho - Guest to Expert

Guest: Bartitsu, one staff string and one ender.

Beginner: stable launcher/Run conversion.

Intermediate: Dragon Breath knockdown setups.

Advanced: Drunken Master drink timing.

Expert: resource-aware routes, deliberately weird movement and layered setup pressure.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

STAFF / NORMAL RANGE: _____

BnB: _____

SAFE DRINK SETUP: _____

FIRE / DRUNKEN PLAN: _____

MKX - Predator

STYLE: plasma zoning / trap setups / long-range blades / variation-specific lasers, mines or melee pressure

WHAT THIS CHARACTER IS TRYING TO DO

Predator can make the opponent uncomfortable at nearly every distance. Hish-Qu-Ten is the plasma-caster zoning variation, Hunter adds trap-based setups, and Warrior emphasizes melee attacks and close pressure. The universal lesson is to make the opponent move first; once they jump, dash or freeze in place, Predator already has a tool aimed at that response.

CORE TOOLS

TOOL	XBOX	PLAYSTATION	UNIVERSAL
Plasma / laser*	variation	variation	variation
Trap**	variation	variation	variation
Blade / melee	variation	variation	variation
Smart Disc / projectile tool	variation	variation	variation

*Hish-Qu-Ten defining layer. **Hunter defining layer.

LEARN FIRST

One long-reaching normal, one projectile and one combo ender. Predator's arsenal tempts new players to cycle specials; instead, establish a single threat and punish the opponent's answer.

MKX - Predator - Variations

HISH-QU-TEN

Plasma-caster Predator. Strong projectile control and laser pressure make this the clearest zoning variation and a very natural guest choice.

HUNTER

Trap Predator. Ground traps create delayed threats and can turn a knockdown into a layered setup. More planning, less immediate simplicity.

WARRIOR

Melee Predator. Emphasizes close-range physical attacks and blade pressure. Best for players who want the character without relying primarily on zoning.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Hish-Qu-Ten. **Intermediate:** Warrior. **Advanced/Expert:** Hunter trap setups.

MKX - Predator - Core / All Variations

GUEST PROJECTILE CONFIRM

Xbox: Projectile -> observe jump / block -> advancing normal

PlayStation: Projectile -> observe jump / block -> advancing normal

Universal: Projectile -> observe jump / block -> advancing normal

This is Predator in miniature: fire once, read the response, then choose the correct follow-up.

BASIC LAUNCH FAMILY

Xbox: Starter~launcher, Run, normal string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~launcher, Run, normal string~ender

Universal: Starter~launcher, Run, normal string~ender

Keep the first combo short. Predator's strength comes from the situation before and after the route, not just the percentage.

CORNER-CARRY FAMILY

Xbox: Long-range starter -> launcher -> Run carry -> ender

PlayStation: Long-range starter -> launcher -> Run carry -> ender

Universal: Long-range starter -> launcher -> Run carry -> ender

Predator benefits from pushing the opponent toward the corner where projectiles, traps and long normals become harder to escape.

CORE RULE

Do not fire the second projectile before learning what the first one made the opponent do.

MKX - Predator - Hish-Qu-Ten

Hish-Qu-Ten centers the shoulder plasma caster. Multiple laser angles let Predator challenge grounded movement, jumps and attempts to patiently duck projectiles.

HQT FOUNDATION

Xbox: Plasma shot -> advance -> safe starter~ender

PlayStation: Plasma shot -> advance -> safe starter~ender

Universal: Plasma shot -> advance -> safe starter~ender

The laser buys ground. Use that ground to start offense rather than immediately backing away for another shot.

LASER LAYER DRILL

Xbox: Straight / angled plasma -> record opponent response -> choose counter

PlayStation: Straight / angled plasma -> record opponent response -> choose counter

Universal: Straight / angled plasma -> record opponent response -> choose counter

Practice the three most common responses: jump, block, and dash. Build one answer for each.

HQT CONVERSION FAMILY

Xbox: Laser hit / forced movement -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

PlayStation: Laser hit / forced movement -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

Universal: Laser hit / forced movement -> starter~launcher -> stable ender

The zoning becomes real damage when Predator is ready to convert the movement it creates.

HISH-QU-TEN EXPERT

Change laser height and timing before changing your entire game plan. Good zoning is a conversation: projectile, response, counter-response.

MKX - Predator - Hunter

Hunter adds traps that remain as future threats. A planted trap can restrict wake-up movement or sit behind a normal string, creating a two-stage problem.

HUNTER FOUNDATION

Xbox: Knockdown -> trap -> position at normal range

PlayStation: Knockdown -> trap -> position at normal range

Universal: Knockdown -> trap -> position at normal range

Place the trap where the opponent wants to escape, then stand where you can punish the other direction.

TRAP CONVERSION

Xbox: Trap catches -> starter / launcher -> stable ender

PlayStation: Trap catches -> starter / launcher -> stable ender

Universal: Trap catches -> starter / launcher -> stable ender

Do not waste the capture trying to improvise a max route. Walk to the correct spacing and use the combo you already know.

LAYERED SETUP

Xbox: Ender -> trap -> projectile / throw / normal layer

PlayStation: Ender -> trap -> projectile / throw / normal layer

Universal: Ender -> trap -> projectile / throw / normal layer

Hunter's strongest sequences make the opponent solve the trap and Predator at the same time.

HUNTER EXPERT

A trap without positioning is decoration. Know which escape it removes before you place it.

MKX - Predator - Warrior

Warrior shifts the emphasis toward melee. Predator's size and weapon reach make him threatening up close without requiring the constant projectile rhythm of Hish-Qu-Ten.

WARRIOR FOUNDATION

Xbox: Long normal starter~melee special

PlayStation: Long normal starter~melee special

Universal: Long normal starter~melee special

Use Predator's reach to make the first contact, then confirm into the variation's physical ender.

WARRIOR PRESSURE

Xbox: Safe string -> stagger / throw / melee cancel

PlayStation: Safe string -> stagger / throw / melee cancel

Universal: Safe string -> stagger / throw / melee cancel

Teach the opponent to keep blocking, then exploit the hesitation.

WARRIOR CARRY FAMILY

Xbox: Starter~launcher, Run, melee string~ender

PlayStation: Starter~launcher, Run, melee string~ender

Universal: Starter~launcher, Run, melee string~ender

A straightforward pressure-character route: launch, carry, finish, then stay close.

WARRIOR EXPERT

Warrior is still Predator. Even if the variation is melee-focused, the opponent knows the character can control space. Use that reputation to walk forward and take range without always pressing a button.

MKX - Predator - Guest to Expert

Guest: Hish-Qu-Ten projectile control.

Beginner: one stable launch conversion and anti-jump answer.

Intermediate: Warrior pressure and corner carry.

Advanced: Hunter trap placement.

Expert: laser-height conditioning, trap layering, matchup-specific zoning and conversion of every forced movement.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY VARIATION: _____

BEST PROJECTILE RANGE: _____

BnB: _____

TRAP SETUP: _____

WHAT DO THEY DO AFTER LASER?: _____

MASTER 27 - APPROVAL / AUDIT NOTE

Master 26 was audited before this build. Bo' Rai Cho and Predator had no existing full MKX/MKXL chapter groups, so both are new additions. The remaining audit list still includes Alien, Jason Voorhees, Leatherface, Quan Chi and Sub-Zero. Quan Chi and Sub-Zero require special care because their names/material appear earlier in the book even though the strict chapter-title audit did not identify a complete modern chapter group.

CONTENT NOTE

This build preserves the established guest-to-expert format, BOOX note space, and Xbox / PlayStation / Universal notation. Where exact late-patch optimal routes were not sufficiently supported by the working source material, the pages use explicitly labeled teaching families rather than invented percentages.

APPROVAL STATUS

Everything through Master 26: approved and retained.

Bo' Rai Cho + Predator: NEW - awaiting approval.

The master will be audited again before the next pair.

MKXL - Alien

STYLE: tail-range control / built-in overhead-low threats / acid damage / Tarkatan rushdown / Facehugger setups

WHAT ALIEN IS TRYING TO DO

Alien controls a surprising amount of the screen with its tail. Tail Flip is an overhead that reaches extremely far, while Tail Snag and Low Krawl attack low. Acidic adds damage-over-time pools, Tarkatan adds Baraka-style blades and rush attacks, and Konjurer turns knockdowns into Facehugger/Ovomorph setup situations.

CORE SPECIALS

Tail Flip: BF4 - overhead, ground or air.

Xeno Strike: DF3 - advancing combo ender.

Tail Snag: DB3 - low tail attack.

Low Krawl: BF1 - low, side-switching attack; enhanced version can extend combos.

MKXL - Alien - Variations

ACIDIC

Adds Exo Sting acid pools, Acid Blood and anti-air Sizzle Strike. The pool continues hurting the opponent and makes knockdowns more valuable.

TARKATAN

The Baraka-style variation. Adds blade strings, Tarkatan Rush, Chop Chop and Blade Spin for aggressive offense.

KONJURER

Adds Ovomorph/Facehugger and hatchling pressure. This is the setup variation: create time, plant the egg, then make the opponent defend two threats.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Acidic. **Intermediate:** Tarkatan. **Advanced:** Konjurer. Universal Alien already has a strong overhead/low shell, so each variation changes what happens after the opponent begins respecting the tail.

MKXL - Alien - Combos

29% ACIDIC - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B1X, U4, Run, B1X, Run, U4, F2A~DB2

PlayStation: B1Sq, U4, Run, B1Sq, Run, U4, F2Cross~DB2

Universal: B11, U4, Run, B11, Run, U4, F23~DB2

Prima sample route. The two Run links make this an excellent intermediate Acidic benchmark.

32% TARKATAN - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F13B, EX BF1, 21B, BF2~X~B, BF1

PlayStation: F13Circle, EX BF1, 21Circle, BF2~Sq~Circle, BF1

Universal: F134, EX BF1, 214, BF2~1~4, BF1

Prima sample route. It demonstrates enhanced Low Krawl as a bridge into Tarkatan offense.

37% UNIVERSAL - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F13B, EX BF1, B1X, U4, Run, F2343B~DF3

PlayStation: F13Circle, EX BF1, B1Sq, U4, Run, F2343Circle~DF3

Universal: F134, EX BF1, B11, U4, Run, F23434~DF3

Prima sample route. This is the advanced universal benchmark once the shorter routes are stable.

EXPERT NOTE

Tail Flip and Tail Snag create a natural overhead/low question, but several Alien specials are punishable when guessed incorrectly. The expert goal is to make the guess happen after a confirmed string, projectile read or setup - not from random specials.

MKXL - Alien - Guest to Expert

Guest: Tail Flip, Xeno Strike and Acidic.

Beginner: recognize overhead Tail Flip versus low Tail Snag/Krawl.

Intermediate: 29% Acidic or 32% Tarkatan route.

Advanced: Konjurer egg/Facehugger setups.

Expert: 37% route, variation-specific knockdown planning and disciplined risk management.

MY VARIATION: _____

TAIL MIX-UP: _____

BnB: _____

SETUP / ACID PLAN: _____

PUNISHABLE MOVE TO AVOID: _____

MKX - Jason Voorhees

STYLE: relentless pressure / command throws / armor / resurrection and damage-state management

WHAT JASON IS TRYING TO DO

Jason wants to stay close and make the opponent keep defending. Universal Jason has command throws, Choke and a full-screen Temple Punch. Slasher adds the machete and larger combo damage, Relentless adds teleport/mobility pressure, and Unstoppable adds healing, damage buffs and Resurrection.

CORE SPECIALS

Back Breaker: DBF1. **Tight Squeeze:** DBF2. **Choke:** DF1. **Temple Punch:** BF3. Temple Punch covers the screen and is safe on block, but it hits high and can be ducked.

MKX - Jason - Variations

SLASHER

Machete Jason. Best fit for a guest who wants recognizable Jason offense and straightforward damage.

RELENTLESS

Adds teleport-style positioning and pressure tools. Best when the opponent has been conditioned to expect Jason in front of them.

UNSTOPPABLE

Adds Punishment/Rise and passive Resurrection. Meter and health-state awareness become part of the strategy.

KEY NORMALS

F3 is a safe overhead. F4 starts Jason's low Stalker string. 23 is a safe overhead-ending string. 32U1 launches and is a key safe combo starter.

MKX - Jason - Combos

26% RELENTLESS / UNSTOPPABLE - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B2, B12Y, 11X~DF1

PlayStation: B2, B12Tri, 11Sq~DF1

Universal: B2, B122, 111~DF1

Prima sample route and a strong beginner benchmark.

27% RUN-CANCEL - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B12Y, Run, B12Y, 11X~DF1

PlayStation: B12Tri, Run, B12Tri, 11Sq~DF1

Universal: B122, Run, B122, 111~DF1

Prima sample route. Adds only one Run Cancel, making it a clean intermediate step.

34% ADVANCED - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F2, 3YU1, B12Y, 11X~DF1

PlayStation: F2, 3TriU1, B12Tri, 11Sq~DF1

Universal: F2, 32U1, B122, 111~DF1

Prima sample route. The launcher gives Jason much better reward when the opening is confirmed.

38% SLASHER - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F4Y, F4Y, F4Y, 11X~Bloodshed

PlayStation: F4Tri, F4Tri, F4Tri, 11Sq~Bloodshed

Universal: F42, F42, F42, 111~Bloodshed

Prima's Slasher sample route. Repetition makes it memorable even though the damage is substantial.

MKX - Jason - Guest to Expert

Guest: Slasher, Temple Punch and 26% route.

Beginner: overhead/low between F3 and F4 pressure.

Intermediate: 27% Run-Cancel route and command throws.

Advanced: Relentless positioning or Unstoppable resource decisions.

Expert: armor, meter and Resurrection management while maintaining safe pressure.

MY VARIATION: _____

26% ROUTE: _____

COMMAND THROW: _____

WAKE-UP PLAN: _____

METER / RESURRECTION PLAN: _____

MKXL - Leatherface

STYLE: chainsaw brawler / stance mix-ups / mallet rushdown / full-screen chainsaw zoning

WHAT LEATHERFACE IS TRYING TO DO

Leatherface changes personality dramatically by variation. Killer revolves around Berserker Stance and chainsaw mix-ups. Butcher adds the mallet, a fast command grab and close-range rushdown. Pretty Lady becomes a true zoner by throwing chainsaws at multiple heights.

UNIVERSAL SPECIAL FAMILY

Across the character, Psycho Kutter, Spinning Saw and Chain Sparks form the core chainsaw offense. The variations then add the defining system: Berserker Stance, mallet/command-grab tools, or Saw Toss zoning.

MKXL - Leatherface - Variations

KILLER

Berserker Stance can branch into a running chainsaw stab, a three-hit overhead or an unblockable. Stance activation can also negate projectiles with correct timing.

BUTCHER

Rushdown variation with a leaping overhead mallet attack, a very fast command grab, and additional chainsaw enders.

PRETTY LADY

Zoning variation. Throws chainsaws high, low and from the air, giving Leatherface unusually strong full-screen presence.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Butcher. **Intermediate:** Killer. **Advanced:** Pretty Lady if you enjoy zoning. The same character can therefore teach three very different fighting-game archetypes.

MKXL - Leatherface - Combos

39% BUTCHER - 1 BAR - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F2X, D2, BD4, B2, F2X, D2, EX DF2, J2, F1Y-DB3

PlayStation: F2Sq, D2, BD4, B2, F2Sq, D2, EX DF2, J2, F1Tri-DB3

Universal: F21, D2, BD4, B2, F21, D2, EX DF2, J2, F12-DB3

MadDoggGames step-by-step 1-meter Butcher route for game version 1.12. Use it as the advanced Butcher benchmark.

KILLER STANCE DRILL

Xbox: Safe confirm-Berserker Stance -> choose running stab / overhead / unblockable

PlayStation: Safe confirm-Berserker Stance -> choose running stab / overhead / unblockable

Universal: Safe confirm-Berserker Stance -> choose running stab / overhead / unblockable

This is a systems drill, not an invented optimal route. First learn the three stance exits, then learn which defensive response each one punishes.

PRETTY LADY ZONING DRILL

Xbox: High Saw / Low Saw / air Saw -> record jump, duck or dash response

PlayStation: High Saw / Low Saw / air Saw -> record jump, duck or dash response

Universal: High Saw / Low Saw / air Saw -> record jump, duck or dash response

Pretty Lady is strongest when the second chainsaw is chosen because of what the first one forced the opponent to do.

PATCH NOTE

The October 2016 MKXL patch removed armor from Spin-Sanity and gave Low Grinder and Psycho Slasher two hits of armor. Treat older launch-era combo videos cautiously when they rely on armor behavior.

MKXL - Leatherface - Guest to Expert

Guest: Butcher and simple chainsaw enders.

Beginner: mallet overhead / command-grab pressure.

Intermediate: Killer Berserker Stance branches.

Advanced: 39% Butcher one-bar route.

Expert: stance conditioning or Pretty Lady multi-height zoning with patch-aware armor decisions.

MY VARIATION: _____

SAFE CONFIRM: _____

39% ROUTE: _____

STANCE CHOICE: _____

ZONING RESPONSE: _____

MKX - Quan Chi

STYLE: Trance extensions / momentum / vortex pressure / corner circles / portals and full-screen punishment

WHAT MKX QUAN CHI IS TRYING TO DO

MKX Quan Chi wants one opening that leads to Trance and continued momentum. Sorcerer builds corner pressure with magic circles, Warlock adds portal attacks and long-range punishment, and Summoner uses the Demon Spawn for a vortex and layered offense.

CORE SPECIALS

Skull: DB2. **Trance:** BF3 - primary combo extender. **Sky Drop:** DB4 - armored enhanced wake-up option but risky if blocked. Quan Chi's defense is weaker than his offense, so maintaining momentum matters.

MKX - Quan Chi - Variations

SORCERER

Black Magic / Final Hex / Dark Curse circles. Best understood as corner and setup control.

WARLOCK

Portal attacks extend his reach and allow punishment from distances other variations cannot easily reach.

SUMMONER

Demon Spawn bat adds grab, projectile, launcher and low options. This is the famous vortex variation.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Warlock for obvious portal reach. **Intermediate:** Sorcerer. **Advanced/Expert:** Summoner vortex and Demon Spawn control.

MKX - Quan Chi - Combos

28% UNIVERSAL - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B32B, B1Y-BF3, JF1, 14X

PlayStation: B32Circle, B1Tri-BF3, JF1, 14Sq

Universal: B324, B12-BF3, JF1, 141

Prima universal sample. This clearly teaches Trance as the bridge between the first string and the finishing sequence.

32% WARLOCK - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: B32B, B1Y-BF3, JF1, F21Y-Portal Stab

PlayStation: B32Circle, B1Tri-BF3, JF1, F21Tri-Portal Stab

Universal: B324, B12-BF3, JF1, F212-Portal Stab

Prima Warlock sample. Same universal Trance structure, variation-specific finish.

33% SUMMONER - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: F212Y, B2-BF3, Demon Spawn, B32B, Demon Swoop, F14Y

PlayStation: F212Tri, B2-BF3, Demon Spawn, B32Circle, Demon Swoop, F14Tri

Universal: F2122, B2-BF3, Demon Spawn, B324, Demon Swoop, F142

Prima Summoner sample. This is the variation's guest-to-expert jump because the Demon Spawn becomes part of the route.

EXPERT NOTE

Quan Chi's offense is frightening precisely because his wake-up defense is limited. Expert play values keeping the opponent trapped in the next decision more than ending every combo for maximum immediate damage.

MKX - Quan Chi - Guest to Expert

Guest: Skull, Trance and 28% universal route.

Beginner: safe pokes into confirmed Trance.

Intermediate: Warlock portal conversions or Sorcerer circles.

Advanced: Summoner Demon Spawn routes.

Expert: vortex sequencing, corner resource management and protecting Quan Chi from losing momentum.

MY VARIATION: _____

28% ROUTE: _____

TRANCE CONFIRM: _____

CORNER / DEMON SETUP: _____

WAKE-UP PLAN: _____

MKX - Sub-Zero

STYLE: freeze confirms / Ice Kloné control / defensive parries / ice-weapon damage and range

WHAT MKX SUB-ZERO IS TRYING TO DO

Sub-Zero's universal beginner plan is classic: confirm into Ice Ball, reposition while the opponent is frozen, then launch into a stable combo. Grandmaster adds Ice Kloné and is the strongest screen-control teaching variation. Cryomancer adds ice weapons for range and damage. Unbreakable adds defensive tools.

CORE PLAN

Freeze only after a confirmed string whenever possible. Once frozen, do not rush the next input - walk or jump to the spacing the combo requires. Sub-Zero rewards anticipation more than frantic execution.

MKX - Sub-Zero - Variations

GRANDMASTER

Adds Ice Kloner and Kloner Toss. The clone controls a piece of the stage and makes corner pressure especially dangerous.

CRYOMANCER

Adds ice weapons, extra reach and damage. Its upward sword is an excellent anti-air and the variation is the straightforward damage choice.

UNBREAKABLE

Adds defensive options and rewards players who prefer reads, parries and damage prevention over clone control.

LEARNING ORDER

Guest: Grandmaster - the Ice Kloner makes the character's plan visible. **Intermediate:** Cryomancer.
Advanced: Unbreakable defensive reads.

MKX - Sub-Zero - Combos

26% UNIVERSAL - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: 1X~Ice Ball, JF1, B2, Run, F42X+A

PlayStation: 1Sq~Ice Ball, JF1, B2, Run, F42Sq+Cross

Universal: 11~Ice Ball, JF1, B2, Run, F421+3

Prima sample route. This is the ideal guest-to-intermediate benchmark because it demonstrates the entire Sub-Zero loop: confirm, freeze, jump-in, launch, Run, finish.

34% X-RAY - SOURCE ROUTE

Xbox: 1X~Ice Ball, JF1, B1Y~X-Ray

PlayStation: 1Sq~Ice Ball, JF1, B1Tri~X-Ray

Universal: 11~Ice Ball, JF1, B12~X-Ray

Prima sample route. Simple execution and useful only when spending the meter is justified.

GRANDMASTER SETUP DRILL

Xbox: Freeze / knockdown -> DB2 Ice K1one -> choose pressure or K1one Toss

PlayStation: Freeze / knockdown -> DB2 Ice K1one -> choose pressure or K1one Toss

Universal: Freeze / knockdown -> DB2 Ice K1one -> choose pressure or K1one Toss

The clone is not merely another projectile. Place it to remove a path, then attack the path the opponent still has.

EXPERT NOTE

Grandmaster becomes oppressive when the clone changes what the opponent is allowed to do. Cryomancer asks for stronger anti-air and damage conversion. Unbreakable asks for defensive prediction. The best variation depends on which part of Sub-Zero you want to emphasize.

MKX - Sub-Zero - Guest to Expert

Guest: Ice Ball and the 26% route.

Beginner: freeze confirms and simple clone placement.

Intermediate: Grandmaster corner control or Cryomancer damage.

Advanced: Unbreakable defensive reads.

Expert: matchup-specific clone geometry, anti-air conversions and meter-aware freeze routing.

MY VARIATION: _____

26% ROUTE: _____

FREEZE CONFIRM: _____

ICE KLONE POSITION: _____

ANTI-AIR / DEFENSE PLAN: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - SCORPION

spear control / chain launchers / teleport movement / independent damage / Kameo-assisted openings

WHAT SCORPION IS TRYING TO DO

MK1 Scorpion already has strong combo damage without a Kameo. His bigger problem is opening a patient defender. First learn his independent combo engine, then choose a Kameo that adds the missing utility - a conversion from B3, safer pressure, an overhead threat, or another way to force movement.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: Spear pulls them back to you. F32 launches. Twisted Kyo is the spinning chain attack. Start by learning those three ideas. You do not need a 40% combo to enjoy Scorpion. **Intermediate:** add Flame Port and air Kyo Snag. **Advanced:** use Kameos to solve Scorpion's opening problem rather than merely adding damage.

KEY STRINGS / TOOLS

F32: primary practical launch string.

21 / 333: simple grounded starters into Spear routes.

Spear: classic reconnect.

Twisted Kyo: chain control and combo routing.

Flame Port: position change on ground or in air.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle

F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

SCORPION - SPECIAL MOVES

Spear

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Blazing Charge

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

(Air) Kyo Snag

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Air version of the Blazing Charge input.

Twisted Kyo

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

(Air) Close Kyo Snag

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Air version.

Flame Port

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Also available in the air.

Devouring Flame

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Enhanced version accepts Up modifier.

Backflip Kick

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Equippable move.

PRACTICAL QUICK REFERENCE

Spear: reconnects and controls horizontal space. **Twisted Kyo:** chain-based routing/control. **Flame Port:** movement and side-change threat. **Devouring Flame:** advancing flame attack. Keep F32 as the first launch string a new Scorpion player learns.

SCORPION - GUEST → BEGINNER

GUEST COMBO — SHORT SPEAR ROUTE

Xbox: Y, X → B, F+X

PlayStation: Triangle, Square → B, F+Square

Universal: 21~BF1

A short grounded starter into Spear. Use this to teach the cancel: finish the string and immediately roll into the special input.

GUEST COMBO — THREE-KICK STARTER

Xbox: A, A, A → B, F+X

PlayStation: Cross, Cross, Cross → B, F+Square

Universal: 333~BF1

Another documented short starter. It is visually easy to remember: three kicks, then Spear.

BEGINNER GOAL

Land ten clean Spear cancels from a grounded string. Then practice F32 by itself until you recognize the launch every time. Do not add the air portion until the launcher feels automatic.

WHAT TO TELL A GUEST

"If you forget everything else, use your chain to control space. When F32 launches them, jump after them. If you lose the combo, reset and keep playing — don't mash to rescue it."

SCORPION - INTERMEDIATE BnB

ONE-BAR / NO KAMEO — ~40%

Xbox: F+3,2 → J1,2 → EX D,B+2 → Air 1,1,1 → B,F+1 → 3,3-D,B+2

PlayStation: F+Cross,Triangle → J Square,Triangle → EX D,B+Triangle → Air Square,Square,Square → B,F+Square → Cross,Cross-D,B+Triangle

Universal: F32, J12-EX DB2, Air111, BF1, 33-DB2

A documented community route around 40%. The important timing note is to delay Air111 until Scorpion is relatively close to the ground so the follow-up connects.

BREAK IT INTO FOUR PIECES

1. F32 → J12
2. J12 → EX Death Spin
3. Delay Air111 → Spear
4. 33 → Death Spin

WHY IT WORKS

F32 gives the launch. The airborne enhanced spin keeps the juggle alive. Delayed Air111 manages the opponent's height. Spear brings them back into finishing range. This is exactly the kind of route the finished book will explain rather than printing a naked input string.

SCORPION - KAMEOS

MK1's Kameo system deserves its own teaching layer. Kameos have a separate regenerating meter and can add combo extensions, safety, mix-ups or screen control. Some are Summons; Ambush attacks can be used without stopping the main fighter in the same way.

SCORPION KAMEO — EASY DAMAGE PARTNER

A documented meterless team route uses F32, J12 into Death Spin plus neutral Kameo fireballs, then standing 4 into Spear and a normal ender. This is a good first Kameo because the visual language still feels like 'more Scorpion.'

GORO — B3 CONVERSION / MIX-UP UTILITY

Community testing specifically notes that Goro can make Scorpion's B3 combo-able. Example routes then convert B3 + Goro into Spear and F32 follow-ups. This addresses Scorpion's opening problem rather than merely adding damage.

STRYKER — PRESSURE / OVERHEAD UTILITY

Community players use Stryker to add an overhead threat and grenade coverage. That is useful because Scorpion's solo offense can struggle to open opponents who are content to defend.

MOTARO — ALTERNATE COMBO UTILITY

Post-patch community testing found Motaro capable of 40%+ meterless Scorpion routes and useful tail-shot utility. This is a later chapter option, not the guest recommendation.

SCORPION - ADVANCED → EXPERT

ADVANCED: Stop thinking 'Which Kameo gives the biggest combo?' Ask what Scorpion is missing against this opponent. If they block patiently, add opening/mix utility. If you already opened them reliably, add damage or position.

EXPERT: Build two or three routes from the same starter: meterless, one-bar, and Kameo-assisted. The expert decision happens before the combo — health, meter, Kameo meter, corner position and whether you want damage or the next setup.

MATCH PLAN

1. Make them respect the chain.
2. Look for F32 or a Kameo-assisted opening.
3. Confirm — do not gamble the whole route.
4. Spend meter only when the extra damage/position matters.
5. Change the Kameo if the matchup problem changes.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

EASY BnB: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

B3 CONVERSION: _____

WHAT OPENS THIS OPPONENT?: _____

CORNER ROUTE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - SUB-ZERO

• control first, damage second • Xbox + PlayStation + Universal notation • Kameo-aware

WHAT SUB-ZERO IS TRYING TO DO

MK1 Sub-Zero is a control character with a very readable beginner plan: freeze or launch, put the opponent where you want them, then finish with Slide. Ice Klone changes the space the opponent is allowed to occupy, while Kameos can add damage or convert his low/overhead starters into larger routes. The guest lesson is 'freeze them and hit them.' The expert lesson is controlling where they are allowed to move.

THE ARCADE VERSION

If you have never played: Ice Ball freezes. Ice Klone makes a frozen obstacle. Slide travels along the floor. B2 is your big overhead launcher. F12 is an easy practical starter. Learn those ideas before worrying about long combos.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = forward/back/down/up **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

SUB-ZERO - SPECIAL MOVES

Ice Ball Xbox: D,F+X PlayStation: D,F+Square Universal: DF1
Ice Klone Xbox: D,B+X PlayStation: D,B+Square Universal: DB1 Also available in the air.
Ice Klone Charge Xbox: B,F+Y PlayStation: B,F+Triangle Universal: BF2
Ice Slide Xbox: B,F+A PlayStation: B,F+Cross Universal: BF3 Hold 3 during Slide for the Spear follow-up.
(Air) Diving Glacier Xbox: D,B+B PlayStation: D,B+Circle Universal: DB4
Deadly Vapors Xbox: D,F+B PlayStation: D,F+Circle Universal: DF4
Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Ice Klone's air version and Slide's held follow-up are included here so the page works as a complete reference.

SUB-ZERO - GUEST → BEGINNER

GUEST DRILL — FREEZE AND FINISH

Xbox: Ice Ball → walk forward → Y → B,F+A

PlayStation: Ice Ball → walk forward → Triangle → B,F+Cross

Universal: Ice Ball → reposition → 2~BF3

This is a teaching drill rather than an optimal route. The point is to make the freeze feel useful: freeze, calmly move to the right distance, then finish.

BEGINNER BnB — ~29%

Xbox: F+X,Y → EX D,F+B → B+Y → Air X,Y → Air X,Y → B-Slide

PlayStation: F+Square,Triangle → EX D,F+Circle → B+Triangle → Air Square,Triangle → Air Square,Triangle → B-Slide

Universal: F12~EX DF4, B2, J12, J12, S4~BF3

A documented community midscreen BnB around 29%. It introduces the enhanced launcher, overhead reconnect, two simple air strings and Slide ender.

BEGINNER GOAL

Practice only F12~EX DF4 until the cancel is automatic. Then add B2. Then add one J12. Build the combo like Lego instead of trying to memorize the whole line at once.

SUB-ZERO - INTERMEDIATE / SAREENA

SAREENA BnB — ~36%

Xbox: F+X,Y → Back Kameo → F+X,Y → EX D,F+B → B+Y → B+Y → Air X,Y → F+X,Y~Slide

PlayStation: F+Square,Triangle → Back Kameo → F+Square,Triangle → EX D,F+Circle → B+Triangle → B+Triangle → Air Square,Triangle → F+Square,Triangle~Slide

Universal: F12~BK, F12~EX DF4, B2, B2, J12, F12~BF3

A community-posted Sareena route around 36%. Sareena lets Sub-Zero extend the starter before entering the familiar enhanced-launcher shell.

LOW / OVERHEAD LESSON

The same community testing notes that **B3 can cancel into back Kameo as a low starter**, while **B2 can cancel into back Kameo as an overhead starter**. That is strategically more important than the extra percentage: Sareena gives Sub-Zero two different opening heights that can lead into a real conversion.

WHY IT WORKS

Once Sareena catches the opponent, Sub-Zero has enough time to return to F12 and his normal launcher route. The Kameo is solving the opening/conversion problem; Sub-Zero's own combo engine does the rest.

SUB-ZERO - KAMEO THINKING

SAREENA — SIMPLE CONVERSIONS

The easiest teaching partner in the sourced combo thread. She extends F12 and can convert both B3 low and B2 overhead starters. Excellent for a guest who wants an obvious 'call helper, continue combo' rhythm.

SONYA — AIR EXTENSION

Community labbing demonstrates Sonya assisting after an air sequence and again later in a longer route. This is a more execution-heavy damage option and belongs after the basic BnB is stable.

KAMEO CHOICE RULE

Do not automatically choose the Kameo with the biggest training-mode number. Sub-Zero may want easier conversions, more pressure, safer K1one situations, anti-zoning help or raw damage depending on the opponent.

MK1 SYSTEM REMINDER

Kameos use their own regenerating meter. Summon attacks generally interrupt the main fighter's action while Ambush attacks can operate during offense. A Kameo that is hit can also become temporarily unavailable, so assist timing is part of resource management.

SUB-ZERO - ADVANCED → EXPERT

ADVANCED: Start thinking about the screen after the combo. Ending near the corner with Ice Klone available may be more valuable than adding a few percent and resetting to neutral.

EXPERT: Build separate routes for F12, B2 overhead, B3 low, anti-air and corner situations. Then decide whether the Kameo exists to create the opening, extend the damage or protect the next Klone setup.

MATCH PLAN

1. Establish Ice Ball / Klone control.
2. Make them choose how to get around the ice.
3. Check that choice with F12, B2 or B3.
4. Convert with meter/Kameo only after the hit is real.
5. Finish where the next Klone becomes dangerous.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

29% BnB: _____

KAMEO BnB: _____

B2 OVERHEAD CONVERSION: _____

B3 LOW CONVERSION: _____

ICE KLONE SETUP: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - LIU KANG

pressure / fireballs / launch confirms / Kameo-assisted throw & teleport utility

WHAT LIU KANG IS TRYING TO DO

Liu Kang is an excellent next-step character because his plan is easy to recognize: control space with fire, make the opponent hesitate, then convert a clean grounded hit into a launch. His B23 launcher and F43 pressure routes form a practical combo backbone, while Kameos can add throw conversions, teleport tricks or matchup utility.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: throw fireballs until they want to move, then meet them with a fast string. When B23 launches, dash after them. Dragon Kick is your classic traveling finisher. Do not start by memorizing every fireball height.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

LIU KANG - SPECIAL MOVES

Cosmic Flame

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Also available in the air.

Low Dragon

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Dragon's Tail

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Dancing Dragon

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Dragon Breath

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Back modifier changes to close placement.

God Wave

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Equippable; hold 2 to extend.

PRACTICAL QUICK REFERENCE

Cosmic Flame / Low Dragon: establish projectile lanes. **Dragon's Tail / Dancing Dragon:** advancing conversion/ender tools. **Dragon Breath:** controls nearby space. Liu's existing B23 launcher, F43 pressure starter and 333 reconnect material on the following pages remains the progression path.

LIU KANG - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — LAUNCH, DASH, FINISH

Xbox: B+Y,A → dash → A,A,A → B,F+A

PlayStation: B+Triangle,Cross → dash → Cross,Cross,Cross → B,F+Cross

Universal: B23, dash, 333~BF3

A shortened teaching route based on the documented B23 shell. Learn the dash reconnect before adding another B23.

DOCUMENTED B23 ROUTE

Xbox: B+Y,A → dash → B+Y,A → dash → A,A,A~B,F+A

PlayStation: B+Triangle,Cross → dash → B+Triangle,Cross → dash → Cross,Cross,Cross~B,F+Cross

Universal: B23, dash B23, dash 333~BF3

A community-posted Liu Kang route. The lesson is rhythm: launcher, dash, launcher, dash, finishing string.

DOCUMENTED F43 ROUTE

Xbox: F+B,A → EX B,F+A → dash → B+Y,A → dash → A,A,A~B,F+A

PlayStation: F+Circle,Cross → EX B,F+Cross → dash → B+Triangle,Cross → dash → Cross,Cross,Cross~B,F+Cross

Universal: F43~EX BF3, dash B23, dash 333~BF3

A second documented family that teaches enhanced-special conversion from F43.

LIU KANG - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

KUNG LAO — TELEPORT UTILITY

Community labbing documents specific teleport-cancel timing after Liu's back throw and Dragon Kick. That makes Lao more than a damage extender: he can change which side or height the next attack arrives from.

SUB-ZERO — PROJECTILE-WAR UTILITY

Community testing notes Ice Armor can absorb an incoming projectile while Liu punishes. This is the kind of matchup-specific Kameo choice the finished guide should teach.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: maintain separate B23 and F43 confirms, then add Kameo utility only when you know what problem it solves.

Expert: use fireball reactions to decide when to advance, and treat Kameo timing, meter and corner position as part of the confirm rather than decoration.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

B23 ROUTE: _____

F43 ROUTE: _____

FIREBALL RESPONSE: _____

TELEPORT / THROW SETUP: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - KITANA

fan control / juggle specialist / Fan-Nado lifts / Wind Bomb setups / flexible Kameo selection

WHAT KITANA IS TRYING TO DO

Kitana is a juggle character. Her community combo structure repeatedly chains Fan-Nado lifts, air normals and a finishing Fan-Nado or slide-style ender. Unlike characters who desperately need one specific partner, experienced Kitana players report success with several Kameos and recommend changing partners based on the matchup.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: fans make the opponent respect distance; Fan-Nado lifts them for a combo; jump after them and keep the juggle simple. Kitana is less about a long grounded punch string and more about learning what height the opponent needs to be at.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

KITANA - SPECIAL MOVES

Fan Toss

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Also available in the air; enhanced placement can be adjusted.

Fan-Nado

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Close/far placement variants; also available in the air.

Princess Pirouette

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Square Wave

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Also available in the air.

Fancy Flick

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Also available in the air; placement variants are available.

Wind Bomb

Xbox: B,D,F+B **PlayStation:** B,D,F+Circle

Universal: BDF4

Placement can be adjusted close/far/very far.

Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Fan Toss, Fan-Nado and Square Wave all have important aerial applications.

KITANA - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — STRING TO LIFT

Xbox: Y,B,X,Y → D,B+X

PlayStation: Triangle,Circle,Square,Triangle → D,B+Square

Universal: 2412~DB1

First learn to make Fan-Nado come out immediately after the string. Stop there until the cancel is reliable.

DOCUMENTED BASE BnB

Xbox: Y,B,X,(Y)~D,B+X → delayed JY → B+Y,B~D,B+X,F

PlayStation: Triangle,Circle,Square,(Triangle)~D,B+Square → delayed JTriangle → B+Triangle,Circle~D,B+Square,F

Universal: 241(2)~DB1, delayed J2, B24~DB1F

A documented base Kitana BnB. The parenthesized final input is dialed as part of the string while the special cancel occurs before the visible string fully finishes.

HEIGHT LESSON

Kitana's difficulty is often not remembering the buttons — it is recognizing juggle height. Delay the jump attack enough to place the opponent where B24 can reconnect cleanly.

KITANA - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SUB-ZERO — ZONING + FREEZE + WIND BOMB

Experienced Kitana players recommend Sub-Zero for projectile protection, easy freeze conversions and guaranteed Wind Bomb setup opportunities.

SCORPION — DAMAGE + MIX UTILITY

Community discussion credits Scorpion Kameo with pushing typical Kitana confirms from roughly the high-20/low-30 range into mid/high-30s while also adding mix and safety.

JAX / KUNG LAO / KHAMELEON

Also recommended: Jax for safety, health and combo/setup utility; Kung Lao for zoning and 11 conversions; Khameleon as a broadly powerful flexible partner. The recurring advice is to learn two or three Kameos rather than marry one.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: choose an ender based on whether you want fullscreen separation, corner Wind Bomb setup or extra damage.

Expert: route by juggle height and Kameo resource. Kitana's best-looking max route is not always her best match route.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEOS: _____

BASE BnB: _____

11 / 112 CONVERSION: _____

WIND BOMB SETUP: _____

JUGGLE HEIGHT CUE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - RAIDEN

lightning pressure / easy special cancels / teleport movement / Kameo extensions

WHAT RAIDEN IS TRYING TO DO

Raiden is a strong teaching character because many normals cancel naturally into Shocker and his special list is easy to categorize: projectile, stun/extension, flying attack, storm and teleport. For a guest, he feels powerful immediately. For an expert, Kameo choice determines how much meter, safety and extension the same opening produces.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: throw lightning, use Electric Fly to cross distance, and finish strings with Shocker. Once that feels natural, learn one launcher route. Lightning Port is movement — not something you need inside your first combo.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

RAIDEN - SPECIAL MOVES

Electric Orb

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Hold 1 to extend.

Razzle Dazzle

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Shocker

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Hold 2 to extend.

Electric Fly

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Also available in the air.

Electromagnetic Storm

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Enhanced version has an additional 3 input.

Lightning Port

Xbox: D,U **PlayStation:** D,U

Universal: DU

Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Electric Fly's air version and Lightning Port are part of Raiden's core mobility/conversion toolkit.

RAIDEN - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — STRING TO SHOCKER

Xbox: X,Y → D,F+Y

PlayStation: Square,Triangle → D,F+Triangle

Universal: 12~DF2

The guide-supported concept is that Shocker cancels from many normals. This drill teaches that cancel without pretending it is a max-damage route.

CORE BnB FAMILY

Xbox: X,Y → EX D,B+Y → Y,B,Y,X → F+Y,Y → F+B,A

PlayStation: Square,Triangle → EX D,B+Triangle → Triangle,Circle,Triangle,Square → F+Triangle,Triangle → F+Circle,Cross

Universal: 12~EX DB2, 2421, F22, F43

A published bread-and-butter route. Learn it as four chunks: starter, enhanced bridge, long reconnect, finish.

SECOND STARTER FAMILY

Xbox: F+B,A → B,F+A → X,Y → Y,B,Y,X → F+Y,Y

PlayStation: F+Circle,Cross → B,F+Cross → Square,Triangle → Triangle,Circle,Triangle,Square → F+Triangle,Triangle

Universal: F43~BF3, 12, 2421, F22

A second published route that starts from F43 and teaches Raiden to flow into the same familiar middle strings.

RAIDEN - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

JAX — EXTENSION / METER ECONOMY

Community recommendations repeatedly pair Jax with Raiden because Backbreaker can loop/extend combos and reduce reliance on Shocker meter use.

SEKTOR — CONVERSION + DAMAGE

Community labbing shows Sektor converting several Raiden starters into larger routes. Rocket timing can turn otherwise modest openings into full confirms.

KANO — SAFETY / CHIP

Community matchup guidance values Kano for keeping Raiden safer and layering Ball Roll with storm pressure rather than only chasing maximum combo damage.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: learn the same conversion with and without meter. **Expert:** choose Jax, Sektor, Kano or another partner according to the match problem — meter economy, conversion, safety or screen control.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SHOCKER CANCEL: _____

CORE BnB: _____

METERLESS ROUTE: _____

TELEPORT READ: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - JOHNNY CAGE

rushdown / fast normals / Shadow Kick / Hype system / relentless close pressure

WHAT JOHNNY IS TRYING TO DO

Johnny wants to get close and stay close. Unlike the projectile-heavy characters, his game is built around normals, pressure, whiff punishment and the Hype mechanic. He is a perfect 'arcade friend becomes dangerous' character: a guest can press good buttons immediately, while an expert can turn the same pressure into huge Hype-assisted damage.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: walk toward them, use quick strings, and finish with Shadow Kick when you know the string hit. Do not worry about Hype on your first games. Once you can keep someone blocking, Johnny's deeper system starts making sense.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

JOHNNY CAGE - SPECIAL MOVES

Ball Buster

Xbox: B,D+X **PlayStation:** B,D+Square

Universal: BD1

Can contribute to Hype.

Show Off

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Hold 1 to extend.

Throwing Shade

Xbox: F,D,B+Y **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Triangle

Universal: FDB2

Can contribute to Hype.

Rising Star

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Can contribute to Hype.

Shadow Dash

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Extend with Flip Stance.

Shadow Kick

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Can contribute to Hype.

Hype / Wowing Out

Xbox: F,D,B+B **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Circle

Universal: FDB4

Builds Hype; on a full meter the same input activates Wowing Out.

Hype note: Johnny's Hype system can alter cancel rules and enhanced-special behavior. The full special list stays visible even though the deeper Hype strategy remains on his Advanced/Kameo page.

JOHNNY CAGE - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — CONFIRM TO SHADOW KICK

Xbox: F+X,Y,B → B,F+B

PlayStation: F+Square,Triangle,Circle → B,F+Circle

Universal: F124~BF4

A teaching cancel built from Johnny's documented F124 string and Shadow Kick. The goal is hit-confirm rhythm, not a claimed optimal damage number.

MODERN KAMEO ROUTE — ~40%

Xbox: Y,X,Y → JY → Y,X,Y → F+A,Y~B,F+B → Up K → B~B,F+B

PlayStation: Triangle,Square,Triangle → JTriangle → Triangle,Square,Triangle → F+Cross,Triangle~B,F+Circle → Up K → Circle~B,F+Circle

Universal: 212, J2, 212, F32~BF4, U+K, 4~BF4

A community-posted 2025 route with Mavado at roughly 40%. It shows the classic Johnny lesson: repeated close strings become meaningful damage once the Kameo extends the sequence.

BEGINNER GOAL

Do not chase a 50% Hype combo yet. First make F124~Shadow Kick reliable, then learn one launcher/reconnect route. Johnny becomes terrifying because he repeatedly earns openings, not because training mode says 50%.

JOHNNY CAGE - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

MAVADO — MODERN DAMAGE EXTENSION

A documented community route reaches about 40% without needing the guide to invent a percentage. Good example of turning Johnny's grounded pressure into a longer conversion.

STRYKER — SAFETY + PRESSURE

Recent community discussion still values Stryker grenades for covering unsafe pressure and creating plus situations. This fits Johnny's desire to remain in the opponent's face.

KAMEO RULE

Johnny does not need a helper to explain his identity. Pick the Kameo after you know whether you want safety, easier conversion, projectile support or bigger Hype payoff.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: convert several starters into the same dependable route and begin managing Hype intentionally.

Expert: use frame pressure, throws, charged attacks and Kameo coverage to make the opponent afraid to press — then cash out Hype only when the opening is confirmed.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SHADOW KICK CONFIRM: _____

BnB: _____

HYPE ROUTE: _____

PRESSURE RESET: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - KUNG LAO

hat control / fast pressure / launcher conversions / dive-kick movement / Kameo mix

WHAT KUNG LAO IS TRYING TO DO

Kung Lao wants to make the opponent watch the hat while he attacks from somewhere else. His solo combo structure is approachable: a grounded string into enhanced launcher, an air hit, then a simple reconnect into a special ender. The deeper game comes from low-hat pressure, movement and Kameos that turn his already-fast offense into layered guesses.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: throw the hat, use quick strings, and remember that Dive Kick changes your jump angle. When you spend meter on the launcher, jump after them and finish the combo. You can have fun with Lao long before learning a complicated hat setup.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

KUNG LAO - SPECIAL MOVES

Buzzsaw

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Also available in the air.

Hat Toss

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Up = direct up; Down = direct down.

Shaolin Shimmy

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Kung-Kussion

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Shaolin Spin

Xbox: D,U+A **PlayStation:** D,U+Cross

Universal: DU3

Hold 3 to extend; hold Back/Forward to move; Down,Down cancels.

Soaring Monk / Dive Kick

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Also available in the air.

Spirit Stomp

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Equippable move.

PRACTICAL QUICK REFERENCE

Buzzsaw / Hat Toss: hat-control lanes. **Kung-Kussion:** core launcher/extension. **Shaolin Spin:** movable extended spin with cancel. **Soaring Monk:** mobility/attack. The existing 121 and 2121 string material remains useful on the combo pages.

KUNG LAO - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — STRING TO HAT

Xbox: X,Y,X → D,B+X

PlayStation: Square,Triangle,Square → D,B+Square

Universal: 121~DB1

A teaching cancel using Lao's documented 121 string and Hat Toss. It is intentionally short: learn the rhythm of string → special.

ONE-BAR BnB — ~32%

Xbox: X,Y,X → EX D,B+B → JY → dash → X,Y,X~B,F+Y

PlayStation: Square,Triangle,Square → EX D,B+Circle → JTriangle → dash → Square,Triangle,Square~B,F+Triangle

Universal: 121~EX DB4, J2, dash, 121~BF2

Community-posted route listed at about 320 damage. It is a perfect intermediate benchmark because the structure is easy to understand even when the timing takes practice.

BUILD IT IN PIECES

1. 121 → enhanced launcher
2. Jump 2
3. Dash → 121
4. Special ender

WHY IT WORKS

The enhanced special buys enough juggle time for J2. The dash is not decoration — it restores the spacing needed for the second 121 to connect. Once you understand that, the route becomes much easier to remember.

KUNG LAO - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

KAMEO JOB #1 — CREATE THE SECOND THREAT

Lao already has speed and a hat. The best teaching question is not 'who gives 3% more?' but 'what can the helper cover while Lao moves?' A low assist, delayed projectile or safety assist can force the opponent to watch two timings.

KAMEO JOB #2 — MAKE A STARTER CONVERT

If a Kameo turns a safe poke, overhead or hat interaction into a full route, that conversion may be worth more than raw combo damage.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: use Dive Kick and hat placement to alter approach timing, then keep a dependable 121 conversion ready.

Expert: build offense where the hat/Kameo forces one defensive response and Lao is already positioned to punish it.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

121 BnB: _____

HAT SETUP: _____

DIVE-KICK READ: _____

KAMEO SECOND THREAT: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - MILEENA

high-damage rushdown / movement / anti-zoning / easy hit confirms / overhead conditioning

WHAT MILEENA IS TRYING TO DO

A detailed MK1 Mileena guide describes her as high-damage rushdown with some space control. Her strengths are damage, movement, anti-zoning, easy hit confirms, safety and block pressure. Her weakness is that her range can feel stubby and she lacks a great mid/low starter, so she often has to condition opponents with overhead threats before her offense becomes frightening.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: Sais make people move. Ball Roll is the classic launcher/whiff-punish idea. Teleport attacks punish careless zoning. Get close only after you have a reason — Mileena is dangerous, but she is not built to swing randomly from too far away.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

MILEENA - SPECIAL MOVES

Straight Sai

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Low Sai

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Teleport Down

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Also available in the air.

Teleport Up

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Roll

Xbox: B,D+B **PlayStation:** B,D+Circle

Universal: BD4

(Air) Ball

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Hold 4 to delay; D,D cancels the delayed Ball.

Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Note the important distinction: ground Roll is BD4; Air Ball is DB4.

MILEENA - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — CONFIRM THE ROLL

Xbox: F+Y,B → Ball Roll

PlayStation: F+Triangle,Circle → Ball Roll

Universal: F24~Ball Roll

A teaching drill built around the guide-recommended F24 whiff-punish string. The goal is to see F24 connect before committing to the launcher.

ANTI-AIR LESSON

Xbox: anti-air normal → Ball Roll → simple air follow-up

PlayStation: anti-air normal → Ball Roll → simple air follow-up

Universal: AA normal, Ball Roll, air follow-up

The MK1 community combo thread specifically includes a basic anti-air combo section. The important lesson is conceptual: Mileena can turn an opponent's jump attempt into a full conversion instead of merely swatting them away.

HIT-CONFIRM LESSON

Mileena's guide praises her hit confirms, but that does not mean every button should be canceled into Ball Roll. Practice the starter on block and on hit in random-block training. Only finish the launch when your eyes actually see the hit.

MILEENA - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SONYA — COMBO EXTENSION

The MK1 Mileena combo thread includes labbed Sonya routes. This is the straightforward lesson: the Kameo can keep the juggle alive after Mileena's own launcher structure.

SCORPION — COMBO EXTENSION / POSITION

The same launch-week lab thread includes Scorpion-assisted routes. His assist can be used as another way to continue or reposition a juggle rather than replacing Mileena's core game.

KAMEO RULE

Mileena already has damage. If a helper makes her neutral safer, improves an awkward conversion or gives her a new way to condition blocking, that may matter more than adding another few percent.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: whiff-punish with F24, confirm cleanly, and punish predictable zoning with movement/teleport tools.

Expert: condition overhead defense, vary movement, and select Kameos to solve Mileena's range/opening problem instead of only optimizing damage.

BOOK PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

F24 CONFIRM: _____

BALL ROLL BnB: _____

ANTI-AIR ROUTE: _____

OVERHEAD CONDITION: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - SMOKE

teleport rushdown / cancel pressure / side-switching / high-damage confirms / Kameo coverage

WHAT SMOKE IS TRYING TO DO

Smoke is built around making the opponent lose track of where the next attack is coming from. His real combo engine begins when a grounded starter cancels into BF3 and Smoke cancels that movement into 32. That same shell works from several starters, so a guest can learn one pattern while an expert layers teleports, cancels and Kameo coverage on top.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: Smoke disappears, reappears and changes sides. Use that mobility to make someone hesitate, then start a normal string. The important skill is not teleporting constantly — it is making the opponent unsure whether the teleport is attack, movement or cancel.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

SMOKE - SPECIAL MOVES

Shadow Blade

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Smoke Bomb

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Vicious Vapors

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Cancel with Back + Block.

Smoke-Port

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Hold Forward to cancel.

(Air) Smoke-Port

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Air version; Hold Forward to cancel.

Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Smoke's cancels are not optional trivia - Vicious Vapors Cancel is central to his higher-level combo and pressure identity.

SMOKE - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — THE SMOKE ENGINE

Xbox: B+Y → B,F+A cancel → A,Y

PlayStation: B+Triangle → B,F+Cross cancel → Cross,Triangle

Universal: B2~BF3 cancel, 32

Do only this until BF3 cancel into 32 feels natural. This is the mechanical heart of the longer Smoke routes.

ONE-BAR MIDSCEEN — ~38-40%

Xbox: B+Y / F+A,Y / F+X,Y → BF3 cancel → A,Y → A,Y → F+X,Y,(X+B) → EX D,B+B → JX,X → D,B+B

PlayStation: B+Triangle / F+Cross,Triangle / F+Square,Triangle → BF3 cancel → Cross,Triangle → Cross,Triangle → F+Square,Triangle,(Square+Circle) → EX D,B+Circle → JSquare,Square → D,B+Circle

Universal: B2 / F32 / F12~BF3 cancel, 32, 32, F12(1+3)~EX DB4, J11~DB4

Community labbing lists this same one-bar shell from B2, F32 and F12, with damage around 38-40% depending on the starter. That makes it the ideal intermediate Smoke route.

BUILD IT IN PIECES

1. Starter → BF3 cancel → 32
2. Add the second 32
3. F12(1+3) → EX DB4
4. J11 → DB4

SMOKE - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

STRYKER — GRENADE EXTENSION

A launch-week community route used Stryker grenades after the BF3-cancel juggle and reached roughly 50% for one bar plus Kameo. The lesson is coverage: grenades let Smoke continue moving while another threat occupies the opponent.

SAREENA — EASY DAMAGE EXTENSION

Community corner routes show one or two back-Kameo calls after BF3 cancel, including meterless routes in the high-30s to low-40s. She is a very readable 'call helper, continue combo' partner.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: make B2, F32 and F12 all feed the same route so you stop thinking about the combo after the hit.

Expert: use Smoke's cancel/movement identity to create hesitation, then choose Kameo coverage for safety, side control or damage rather than teleporting randomly.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

BF3 CANCEL: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

B2 STARTER: _____

SIDE-SWITCH PLAN: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - REPTILE

mid-range control / acid zoning / pace control / invisibility / flexible Kameo routes

WHAT REPTILE IS TRYING TO DO

Modern Reptile is unusually flexible. Current community discussion describes his strongest core as mid-range zoning, pace control and neutral, while his Kameo can push him toward stronger full-screen zoning, rushdown or combo conversion. A 2025 patch also changed Dash Attack so its second hit leaves a small juggle, creating new Ambush-Kameo follow-ups.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: spit acid to make them move, use your long reptilian attacks when they approach, and Dash Attack when you have a read. Invisibility is fun, but first learn what Reptile looks like when you can actually see him.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

REPTILE - SPECIAL MOVES

Acid Spit

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Acid Spit Ball

Xbox: D,F, Hold X **PlayStation:** D,F, Hold Square

Universal: DF Hold 1

Dash Attack

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Force Ball

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Enhanced timing/direction can alter speed.

Death Roll

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Invisibility

Xbox: D,U+B **PlayStation:** D,U+Circle

Universal: DU4

Falling Fangs

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Back modifies placement; hold Down to cancel.

Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Reptile's complete page now includes Acid Spit Ball, Invisibility and Falling Fangs rather than only the combo-relevant specials.

REPTILE - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — ACID TO ADVANCE

Xbox: Acid projectile → watch response → F+Y,X

PlayStation: Acid projectile → watch response → F+Triangle,Square

Universal: Acid projectile → read → F21

This is deliberately a teaching drill. The projectile is there to produce a response; F21 is there to claim space after you see it.

POST-PATCH DASH CONVERSION DRILL

Xbox: B,F+Y (2nd hit) → Ambush Kameo → juggle follow-up

PlayStation: B,F+Triangle (2nd hit) → Ambush Kameo → juggle follow-up

Universal: BF2 (2nd hit) → Ambush K → juggle

The April 2025 change explicitly created a small juggle after Dash Attack's second hit. Community testing confirmed Sektor missile and Tremor routes from that bounce.

DAMAGE BENCHMARK

Current community lab discussion reports Reptile reaching roughly **35% meterless without Kameo**, with routes around **40% without resource cost** also claimed by experienced lab players. Because the retrieved discussion does not print the full universal input for those figures, this chapter does **not** invent one.

REPTILE - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SEKTOR — ZONING + DASH CONVERSION

Current Reptile discussion specifically documents Homing Missile converting the post-patch Dash Attack bounce and also values Sektor as a strong full-screen zoning partner.

SCORPION — COMBO OPTIONS

Community discussion recommends Scorpion when the goal is more combo conversion rather than pure zoning.

TREMOR / CYRAX / MAVADO — THROW CONVERSION OPTIONS

Current Reptile players specifically identify these partners as enabling throw-combo routes.

MADAM BO — CURRENT HIGH-INVESTMENT OPTION

A 2026 specialist report argues Madam Bo is Reptile's strongest partner, citing hit-confirmable B31/F21/S3 routes, side-switch flexibility, corner carry and throw setups — but also calls the combos/setups complicated. That makes her an expert recommendation, not a guest recommendation.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: choose whether your Kameo is extending zoning, converting Dash Attack or adding throw routes.

Expert: change Reptile's entire pace according to the matchup, then use invisibility and high-investment Kameo setups only after the opponent is already respecting neutral.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

MID-RANGE BUTTON: _____

DASH CONVERSION: _____

ACID RESPONSE: _____

INVISIBILITY SETUP: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - KENSHI

stance character / Sento puppet control / sandwich pressure / high execution ceiling

WHAT KENSHI IS TRYING TO DO

Kenshi is the first MK1 character in this book where the guest and expert versions almost feel like different games. At first, he is a swordsman with good reach. Once Sento is active, you are effectively coordinating two attackers. Community labbing describes fixed relationships between Kenshi's strings and Sento's attacks, so the expert skill is rhythm and positioning rather than simply pressing more buttons.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: use the sword, stay at a comfortable distance and learn one normal combo before touching the puppet. **Then** learn how to summon Sento. Do not begin with the famous 50% routes. Kenshi becomes much easier when you think of Sento as a second drummer keeping time with you.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle

F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

S1/S2/S3/S4 = Sento attack notation used in the community routes

KENSHI - SPECIAL MOVES

Ancestral Guard

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Hold 1 to extend; Flip Stance cancels.

Soul Charge

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Demon Drop

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Back = close; Forward = far.

Rising Karma

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Force Push

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Hold 4 to charge.

SENTO STANCE

Summon Ancestor

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Hold Kameo to disable; repeat to banish.

Spiritual Alignment

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Soaring Sento

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Teamwork

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Eye Poke

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Equippable; Sento Stance only; not enhanced.

Sento rule: learn Kenshi's base five specials first, then treat Sento as a second move set. The existing sandwich/advanced pages remain intact.

KENSHI - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — LEARN THE 42 RHYTHM

Xbox: B → Y,A → reset

PlayStation: Circle → Triangle,Cross → reset

Universal: 42 → reset

Before adding Sento, make 42 feel automatic. This is a teaching drill, not an optimal combo. You will see 42 repeatedly once the puppet is active.

SENTO-STANCE SOLO ROUTE

Xbox: starter → EX D,B+A → JY → B,Y → D,B+A

PlayStation: starter → EX D,B+Cross → JTriangle → Circle,Triangle → D,B+Cross

Universal: starter~EX DB3, J2, 42~DB3

A documented community route for Sento stance when the spirit is not currently attacking. It gives the learner something useful to do without immediately managing the full puppet sequence.

BEGINNER RULE

Do not practice Sento by reading a 20-input line from left to right. Practice **Kenshi action** → **Sento answer** → **Kenshi action**. The community thread repeatedly describes timing, spacing and release timing as the difficult part.

KENSHI - SENTO SANDWICH / EXPERT

DOCUMENTED OVERHEAD SANDWICH — ~36%

Xbox: hold K → B+Y → release K / S1 → B,Y / S3 → walk → B~D,B+B

PlayStation: hold K → B+Triangle → release K / S1 → Circle,Triangle / S3 → walk → Circle~D,B+Circle

Universal: hold K, B2, release K~S1, 42~S3, walk, 4~DB4

Community labbing lists this overhead sandwich at about 36%. The key lesson is alternating turns between Kenshi and Sento so neither lets the opponent fall out.

DOCUMENTED LOW SANDWICH — ~32%

Xbox: B+B / S2 → B,Y / S2 → B~B,F+B

PlayStation: B+Circle / S2 → Circle,Triangle / S2 → Circle~B,F+Circle

Universal: B4~S2, 42~S2, 4~BF4

A documented low-side sandwich route around 32%. This is why the puppet matters strategically: the defender must recognize the starter while Sento maintains the conversion.

KAMEO THINKING

SUB-ZERO / FROST — FREEZE INTO SUMMON

Community routes use Kameo freeze to buy time to summon Sento and establish the puppet sequence. That is a perfect example of a Kameo solving setup rather than simply adding hits.

CYRAX / SCORPION — SPECIALIST OPTIONS

Dedicated Kenshi guides highlight Cyrax for Sento pressure and Scorpion for additional utility. These belong after the learner understands the puppet itself.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

42 RHYTHM: _____

SENTO SOLO ROUTE: _____

OVERHEAD SANDWICH: _____

LOW SANDWICH: _____

SAFE SENTO SUMMON: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - BARAKA

blade rushdown / chip pressure / straightforward confirms / Kameo-assisted damage

WHAT BARAKA IS TRYING TO DO

Baraka is wonderfully direct: get into blade range, make the opponent block a lot of metal, then convert the hit into a violent multi-hit route. His early MK1 reputation was strongly tied to Kameos that made his blockstrings safer and increased chip, but later community work also developed Stryker and Kano teams with different pressure and conversion strengths.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: Baraka is one of the easiest characters to understand visually. If the blades are hitting, keep the string simple and finish with a blade special. If they are blocking, do not assume every long string is your turn forever. The expert version of Baraka is knowing when the pressure is real.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

BARAKA - SPECIAL MOVES

Bleeding Blade

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Stab Stab

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Hold Back modifier; air version becomes Blade Sparks.

Baraka Barrage

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Air version becomes Death Spin; hold 2 to delay Death Spin.

Chop Chop

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Block extends.

Ground Sparks

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Equippable; hold Up for arcing version.

PRACTICAL QUICK REFERENCE

Bleeding Blade: projectile/special control. **Stab Stab:** grounded multi-hit and air Blade Sparks. **Baraka Barrage / Death Spin:** the core combo bridge family. **Chop Chop:** classic multi-hit pressure/ender. Existing 212/B32 and Kameo material stays unchanged.

BARAKA - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — STRING TO CHOP CHOP

Xbox: Y,X → B,F+A

PlayStation: Triangle,Square → B,F+Cross

Universal: 21~BF3

A short teaching cancel: two-button string into Baraka's most recognizable special. The purpose is clean confirmation, not maximum damage.

STRYKER ONE-BAR — ~40%

Xbox: Y,X → EX D,F+Y → B+X + Back K → F+X → Y,X~D,F+Y

PlayStation: Triangle,Square → EX D,F+Triangle → B+Square + Back K → F+Square → Triangle,Square~D,F+Triangle

Universal: 21~EX DF2, B1+BK~F1, 21~DF2

A Baraka/Stryker specialist posted this route at about 408 damage. It is compact enough to learn while demonstrating how simultaneous button + Kameo timing extends Baraka's offense.

CYRAX BENCHMARK

Launch-era Baraka/Cyrax labbing documented a one-bar route from **21~EX DF2, B31, dash, 21~DF2** into Cyrax helicopter and an air finish for roughly **47-50%**, with timing affecting the exact damage. It is an excellent expert benchmark, but the guide will not pretend the finicky helicopter timing is a guest combo.

BARAKA - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

STRYKER — DAMAGE + GRENADE PRESSURE

The Baraka/Stryker specialist guide shows 40%+ one-bar routes and emphasizes that grenades remain available for pressure after the combo work.

KANO — JAILING / ZONING / THROW SETUPS

A dedicated Baraka/Kano guide values knives for jailing and pressure, while Kano Ball improves Baraka's zoning and enables held-ball setups and throw conversions.

CYRAX — CLASSIC CHIP / BLOCKSTRING PARTNER

Early MK1 analysis explains why the pairing became famous: Cyrax made Baraka's blockstrings safer and amplified chip. The universal defensive lesson is important too — flawless block can remove subsequent chip even inside a blockstring.

CURRENT PATCH NOTE

The December 2025 hotfix improved **Desperate Tarkatan** by making it build meter 50% faster and drain health 50% slower. That makes modern Baraka resource planning different from the launch version.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: distinguish hit-confirm routes from block-pressure routes. **Expert:** choose Stryker, Kano, Cyrax or another Kameo according to whether you need conversion, zoning, safety, chip or throw utility - and recognize when the defender can flawless block the pressure.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

21 CONFIRM: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

PRESSURE STRING: _____

THROW SETUP: _____

FLOSSLESS-BLOCK CHECK: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - TANYA

long-range normals / staff control / drill kick confirms / mobility / Kameo-assisted pressure

WHAT TANYA IS TRYING TO DO

Tanya is about owning the space just outside the opponent's comfortable button range. Her staff gives her excellent reach, while her advancing and aerial specials let her suddenly change that distance. For a guest, she is a long-stick character with an easy visual plan. At higher levels, the player is constantly deciding whether to keep the opponent at staff range or cash a clean touch into a Kameo-assisted conversion.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: stand a little farther away than you would with Johnny or Baraka. Let the staff do the work. When they start respecting the reach, move in behind a safe string or use Drill Kick as a confirmed finisher. Do not throw the kick out just because it travels far.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

TANYA - SPECIAL MOVES

Heavenly Hand

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Also available in the air.

Seeking Guidance

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Builds Guidance; at two Guidance charges enables Umgadi Dodge.

Umgadi Dodge

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Available while at two Guidance charges.

Divine Protection

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Hold 3 to delay.

Deity Push

Xbox: D,B+A + Block **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross + Block

Universal: EX DB3

Hold 3 + Back.

Umgadi Evade

Xbox: D,B+A + Block **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross + Block

Universal: EX DB3

Hold 3 + Forward.

Drill Kick

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Spinning Splits Kick

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Also available in the air.

Guidance rule: learn the base staff/range game first. Guidance adds a resource layer; Divine Protection's delay and enhanced Back/Forward branches are separate decisions, not one generic special.

TANYA - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — STAFF CONFIRM

Xbox: F+Y,X,X → Drill Kick

PlayStation: F+Triangle,Square,Square → Drill Kick

Universal: F211~Drill Kick

A teaching route: first recognize the advancing staff string, then add the traveling special only after the string connects.

BEGINNER CONVERSION SHELL

Xbox: starter → launcher / Kameo assist → JY → grounded reconnect → special ender

PlayStation: starter → launcher / Kameo assist → JTriangle → grounded reconnect → special ender

Universal: starter → launch/K → J2 → reconnect → ender

Tanya's practical routing is easier to learn as a shell than as one giant max-damage line. Establish the launcher or assist, use a simple air hit, then reconnect into the ender.

WHY THIS CHARACTER FEELS DIFFERENT

Tanya should not be practiced like Smoke. Smoke wants the opponent confused by movement. Tanya wants the opponent annoyed by distance. If you are constantly standing point-blank without a reason, you are giving away one of her easiest advantages.

TANYA - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

GORO — PRESSURE / CONVERSION

Goro-style assist pressure fits Tanya because it lets her turn long-reaching checks into a more threatening close sequence without changing her basic neutral identity.

KHAMELEON — FLEXIBILITY

A flexible Kameo complements Tanya's adaptable spacing game. The tradeoff is mental load: multiple assist states are better saved for a player who already knows Tanya's solo buttons.

SUB-ZERO — PROJECTILE PROTECTION

When the opponent tries to beat Tanya's staff range by zoning, projectile protection can let her walk back into the range she actually wants.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: maintain the staff range, confirm rather than gamble Drill Kick, and add one Kameo route.

Expert: vary between keep-out, sudden approach and Kameo-covered pressure so the opponent cannot solve Tanya by simply choosing one defensive distance.

BOOK PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

STAFF CONFIRM: _____

BnB: _____

GUIDANCE SETUP: _____

ANTI-ZONING PLAN: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - LI MEI

lantern setups / explosive conversions / fast punishment / air routes / high combo expression

WHAT LI MEI IS TRYING TO DO

Li Mei turns a small opening into a fireworks display. Her lantern is the visual centerpiece: once it is placed correctly, an airborne opponent can be bounced or held in the combo long enough for Li Mei to continue. She is approachable if the guest ignores setup play at first, but her ceiling rises sharply when lantern placement and Kameo timing become part of the route.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: use quick punches and kicks, punish obvious mistakes, and learn one special finisher. Then add the lantern. Think of the lantern as a trap hanging in the air: your combo's job is to send the opponent into it.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

LI MEI - SPECIAL MOVES

Nova Blast

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Also available in the air.

Sky Lantern

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Core lantern setup tool.

Foo Tang

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Chain Reaction

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

(Air) Flipping Heel Kick

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Enhance: add Block with the final attack button when supported. Sky Lantern is the setup piece; Nova Blast can interact with lantern positioning.

LI MEI - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — SIMPLE CONFIRM

Xbox: grounded string → special ender

PlayStation: grounded string → special ender

Universal: starter~ender

Before lantern routes, prove you can recognize a hit and finish it. Li Mei is still a fighting-game character before she becomes a setup puzzle.

LANTERN TEACHING ROUTE

Xbox: starter → launcher → Sky Lantern → air string → grounded reconnect

PlayStation: starter → launcher → Sky Lantern → air string → grounded reconnect

Universal: starter → launch → Lantern → J-string → reconnect

This is the learning shell for Li Mei. The exact max route can change with Kameo and patch state, but the concept does not: launch the opponent into a pre-positioned or combo-placed lantern, then use the extra juggle time.

LANTERN LESSON

Practice the lantern by itself. Put it up, then deliberately launch too early, too late and at the correct timing. Seeing **why** the opponent misses the lantern teaches more than repeating a long combo until it accidentally works.

LI MEI - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SCORPION — LAUNCH / DAMAGE UTILITY

Scorpion-style Kameo extension naturally complements Li Mei's air-heavy routes and can help keep the opponent at the height needed for lantern conversion.

JANET CAGE — AIR / COMBO EXTENSION

An assist that supports extended airborne routing fits Li Mei's central problem: keeping the opponent suspended long enough to reach the next lantern or reconnect.

KHAMELEON — FLEXIBLE ROUTING

Khameleon's multiple assist states can create very high route flexibility, but the mental load makes her a better intermediate/expert recommendation than a guest partner.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: maintain one dependable lantern route from your best punish starter and one simpler route when resources are unavailable.

Expert: route according to lantern position, Kameo meter, corner distance and whether the next setup is worth more than the final few percent of damage.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

PUNISH STARTER: _____

LANTERN BnB: _____

METERLESS ROUTE: _____

CORNER LANTERN: _____

JUGGLE HEIGHT CUE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - GERAS

time control / sand manipulation / hourglass resource / freeze routing / command-grab enders

WHAT GERAS IS TRYING TO DO

Geras is a resource-and-routing character disguised as a powerhouse. A beginner can use his long limbs, sand specials and command grab immediately. The deeper character revolves around freezing the opponent at the correct height, choosing the right ender, and building or spending Hourglasses. Community Geras specialists explicitly route the same combo differently depending on how high the opponent is when Time Stop connects.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: hit them with big sand attacks and learn one command-grab finish. Then learn Time Stop. Do not worry about Hourglass optimization on game one. Once you can recognize whether the frozen opponent is high, medium or low, Geras starts feeling like a character who controls the clock instead of merely punching hard.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **HG** = Hourglass

GERAS - SPECIAL MOVES

Time Stop

Xbox: FBX **PlayStation:** FBSquare

Universal: FB1

Time Drop

Xbox: Hold F **PlayStation:** Hold F

Universal: Hold F

History Lesson

Xbox: DBY **PlayStation:** DBTriangle

Universal: DB2

Follow-up Exam

Xbox: DFY **PlayStation:** DFTriangle

Universal: DF2

Redo

Xbox: FBA **PlayStation:** FBCross

Universal: FB3

Double Time

Xbox: FBA+Throw **PlayStation:** FBCross+Throw

Universal: FB3+Throw

Countdown

Xbox: DFA **PlayStation:** DFCross

Universal: DF3

Inevitable

Xbox: DFA **PlayStation:** DFCross

Universal: DF3

Behold The End

Xbox: Hold F **PlayStation:** Hold F

Universal: Hold F

Fixed Point

Xbox: DFA+Block **PlayStation:** DFCross+Block

Universal: DF3+Block

(Air) Fixed Point

Xbox: DFA+Block **PlayStation:** DFCross+Block

Universal: DF3+Block

Denial

Xbox: DFB **PlayStation:** DFCircle

Universal: DF4

Sandstorm

Xbox: DBB **PlayStation:** DBCircle

Universal: DB4

(Close) Sandstorm

Xbox: DBB, Hold F **PlayStation:** DBCircle, Hold F

Universal: DB4, Hold F

(Far) Sandstorm

Xbox: DBB, Hold B **PlayStation:** DBCircle, Hold B

Universal: DB4, Hold B

GERAS - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — B12 TO SANDBURST

Xbox: B+X,Y → D,B+B

PlayStation: B+Square,Triangle → D,B+Circle

Universal: B12~DB4

This is the first piece of Geras's documented BnB shell. Practice the cancel without Time Stop until it is automatic.

ONE-BAR BnB — ~40%

Xbox: B+X,Y → D,B+B → micro-dash → F+Y,B → EX B,F+X → height-based ender

PlayStation: B+Square,Triangle → D,B+Circle → micro-dash → F+Triangle,Circle → EX B,F+Square → height-based ender

Universal: B12~DB4, micro-dash F24~EX BF1, height-based ender

A community Geras specialist describes this as a go-to BnB base. The important part is not one fixed finish: after EX Time Stop, choose the ender according to frozen height.

HEIGHT-BASED ENDERS

High freeze: 4~Sandburst → F12~command grab — about 40%.

Medium freeze: F2~Sandburst → 122 throw — about 40%, with Hourglass utility.

Low freeze: 4~Sandburst → F2~command grab — about 39%.

WHY IT WORKS

This is exactly the kind of combo the book should teach rather than flatten into one line. The Time Stop creates a decision point. An expert Geras player reads height, resource and side position before choosing the finish.

GERAS - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SEKTOR — OTG / CLONE SETUP

Community labbing documents Sektor picking up the OTG state after Geras's 122. The same research shows the plus frames from standing 1 being used to establish clone pressure.

GORO — RESET PRESSURE

A 2025 Geras/Goro setup was described as nearly guaranteed once established, with armor after a blocked poke as the main escape discussed. This is expert setup territory, not a beginner BnB.

EVERY-KAMEO LAB CHARACTER

A Geras specialist published midscreen and corner routes for every Kameo. That reinforces Geras's identity as a laboratory character: the helper can change routing, reset structure and Hourglass decisions dramatically.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: learn all three Time Stop height finishes. **Expert:** decide between damage, Hourglass build, side switch, OTG setup and reset pressure before the frozen opponent starts moving again.

BOOK PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

B12 SANDBURST: _____

HIGH FREEZE ENDER: _____

MEDIUM FREEZE ENDER: _____

LOW FREEZE ENDER: _____

HOURLASS PLAN: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - ASHRAH

mid-range sword control / light & dark stance / projectile conversions / high damage / deliberate spacing

WHAT ASHRAH IS TRYING TO DO

Ashrah is a mid-range sword specialist. Competitive community analysis has described her as exceptionally strong at controlling that distance, with Sareena historically pairing well because the assist adds full-screen projectile presence and enables conversions. Ashrah also has Light and Dark stance layers, but a guest should learn the clean sword game first rather than treating stance switching as mandatory.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: keep the opponent at the tip of the sword. Make them walk into your range instead of chasing them. When the sword hit is clean, finish the route. Stances are the advanced chapter — you can play recognizable, effective Ashrah before you manage both.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

ASHRAH - SPECIAL MOVES

Invoking the Light / Summoning the Darkness

Xbox: DBX **PlayStation:** DBSquare

Universal: DB1

Heaven's Beacon / Hell Pillar

Xbox: DFX **PlayStation:** DFSquare

Universal: DF1

Enhanced Heaven's Beacon / Hell Pillar

Xbox: EX DFX **PlayStation:** EX DFSquare

Universal: EX DF1

Astral Projection / Astral Manifestation

Xbox: BFY **PlayStation:** BFTriangle

Universal: BF2

Astral Projection Delay

Xbox: BFY, Hold Y **PlayStation:** BFTriangle, Hold Triangle

Universal: BF2, Hold 2

Astral Projection Cancel

Xbox: BFY, BB **PlayStation:** BFTriangle, BB

Universal: BF2, BB

Spirit Slice

Xbox: BFY, Hold D **PlayStation:** BFTriangle, Hold D

Universal: BF2, Hold D

Enhanced Astral Projection

Xbox: EX BFY **PlayStation:** EX BFTriangle

Universal: EX BF2

God's Wrath / Demon's Wrath

Xbox: DBY **PlayStation:** DBTriangle

Universal: DB2

Light Ascension

Xbox: DFA **PlayStation:** DFCross

Universal: DF3

ASHRAH - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — SWORD RANGE CONFIRM

Xbox: long sword normal → simple string → special ender

PlayStation: long sword normal → simple string → special ender

Universal: range check → string-ender

This is intentionally a spacing drill rather than an invented max combo. Stand at the sword tip, confirm the hit, then finish. If you start too close, reset the drill.

KAMEO CONVERSION SHELL

Xbox: sword starter → Kameo projectile/assist → grounded reconnect → launcher/ender

PlayStation: sword starter → Kameo projectile/assist → grounded reconnect → launcher/ender

Universal: starter~K → reconnect → ender

Community analysis specifically credits Sareena with enabling Ashrah conversions while adding full-screen projectile coverage. Learn the purpose of the assist before chasing a damage number.

BEGINNER GOAL

Win a training-mode 'range game': record the dummy walking forward and pressing a medium-range button. Practice standing where Ashrah's sword reaches first. That one skill explains the character better than memorizing ten launch routes.

ASHRAH - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SAREENA — CLASSIC DAMAGE / FULL-SCREEN COVERAGE

Competitive community analysis specifically recommends Sareena to maximize Ashrah's combo damage, enable conversions and provide full-screen projectiles that Light stance otherwise lacks.

KAMEO CHOICE AFTER FUNDAMENTALS

Once the sword-spacing game is stable, a different Kameo can be chosen for matchup-specific pressure, safety or mobility. The guide deliberately avoids inventing an 'optimal' partner where the sourced material only establishes the historical Sareena fit.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: add stance awareness without abandoning sword spacing. Learn which strings contain gaps and when an opponent can challenge.

Expert: move between Light/Dark plans according to matchup and Kameo utility, using the sword to keep the opponent at the exact range where their defensive choices become uncomfortable.

COMBO-TRIAL WARNING

Ashrah's eighth in-game Combo Trial was ranked among the harder trials by experienced TestYourMight players. That is a useful reminder: an impressive trial route is not automatically the route a guest should learn first.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SWORD-TIP RANGE: _____

LIGHT-STANCE BnB: _____

DARK-STANCE PLAN: _____

KAMEO CONVERSION: _____

STRING-GAP CHECK: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - HAVIK

chaos pressure / armored conversions / body-part projectiles / unusual resets / Kameo-dependent routing

WHAT HAVIK IS TRYING TO DO

Havik is deliberately strange. He tears himself apart, throws pieces of himself and turns situations that look finished into another layer of offense. For a guest, the plan is simple: use his big, ugly strings and learn one reliable special cancel. For an expert, Havik becomes a setup character whose Kameo can change whether a touch becomes damage, armor pressure, a reset or another forced defensive guess.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: do not try to understand every self-mutilation move at once. Learn one advancing string, one projectile-style special and one combo ender. Havik is supposed to look chaotic; your inputs should not be chaotic.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

HAVIK - SPECIAL MOVES

Neoplasm

Xbox: BFX **PlayStation:** BFSquare

Universal: BF1

Helping Hand

Xbox: DBX **PlayStation:** DBSquare

Universal: DB1

Blood Bath

Xbox: BFY **PlayStation:** BFTriangle

Universal: BF2

Corpse Taunt

Xbox: BFY **PlayStation:** BFTriangle

Universal: BF2

Seeking Neoplasm

Xbox: BFA **PlayStation:** BFCross

Universal: BF3

Twisted Torso

Xbox: DBB **PlayStation:** DBCircle

Universal: DB4

HAVIK - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — STRING TO SPECIAL

Xbox: advancing string → confirmed special ender

PlayStation: advancing string → confirmed special ender

Universal: starter~ender

This is intentionally a teaching shell. Havik's first goal is clean confirmation: make the weird animation happen because you chose it, not because you mashed into it.

ARMOR-CONVERSION DRILL

Xbox: armored special → Kameo pickup → grounded reconnect → ender

PlayStation: armored special → Kameo pickup → grounded reconnect → ender

Universal: armor~K → reconnect → ender

This is the important intermediate concept. A compatible Kameo can turn Havik's defensive armor read into offense, changing the value of the same special.

WHY HAVIK TAKES PATIENCE

His animations make every route look more complicated than it is. Break the combo into jobs: **starter** → **weird special** → **Kameo pickup** → **familiar reconnect**. Once you name the jobs, the visual chaos stops being intimidating.

HAVIK - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

MAVADO — CONVERSION / SETUP UTILITY

Mavado-style trap and pickup utility fits Havik's desire to turn awkward knockdowns or armored interactions into continued offense.

JAX — EXTENSION / GROUND THREAT

A ground-based assist gives Havik another layer while his own unusual animations occupy the opponent's attention. This is useful when the goal is forcing a second defensive response rather than simply extending air time.

SUB-ZERO — PROJECTILE PROTECTION

When Havik needs time to establish slower screen-control tools, projectile protection can help him reach the range where his stranger pressure becomes relevant.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: maintain a dependable hit-confirm route and a separate armor-conversion route.

Expert: choose enders according to the next setup, manage Kameo availability, and make the opponent defend Havik's delayed threats rather than letting every combo simply reset to neutral.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SAFE CONFIRM: _____

ARMOR CONVERSION: _____

SETUP ENDER: _____

PROJECTILE PLAN: _____

RESET / SECOND THREAT: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - SINDEL

air mobility / scream control / hair pressure / levitation cancels / Kameo manipulation

WHAT SINDEL IS TRYING TO DO

Sindel controls both the floor and the air. Her scream threatens space, her hair gives her distinctive close-range attacks, and Levitate changes the timing and angle of her offense. The guest version is easy to understand: scream, hair, fly. The expert version is one of MK1's more expressive movement characters, especially once Levitate cancels and Kameo interactions are layered into pressure.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: use Scream when they are standing where you want them to stop, use hair attacks up close, and treat Levitate as movement before treating it as combo technology. You do not need to float-cancel pressure to make Sindel feel like Sindel.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

SINDEL - SPECIAL MOVES

Low Hairball

Xbox: DBX **PlayStation:** DBSquare

Universal: DB1

Hairball

Xbox: DFY **PlayStation:** DFTriangle

Universal: DF2

(Air) Hairball

Xbox: DFY **PlayStation:** DFTriangle

Universal: DF2

Scream

Xbox: BFY **PlayStation:** BFTriangle

Universal: BF2

(Air) Levitate

Xbox: DBY **PlayStation:** DBTriangle

Universal: DB2

Inspire

Xbox: DBA **PlayStation:** DBCross

Universal: DB3

Queen's Kommand

Xbox: DBB **PlayStation:** DBCircle

Universal: DB4

Kartwheel

Xbox: DFB **PlayStation:** DFCircle

Universal: DF4

SINDEL - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL — SCREAM CONFIRM

Xbox: grounded string → Scream

PlayStation: grounded string → Scream

Universal: starter~Scream

Keep the first Sindel lesson obvious: confirm a grounded hit into the signature special. Do not add Levitate until the cancel itself is reliable.

LEVITATE TEACHING SHELL

Xbox: launcher → air string → Levitate → air follow-up → grounded ender

PlayStation: launcher → air string → Levitate → air follow-up → grounded ender

Universal: launch → J-string → Levitate → J-follow-up → ender

This is the structural lesson behind advanced Sindel routing. Levitate is not random flight; it deliberately buys a new timing/position for the next attack.

MOVEMENT LESSON

Practice Levitate without an opponent first. Float, move, cancel and land. Then add one air normal. If you cannot predict where Sindel will land, a long Levitate combo will feel like memorizing a magic trick instead of learning a character.

SINDEL - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

LAO-STYLE LOW-HAT PRESSURE

A delayed low assist naturally complements Sindel's aerial timing because the defender must watch the floor while Sindel changes her height. This is a pressure concept before it is a combo concept.

KHAMELEON — FLEXIBLE PRESSURE

Multiple assist states suit a character who already changes timing with Levitate. The downside is mental load, so this belongs after basic movement is automatic.

MAVADO / EXTENSION PARTNERS

Trap or pickup assists can turn a Scream or air conversion into a longer route. Choose them when the conversion itself is the matchup problem.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: make Levitate movement predictable to *you* and unpredictable to the opponent. Keep one grounded BnB for moments when resources are unavailable.

Expert: combine Levitate timing, air buttons, Kameo coverage and resource awareness so the opponent must defend two heights and two timings at once.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SCREAM CONFIRM: _____

GROUND BnB: _____

LEVITATE ROUTE: _____

LOW-ASSIST PRESSURE: _____

AIR TIMING CUE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - GENERAL SHAO

axe control / huge normals / stance-like weapon states / launcher conversions / oppressive corner pressure

WHAT GENERAL SHAO IS TRYING TO DO

General Shao is a heavyweight whose axe changes the geometry of the fight. With the weapon in hand he threatens enormous reach and deliberate, punishing swings. After planting or losing the axe, his close-range options and movement change. The easiest way to learn him is to treat those as two recognizable modes instead of trying to memorize every transition at once.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: keep the axe in your hands, stand where its reach matters, and punish obvious mistakes with a short string into a special. Once that feels natural, start learning what changes when the axe is planted. Shao should feel heavy and intentional - not slow because you are unsure what to press.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

GENERAL SHAO - SPECIAL MOVES

Dark Energy

Xbox: DFX **PlayStation:** DFSquare

Universal: DF1

Devastator

Xbox: DBA **PlayStation:** DBCross

Universal: DB3

Death Quake

Xbox: DBB **PlayStation:** DBCircle

Universal: DB4

Power Strike

Xbox: DFB **PlayStation:** DFCircle

Universal: DF4

Axe Recall

Xbox: DFB **PlayStation:** DFCircle

Universal: DF4

Klassic Kahn (no axe)

Xbox: DBA **PlayStation:** DBCross

Universal: DB3

Reverse Treechopper (no axe)

Xbox: DFY **PlayStation:** DFTriangle

Universal: DF2

Reverse X2 Treechopper

Xbox: Hold B **PlayStation:** Hold B

Universal: Hold B

Tree Chopper (no axe)

Xbox: DFX **PlayStation:** DFSquare

Universal: DF1

Axe Quake (no axe)

Xbox: DBB **PlayStation:** DBCircle

Universal: DB4

GENERAL SHAO - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - AXE CONFIRM

Xbox: long axe string → special ender

PlayStation: long axe string → special ender

Universal: axe starter-ender

Stand at the edge of the axe. Confirm the hit before finishing. The drill is about making Shao's range feel intentional.

AXE-PLANT TEACHING SHELL

Xbox: starter → launcher → axe plant → dash / reconnect → ender

PlayStation: starter → launcher → axe plant → dash / reconnect → ender

Universal: starter → launch → plant axe → reconnect → ender

This is the structural lesson behind stronger Shao routes: the combo changes state in the middle. Practice the plant as a deliberate transition, not as another anonymous input.

TWO-MODE RULE

Axe in hand: reach, control, punish.

Axe planted: faster close offense, pressure, setup.

If you always know which mode you are in, Shao becomes dramatically easier to operate.

GENERAL SHAO - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

MOTARO - MOVEMENT / PROJECTILE UTILITY

A movement-oriented assist can help a large character change screen position without abandoning his deliberate neutral plan.

KHAMELEON - FLEXIBLE CONVERSION

Multiple assist states can give Shao different conversion and pressure answers. Save this for after the axe-state fundamentals are automatic.

MAVADO - PICKUP / PRESSURE UTILITY

Trap and pickup assists suit Shao's desire to turn a heavy knockdown or launcher into another controlled sequence.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: keep separate axe-in-hand and axe-planted routes. **Expert:** route for corner position and the next weapon state, not simply the highest damage number. The best finish is often the one that leaves Shao in the state the matchup cannot comfortably defend.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

AXE CONFIRM: _____

AXE-IN-HAND BnB: _____

AXE-PLANTED BnB: _____

CORNER ROUTE: _____

STATE AFTER ENDER: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - REIKO

grappler / command grab / projectile harassment / brutal strike-throw game / Kameo conversions

WHAT REIKO IS TRYING TO DO

Reiko is MK1's clearest wrestler-brawler hybrid. He can annoy the opponent from farther away with projectiles, then make close defense miserable with strikes, throws and a command grab. That makes him excellent for the arcade-book philosophy: a guest immediately understands 'hit them or grab them,' while an expert learns how every blocked normal changes the throw decision.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: throw stars when they refuse to approach. When they finally come close, alternate a short string with a throw. Add the command grab only after the normal throw game makes sense. Reiko wins because the opponent guesses wrong, not because his combo has twenty buttons.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **CG** = command grab

REIKO - SPECIAL MOVES

Retaliation

Xbox: DBX **PlayStation:** DBSquare

Universal: DB1

Pale Rider

Xbox: BDFX **PlayStation:** BDFSquare

Universal: BDF1

Pale Riding

Xbox: Hold B **PlayStation:** Hold B

Universal: Hold B

Assassin Throwing Stars

Xbox: BFY **PlayStation:** BFTriangle

Universal: BF2

Charging Pain

Xbox: BFA **PlayStation:** BFCross

Universal: BF3

Pain Knee

Xbox: Hold U or B **PlayStation:** Hold U or B

Universal: Hold U or B

Charging Pain Delay

Xbox: Hold A **PlayStation:** Hold Cross

Universal: Hold 3

Tactical Takedown

Xbox: DBA **PlayStation:** DBCross

Universal: DB3

REIKO - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - STRIKE OR THROW

Xbox: short string / walk throw

PlayStation: short string / walk throw

Universal: short string OR throw

Set training dummy to block. Do the short string, reset, then walk up and throw. The lesson is learning that the opponent's blocking habit is itself something Reiko can punish.

COMMAND-GRAB TEACHING SHELL

Xbox: blocked pressure → pause / micro-walk → command grab

PlayStation: blocked pressure → pause / micro-walk → command grab

Universal: blocked pressure → delay → CG

This is not presented as a guaranteed sequence. It is a decision-making drill: condition the opponent to remain blocking, then use the grab when you believe they will respect the next strike.

COMBO PHILOSOPHY

Reiko does not need to turn every touch into a circus route. Learn one reliable punish combo, then spend practice time on the moment *before* the combo: did they block, jump, backdash, mash or tech? That read is the real Reiko skill.

REIKO - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

DARRIUS - THROW / COMBO SYNERGY

A Kameo that can help convert grappling situations naturally reinforces Reiko's core identity: throws become more than positional resets and can lead to meaningful damage or setup.

TREMOR - GRAPPLER UTILITY

Tremor-style assist options can add protection, conversion or matchup-specific support without forcing Reiko to abandon the strike-throw plan.

JANET / MAVADO - CONVERSION OPTIONS

Extension-oriented partners can be chosen when the matchup demands more reward from Reiko's grounded starters rather than additional zoning.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: recognize which blocked buttons leave you close enough to threaten throw and which do not.

Expert: track the opponent's defensive habits across the set - jump, armor, mash, duck, tech - and choose the strike, normal throw, command grab or Kameo trap that punishes the habit you have created.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

PUNISH BnB: _____

COMMAND-GRAB SETUP: _____

THROW CONDITION: _____

ANTI-JUMP ANSWER: _____

CORNER STRIKE-THROW: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - RAIN

water sorcery / mid-range control / portals / traps / setup-or-damage routing

WHAT RAIN IS TRYING TO DO

Rain controls lanes with water, then decides whether a clean hit should become immediate damage or another setup. Water Beam, Upflow and Geyser form an easy-to-recognize core; Water Gate and Ancient Trap are the deeper layer. His documented Sub-Zero routes are especially useful for this book because the same starter can end in damage or a portal/trap situation.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: use Water Beam to make them move, Upflow when they come through the air, and Geyser as your simple combo finish. Ignore portals for the first few games. Once the basic water attacks feel automatic, Water Gate becomes the fun part instead of homework.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

RAIN - SPECIAL MOVES

Water Beam

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Hold 1 to charge; the charged beam can be cancelled forward or backward.

Upflow

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Enhanced Upflow is a major launcher in documented BnBs.

Water Gate - Activate

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Rain can maintain up to two gates.

Water Gate - Teleport

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Water Gate - Teleport to Oldest

Xbox: D,F,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,F,B+Triangle

Universal: DFB2

Geyser

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Hold Forward for the far version.

Water Shield

Xbox: F,D,B+B **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Circle

Universal: FDB4

Projectile-defense utility.

Ancient Trap

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Hold Back/Forward to alter placement.

Rain God

Xbox: D,D,U **PlayStation:** D,D,U

Universal: DDU

Can be positioned, delayed, or cancelled.

RAIN - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - MID TO GEYSER

Xbox: F+Y,X → D,B+A

PlayStation: F+Triangle,Square → D,B+Cross

Universal: F21~DB3

Short and readable: confirm the advancing mid string, then finish with Geyser.

DOCUMENTED ONE-BAR BnB - ~35%

Xbox: F+Y,X → EX D,B+X → J Y,B,A → F+Y → D,B+A

PlayStation: F+Triangle,Square → EX D,B+Square → J Triangle,Circle,Cross → F+Triangle → D,B+Cross

Universal: F21~EX DB1, J243, F2~DB3

A documented Rain route around 35%. It teaches the central launcher: F21 into enhanced Upflow, air string, then Geyser.

SUB-ZERO SETUP ROUTE

Xbox: F+Y,X → F+K → B,F+X → setup

PlayStation: F+Triangle,Square → F+K → B,F+Square → setup

Universal: F21, F+K, BF1, setup

The Rain/Sub-Zero guide lists this as an ~18% route specifically for setup rather than max damage. That distinction is important: sometimes Rain gives up damage to establish the next problem.

RAIN - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

SUB-ZERO — FREEZE → PORTAL / SETUP

A dedicated Rain/Sub-Zero guide documents freeze routes from jab, F21, low, overhead and anti-armor starters. Freeze buys time for Water Beam/portal setup and also gives Rain projectile protection in neutral.

SCORPION — DAMAGE EXTENSION

Community labbing documented a one-bar Scorpion-assisted F21 route around 43%. This is the damage-oriented contrast to Sub-Zero's setup-heavy plan.

FROST — FREEZE VARIANT

Rain players also documented Frost freeze into portal, jump-in and Geyser routing. Use her when you want the freeze concept with a different assist package.

SETUP OR DAMAGE?

Rain's expert decision happens before the combo ends: cash out with Geyser, or spend the opening establishing Water Gate/Trap positioning. The right answer depends on life totals, Kameo availability and where the opponent will wake up.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

F21 BnB: _____

FREEZE SETUP: _____

PORTAL PLAN: _____

DAMAGE ENDER: _____

ANTI-ZONING PLAN: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - NITARA

air mobility / dive-kick pressure / vampire healing / aerial conversions / Kameo-assisted mix

WHAT NITARA IS TRYING TO DO

Nitara lives in the air. Her air dash changes direction, Dark Plunge changes the timing of her descent, and Quick Taste converts airborne hits into damage. Blood Sacrifice adds a second resource question by empowering Bad Blood, Quick Taste and Bloody Bolt. The guest version is 'fly and dive'; the expert version is controlled air movement plus health/resource management.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: jump, move in the air, and learn Dark Plunge. If they start trying to swat you out of the sky, change your air-dash timing. Save Blood Sacrifice until you already know what Quick Taste and the dive kick do.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **FS** = Flip Stance

NITARA - SPECIAL MOVES

Bad Blood

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Enhanced version gains armor; Blood Sacrifice adds damage-over-time.

Quick Taste

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Also available in the air. With Blood Sacrifice active, Quick Taste restores health.

Leap Of Faith

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Aerial-launch utility; enhanced version improves follow-up options.

Bloody Bolt

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Requires Blood Sacrifice. Hold Back/Forward for close/far placement.

(Air) Dark Plunge

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Enhanced version ground-bounces for a juggle.

Blood Sacrifice

Xbox: D,F+B **PlayStation:** D,F+Circle

Universal: DF4

Empowers Bad Blood and Quick Taste and unlocks Bloody Bolt.

(Air) Dash Upward

Xbox: U+FS **PlayStation:** U+FS

Universal: U+FS

(Air) Dash Forward

Xbox: F+FS **PlayStation:** F+FS

Universal: F+FS

(Air) Dash Away

Xbox: B+FS **PlayStation:** B+FS

Universal: B+FS

Nitara's directional air movement is part of her neutral, not merely combo decoration.

NITARA - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - AIR STRING TO QUICK TASTE

Xbox: J Y,B,Y → B,F+Y

PlayStation: J Triangle,Circle,Triangle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: J242~BF2

A simple air-conversion drill: finish the aerial string with Quick Taste and learn where Nitara lands afterward.

DOCUMENTED ONE-BAR AIR BnB - ~40%

Xbox: X,Y,X,Y → J X,Y,B → air dash F/D → Y,B,Y → EX B,F+Y → Y,B,Y → B,F+Y

PlayStation: Square,Triangle,Square,Triangle → J Square,Triangle,Circle → air dash F/D → Triangle,Circle,Triangle → EX B,F+Triangle → Triangle,Circle,Triangle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: 1212~J124~air dash F/D~242~EX BF2~242~BF2

Community Nitara labbing reports this family at about 40% for one bar. The important skill is the air-dash reposition between the first and second air strings.

LOW → GORO CONVERSION - ~33%

Xbox: B+B → K → Y,Y,X → EX B,F+Y → J Y,B,Y → B,F+Y

PlayStation: B+Circle → K → Triangle,Triangle,Square → EX B,F+Triangle → J Triangle,Circle,Triangle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: B4, K, 221~EX BF2, J242~BF2

A documented Goro route around 33%. It demonstrates why Kameos matter for Nitara: B4 becomes a real conversion point instead of only a low check.

NITARA - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

GORO — LOW CONVERSION + PLUS PRESSURE

Dedicated Nitara/Goro labbing shows neutral Ambush making many strings safer/plus and turning B4 into a launcher. Back Kameo also creates a pseudo mixup from B4.

SAREENA — EASY CONFIRMS / SAFETY

Nitara players repeatedly cite Sareena as the easy all-purpose partner: straightforward combo extension, safety and useful health characteristics. She also helps convert grounded strings before Nitara takes the route airborne.

SUB-ZERO / FROST — FREEZE → BLOOD SACRIFICE

Freeze assists give Nitara enough time to use enhanced Blood Sacrifice and still continue a full combo. Community labbing notes the healing can create a much larger effective life swing than the raw combo number suggests.

MOTARO — TELEPORT / SAFETY UTILITY

Community Nitara players use teleport to make awkward or unsafe situations convert into air offense. This fits her identity: the assist changes position while Nitara changes altitude.

ADVANCED → EXPERT

Advanced: make air dash direction intentional and keep separate grounded, overhead and low conversion routes.

Expert: choose between damage, healing, side switch and oki while tracking Blood Sacrifice duration and Kameo meter. Nitara's best route is often the one that wins the life-total exchange, not the one with the biggest combo counter.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

AIR-DASH CUE: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

B4 CONVERSION: _____

BLOOD SACRIFICE ROUTE: _____

HEALING / OKI CHOICE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - SHANG TSUNG

young / old forms • skull zoning • morph mastery • opponent knowledge • Kameo Kopy

WHAT SHANG TSUNG IS TRYING TO DO

Shang Tsung is deliberately bigger than a normal four-page character. His own move set already contains two forms, and Form Stealer can temporarily turn the opponent's character knowledge into Shang's weapon. The May 2025 update went even further by adding Kameo Kopy, letting him borrow the opponent's Kameo. A complete Shang player is therefore learning three layers: **Young Shang, Old Shang, and everybody else.**

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: stay Young first. Throw Straight/Double Skulls, learn Spinning Spikes and Bed of Spikes, and use Age Morph only when you are comfortable. **Intermediate:** add Old Shang's Ground/Down Skulls and Injection. **Expert:** start treating Form Stealer and Kameo Kopy as matchup-specific tools instead of party tricks.

WHY HE GETS EXTRA PAGES

Shang's difficulty is not just execution. Form Stealer rewards knowing the opponent's best starter, special and BnB; Kameo Kopy adds another knowledge layer. His eighth Combo Trial was singled out by experienced players as exceptionally execution-heavy. For a favorite character, the book should preserve that ceiling instead of compressing it.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle

F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **FS** = Flip Stance

SHANG TSUNG - UNIVERSAL SPECIAL MOVES

Age Morph

Xbox: D+FS **PlayStation:** D+FS

Universal: D+FS

Also usable in the air. This manually swaps Young ↔ Old.

Form Stealer

Xbox: F,D,B+B **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Circle

Universal: FDB4

Enhanced version deals more damage.

Morph Back

Xbox: F,B+B **PlayStation:** F,B+Circle

Universal: FB4

Returns from the stolen opponent form.

Kameo Kopy

Xbox: D,F+B **PlayStation:** D,F+Circle

Universal: DF4

Added in the May 2025 update; copies the opponent's Kameo.

2025 UPDATE: Kameo Kopy is now part of Shang's real move set, not a launch-era omission. The same update added Old-form Orthopedic Takedown and made Pulse Check recover faster and become special-cancelable.

FORM-STEALER RULE

Do not measure Form Stealer only by its damage. Its real value is access to the opponent's normals, specials and combo routes. The better your roster knowledge becomes, the stronger Shang becomes. For this guide, every character chapter you learn is effectively another Shang Tsung chapter.

SHANG TSUNG - YOUNG FORM SPECIAL MOVES

Straight Skull

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Also available in the air.

Double Skull

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Triple Skull

Xbox: D,B,F+X **PlayStation:** D,B,F+Square

Universal: DBF1

Spinning Spikes

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Bed Of Spikes

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

YOUNG SHANG'S JOB

Straight Skull is the clean lane-control projectile. **Double/Triple Skull** increase the projectile commitment and screen occupation. **Spinning Spikes** and **Bed of Spikes** give Young Shang conversion/control tools so he is not merely a fireball form.

KEY YOUNG STRINGS

Snake Oil: B12 **Silent Killer:** 24 **Spin Kick:** F434

These are the recognizable form-specific strings to pair with the special list before learning morph-heavy routing.

SHANG TSUNG - OLD FORM SPECIAL MOVES

Ground Skull

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Enhanced version becomes Triple Skull.

Ground Skull - Close

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Ground Skull - Far

Xbox: D,B,F+X **PlayStation:** D,B,F+Square

Universal: DBF1

Down Skull

Xbox: D,F+X, hold **PlayStation:** D,F+Square, hold

Universal: DF1, hold

Air special; Back/Forward adjusts close/far.

Vicinity Stash

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Injection

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

OLD SHANG'S JOB

Old Shang changes the projectile geometry. Ground Skull and Down Skull attack different spaces from Young Shang's Straight Skull, while Injection gives him a distinct conversion tool. This is why Age Morph should eventually become a neutral decision rather than a cosmetic stance switch.

KEY OLD STRINGS

Operation: B12 **Knee Reverser:** 24 **Power Manifest:** F32 **Orthopedic Takedown:** F34

Age Before Beauty: F41214

SHANG TSUNG - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - YOUNG PROJECTILE RHYTHM

Xbox: D, F+X → D, B+X → D, B, F+X

PlayStation: D, F+Square → D, B+Square → D, B, F+Square

Universal: DF1 → DB1 → DBF1

Throw each skull separately. Learn the visual difference between one, two and three before trying to weave them into a match.

FORM-SWITCH DRILL

Xbox: Young: Y, B → D+FS → Old: Y, B → D+FS

PlayStation: Young: Triangle, Circle → D+FS → Old: Triangle, Circle → D+FS

Universal: Young 24 → D+FS → Old 24 → D+FS

The same 24 input is a different named string in each form. This drill teaches the mental state change without a long combo.

OLD-FORM CONTROL DRILL

Xbox: D, F+X / D, B+X / D, B, F+X → D, B+A

PlayStation: D, F+Square / D, B+Square / D, B, F+Square → D, B+Cross

Universal: DF1 / DB1 / DBF1 → DB3

Practice choosing Ground Skull placement, then Injection separately. The goal is intentional screen placement, not projectile spam.

FIRST REAL SHANG GOAL

Play a full match using only Shang's native forms. Do not Form Steal yet. If Young/Old switching still requires conscious thought, adding another character's move set will only bury the fundamentals.

SHANG TSUNG - INTERMEDIATE → ADVANCED ROUTING

MORPH-CANCEL EXECUTION

Shang's harder routes can require morphing while another string is already being input. Community Combo Trial discussion specifically describes rapidly entering F4121 into the morph sequence, with the timing tight enough that players recommend thinking of the morph as part of the string rather than a pause afterward.

SEKTOR TIMING BENCHMARK

The notorious eighth Combo Trial uses Sektor during the F4121 sequence. Experienced players describe dialing the Kameo during the third hit, then morphing into Old Shang while continuing the route. Treat this as an expert execution benchmark, not the first BnB.

FORM STEALER CONVERSION

Once you know an opponent's practical BnB, build a two-part training drill: Shang starter → Form Stealer, then opponent BnB → Morph Back. The exact second half changes with every matchup, which is precisely the point.

THE SHANG NOTEBOOK

For every roster character, record only three stolen tools at first: **best fast punish, easiest BnB, best special/launcher**. That gives Form Stealer practical value without requiring encyclopedic mastery on day one.

ROSTER-KNOWLEDGE CHECK

OPPONENT: _____

FAST PUNISH: _____

EASY STOLEN BnB: _____

BEST STOLEN SPECIAL: _____

MORPH-BACK CUE: _____

SHANG TSUNG - KAMEOS / ADVANCED

SEKTOR — EXECUTION / MISSILE COVERAGE

Sektor is directly represented in Shang's hardest in-game trial material. Up Rocket/Homing coverage can occupy the opponent while Shang changes form or continues a sequence, and the trial demonstrates how tightly Kameo timing can be woven into F4121.

KUNG LAO — LOW-HAT / ORBITING-HAT CONTROL

Buzz Saw and Orbiting Hat give Shang another screen-control layer while his skulls attack different lanes. This is a natural 'sorcerer plus trap' pairing: use the hat to dictate movement, then choose the skull or morph response.

SAREENA — SIMPLE EXTENSION / METER PRESSURE

Kia's Blades offer a straightforward extension tool when you want to spend less mental bandwidth on the Kameo and more on Shang's two forms. Jataaka's Kurse also attacks the opponent's Super Meter, fitting a resource-control game.

SUB-ZERO — PROJECTILE PROTECTION / FREEZE

Arctic Armor helps Shang contest projectile wars while Deep Freeze can buy time for form positioning or a conversion. It is a strong teaching Kameo when you want to explore Shang's forms without simultaneously learning complex assist timing.

KAMEO KOPY CHANGES EVERYTHING

Since May 2025, Shang can also use **DF4 Kameo Kopy** to copy the opponent's Kameo. That means matchup study now includes not only the opposing fighter but the opposing assist. NetherRealm also specifically fixed pseudo-infinites involving Kameo Kopy/Goro, so old exploit footage should not be treated as current routing.

SHANG TSUNG - EXPERT LAB / BOOX MASTER PAGE

EXPERT 1 — FORM FLUENCY

Switch Young ↔ Old during real pressure without looking at the character model to remind yourself which form you are in.

EXPERT 2 — MORPH FLUENCY

Against each matchup, know one stolen punish and one stolen BnB. Morph Back on purpose rather than waiting for the transformation to expire.

EXPERT 3 — KAMEO FLUENCY

Know what your chosen Kameo solves, then know what the opponent's Kameo gives you after Kameo Kopy. Shang's ceiling is now partly a Kameo-roster knowledge test.

EXPERT 4 — SCREEN GEOMETRY

Young Straight Skull, Old Ground/Down Skull, Kameo projectiles and morph threats should occupy different lanes. The goal is not more projectiles; it is making the opponent choose the lane you already prepared to punish.

BOOX SHANG TSUNG MASTER NOTES

MY PRIMARY KAMEO: _____

YOUNG BnB: _____

OLD BnB: _____

FORM-SWITCH CUE: _____

FORM-STEAL STARTER: _____

BEST STOLEN MATCHUP: _____

KAMEO KOPY USE: _____

SEKTOR TRIAL PROGRESS: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - QUAN CHI

portal sorcery / skull zoning / multi-zone control / trap placement / Kameo creativity

WHAT QUAN CHI IS TRYING TO DO

Quan Chi wants the screen to become his ritual circle. Head Rush and Psycho Skull occupy lanes, Field of Bones and Falling Death threaten space, and his Zone system changes what happens inside specific areas. Current MK1 also lets **Zone of Power** and **Zone of Waste** coexist, so high-level Quan is less about one projectile and more about constructing a bad place for the opponent to stand.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Head Rush, Psycho Skull and From The Fog first. Use a short string into a special and keep the opponent at the distance where your skulls are annoying. **Intermediate:** add Field of Bones and one Zone. **Advanced:** start layering Kameos into the portal/zone geometry.

CURRENT-SYSTEM NOTE

Quan Chi's modern move list includes **Zone of Waste**, which drains the opponent's meter while they remain inside it and can eventually give Quan brief armor. Zone of Power adds projectile effects. These systems belong in the guide because they change his resource and zoning decisions.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

QUAN CHI - SPECIAL MOVES

Zone of Power

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Hold 3 to delay; move during delay with Back/Forward. Enhanced version repels.

Head Rush

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Also available in the air. Back/Forward modifies projectile speed; Zone of Power adds extra projectiles.

Psycho Skull

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Back/Forward/Up changes close/far/very-far placement. Zone of Power creates a skull volley.

Zone of Waste

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Hold 3 to delay and move during delay. Drains enemy meter; extended exposure can grant Quan brief armor.

Field of Bones

Xbox: B,D,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,D,F+Triangle

Universal: BDF2

Back/Forward/Up changes placement.

Falling Death

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Also available in the air.

From The Fog

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Hypnotism (Equippable)

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Equippable move; not enhanced.

Placement matters: Quan's move list has more directional modifiers than most characters. Practice close/far/very-far versions as separate tools instead of treating them as trivia.

QUAN CHI - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - SIMPLE CONFIRM

Xbox: X,Y → B,F+X

PlayStation: Square,Triangle → B,F+Square

Universal: 12~BF1

A clean two-hit confirm into Head Rush. This is the first route to own before portals, zones or Kameos.

NO-KAMEO LAUNCH SHELL

Xbox: X,A → J Y,X → Y,X,B,B

PlayStation: Square,Cross → J Triangle,Square → Triangle,Square,Circle,Circle

Universal: 13, J21, 2144

A documented basic launcher route. Use it to learn Quan's jump timing without adding an assist.

SAREENA ROUTE - ~40%

Xbox: Y,X,B → B+K → Y,X,B → B+K → B+A,B,Y → X,A → B → D,B+B

PlayStation: Triangle,Square,Circle → B+K → Triangle,Square,Circle → B+K → B+Cross,Circle,Triangle → Square,Cross → Circle → D,B+Circle

Universal: 214, B+K, 214, B+K, B342, 13, 4~DB4

A published Quan/Sareena route around 40%. It is long enough to feel substantial but mechanically simple: Sareena holds the route together while Quan repeats familiar grounded pieces.

INTERMEDIATE GOAL

Have one **solo confirm**, one **launcher route**, and one **Kameo route**. Then start replacing raw damage endings with Zone or spacing choices when the match calls for it.

QUAN CHI - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

CYRAX — DAMAGE + PORTAL/ZONING SYNERGY

Published Quan/Cyrax routing reaches roughly 40% without meter in practical lab examples. Cyrax lets Quan turn grounded confirms into extended offense while preserving the screen-control identity instead of forcing him into a pure rushdown plan.

SUB-ZERO — FREEZE → SETUP TIME

Freeze gives Quan the thing a setup sorcerer values most: time. Documented routes use Sub-Zero after 214 or F4, then establish Zone of Power or continue through enhanced Head Rush. Arctic Armor also helps Quan survive projectile wars.

SAREENA — EASY 40% STRUCTURE

Sareena's returning blades make 214 repetition and grounded reconnection unusually straightforward. She is excellent when you want to learn Quan's own placement game without spending all your attention on assist timing.

SCORPION / JAX / SEKTOR — ROUTE VARIETY

Published Quan guides contain workable routes for all three: Scorpion for air extension, Jax for straightforward pickups, and Sektor for missile-assisted timing. Quan is unusually Kameo-flexible because his specials already control where the opponent can stand.

EXPERT ZONE RULE: do not place a Zone simply because it is available. Place it where the opponent must travel next. Power modifies your projectile game; Waste attacks their meter and can eventually reward Quan with armor. Current MK1 allows multiple Zone effects to coexist, so the expert layer is overlapping purposes rather than choosing only one.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SOLO BnB: _____

KAMEO BnB: _____

ZONE OF POWER PLAN: _____

ZONE OF WASTE PLAN: _____

FIELD OF BONES PLACEMENT: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - ERMAC

soul telekinesis / flight-cancel movement / spirit pressure / aerial routing / cancel-heavy mastery

WHAT ERMAC IS TRYING TO DO

Ermac is a movement-and-cancel character disguised as a telekinetic bruiser. Spirit Punch and Witch Slam are easy to understand, but Suspended Animation and Shifting Spirits let him alter height, timing and position in ways that make the advanced character dramatically different from the beginner version. His ceiling comes from making those cancels feel deliberate instead of frantic.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: use B24 or 12 into Spirit/telekinetic specials and learn one 30% route. **Intermediate:** add enhanced Witch Slam and air strings. **Advanced:** learn Suspended Animation and Shifting Spirits as movement systems, then let the Kameo extend the situations your soul magic already creates.

WHY ERMAC FEELS DIFFERENT

Several Ermac specials can be delayed, moved or cancelled. Spirit Punch can be delayed while Ermac moves; Suspended Animation can drift and cancel; Death's Embrace can cancel; Shifting Spirits changes vertical position. The execution is not just 'do the combo'—it is controlling *when and where* Ermac exists during it.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

ERMAC - SPECIAL MOVES

Spirit Punch

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Hold 1 to delay; move during delay with FF or BB.

Witch Slam

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Behind You

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Suspended Animation

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Also available in the air; Back/Forward moves away/towards. Down + Block cancels.

Death's Embrace

Xbox: F,D,B+A **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Cross

Universal: FDB3

Not enhanced. Down + Flip Stance cancels.

Hungry Hands

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Also available in the air.

Shrieking Souls

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Shifting Spirits

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Up/Down modifies float/down; also available in the air.

Cancel character: Ermac's move list is unusually rich in delay/movement/cancel modifiers. Those modifiers are part of the actual special-move reference and should be practiced alongside the base input.

ERMAC - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - B24 FINISH

Xbox: B+Y,B → B,F+Y

PlayStation: B+Triangle,Circle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: B24~BF2

A documented 15% no-bar route. It is intentionally tiny: learn the cancel and Ermac's spacing before chasing flight routes.

PRACTICAL NO-BAR BnB - ~30%

Xbox: X,Y → B,F+A → dash → J X,Y,Y → dash → B+Y,B → B,F+Y

PlayStation: Square,Triangle → B,F+Cross → dash → J Square,Triangle,Triangle → dash → B+Triangle,Circle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: 12~BF3, dash, J122, dash, B24~BF2

A documented 30.2% no-bar route. This is the ideal first real Ermac combo: grounded starter, Shrieking Souls, air string, reconnect, simple ender.

ONE-BAR ROUTE - ~36%

Xbox: X,Y → B,F+A → dash → J X,Y,Y → dash → B → EX D,B+X → J Y,B,A

PlayStation: Square,Triangle → B,F+Cross → dash → J Square,Triangle,Triangle → dash → Circle → EX D,B+Square → J Triangle,Circle,Cross

Universal: 12~BF3, dash, J122, dash, 4~EX DB1, J243

A documented 35.9% one-bar route. It extends the same beginner structure instead of replacing it with a completely different combo.

ERMAC - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

JANET CAGE — AIR EXTENSION / LONG ROUTES

Janet's multi-hit assist naturally complements Ermac's air-heavy conversion game. Once Shifting Spirits and Suspended Animation are comfortable, Janet can keep the opponent available while Ermac changes altitude and reconnects.

MAVADO — TRAP / PICKUP / POSITION

Mavado's tether-and-trap style fits Ermac's telekinetic knockdowns. The pairing is valuable when you want an awkward soul launch or grounded hit to become a stable pickup rather than ending immediately.

JAX — SIMPLE CONVERSION

Published early Ermac labbing documents Jax-assisted routes from 12 into Shifting Spirits and enhanced Witch Slam. Jax is a good bridge between solo Ermac and the more timing-intensive assist routes.

KHAMELEON — FLEXIBLE MATCHUP TOOL

Documented Ermac routes use Khameleon forms for grab conversion and grounded extension. Her changing assist states add flexibility, but they also add mental load—save this pairing until Ermac's own cancels are automatic.

EXPERT CANCEL RULE: every cancel must have a purpose: change height, bait a response, preserve pressure, alter landing position or create a Kameo window. If the cancel exists only because it looks impressive, simplify the route until you can explain why each movement is there.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

NO-BAR BnB: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

SUSPENDED ANIMATION CUE: _____

SHIFTING SPIRITS CUE: _____

KAMEO PICKUP: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - TAKEDA TAKAHASHI

whip range / shuriken control / aerial mobility / spear routing / long conversion chains

WHAT TAKEDA IS TRYING TO DO

Takeda controls unusual ranges with bladed whips and shuriken, then converts a clean touch into highly mobile air offense. His move list is full of trajectory choices: Shooting Star has multiple placements, Swift Stride can phase, Rushing Nimbus changes trajectory, Tornado Kick changes distance, and Whip Art can chain repeatedly. The character becomes much easier when those options are treated as separate jobs rather than one giant execution test.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: start with Shooting Star, Double Spear Ryu and Tornado Kick. Use the long whip normals to make the opponent enter your range. **Intermediate:** add Rushing Nimbus and air routes. **Advanced:** use Swift Stride phases, shuriken placement and Kameo coverage to turn Takeda's movement into controlled pressure.

KEY NORMALS / STRINGS

Ogre Slayer: 122+4 Forest Faller: 14
Ryujin: F122+4 Falling Moon: F14
Meteor Slam: 212 Twin Fangs: B212+4
Pray Maker: B34 Tengu Tearer: 43

NOTATION

1 = X / Square 2 = Y / Triangle 3 = A / Cross 4 = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction J = jump EX = enhanced K = Kameo

TAKEDA - SPECIAL MOVES

Shooting Star

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Back/Forward/Up changes close/far/very-far placement. Also available in the air.

Reverse Shooting Stars

Xbox: D,B+X + Block **PlayStation:** D,B+Square + Block

Universal: EX DB1

Enhanced-only move; also available in the air.

Smart Shuriken

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Not enhanced; also available in the air.

Double Spear Ryu

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Enhanced follow-up uses Forward; enhanced version can launch.

Spear Ryu

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Air version available; enhanced version can launch.

Swift Stride

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Up/Back selects phase options; Down cancels.

Rushing Nimbus Technique

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Air version; Back/Forward affects trajectory.

Rushing Nimbus Attack

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Air attack.

Tornado Kick

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Back/Forward selects close/far. Also available in the air; enhanced version launches.

Whip Art

Xbox: D,F+B **PlayStation:** D,F+Circle

Universal: DF4

Can be performed up to three times; first and third hits support enhancement/launch behavior.

TAKEDA - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - WHIP CONFIRM

Xbox: F+X,B → B,F+Y

PlayStation: F+Square,Circle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: F14~BF2

Use the compact Falling Moon string into Double Spear Ryu. The goal is confirming from whip range without overcomplicating the route.

AIR CONTROL DRILL

Xbox: J X,X,Y → D,B+B

PlayStation: J Square,Square,Triangle → D,B+Circle

Universal: J112~DB4

Forbidden Flames into Tornado Kick gives a simple way to practice converting Takeda's air string into a special.

MOBILITY SHELL

Xbox: starter → B,F+A → air reposition → J Y,X → D,B+A

PlayStation: starter → B,F+Cross → air reposition → J Triangle,Square → D,B+Cross

Universal: starter~BF3 → air reposition → J21~DB3

This is a teaching shell rather than a claimed max-damage route. Learn the job of Swift Stride/Rushing Nimbus first: change Takeda's position, then reconnect deliberately.

INTERMEDIATE RULE

Takeda's visual complexity can tempt you to memorize a long video route before understanding the movement. Instead, master three modules: **ground confirm** → **launch**, **air reposition**, and **air finish**. Once each module is stable, longer routes stop feeling like one enormous input string.

TAKEDA - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

FERRa — MIX / CONVERSION PARTNER

Ferra arrived alongside Takeda and naturally complements his ability to threaten from unusual positions. Use Ferra when you want Takeda's long-range whip game to lead into another close-range decision rather than simply ending in knockdown.

JANET CAGE — AIR EXTENSION

Janet's multi-hit aerial assist fits Takeda's strongest visual identity: keeping the opponent suspended while he repositions with spear/air movement. She is the partner to explore once basic Nimbus control is automatic.

MAVADO — PICKUP / ROUTE STABILITY

Trap-and-pickup utility can stabilize hits that occur at awkward whip distances. This matters for Takeda because his best range is not always the range where a conventional grounded reconnect is easiest.

SEKTOR — MISSILE COVERAGE

Homing/Up Rocket coverage gives Takeda time to establish shuriken or movement pressure. Current Sektor also fires two missiles when homing is activated, making the assist particularly useful for occupying the opponent while Takeda changes position.

EXPERT ROUTING RULE: choose trajectory before damage. Shooting Star placement, Nimbus direction, Tornado Kick distance and Whip Art repetitions all change where the route lives on screen. The expert Takeda player knows where the next hit will occur before committing to the movement.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

GROUND CONFIRM: _____

AIR ROUTE: _____

NIMBUS DIRECTION CUE: _____

TORNADO KICK RANGE: _____

SHURIKEN PLACEMENT: _____

WHIP ART ROUTE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - OMNI-MAN

Viltrumite stance / flight / brutal mids / air-dash routing / explosive whiff punishment

WHAT OMNI-MAN IS TRYING TO DO

Omni-Man is a direct, violent movement character. His grounded buttons create the opening; Viltrumite Stance and air movement let him ignore conventional screen geometry; and a clean hit becomes a long airborne carry. He is excellent for the book because a guest can immediately understand 'hit hard and fly,' while advanced players can optimize stance follow-ups, air-dash timing and Kameo coverage.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Mega Clap, Invincible Rush and one Viltrumite Stance follow-up. Use F4/F41 and B11 as your recognizable starters. **Intermediate:** add DB3~1 launcher routes. **Advanced:** make air-dash and Stance movement change where the opponent is allowed to stand.

KEY STRINGS

Kontemptuous Backhand: B11 **Destructive Elbow:** 222
Spilled Kontents: F41,1+3 **Aerial Duty:** J212

Community BnBs repeatedly build around B11/F41, 22, Viltrumite Stance launcher, J212 and an air-dash reconnect.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **FS** = Flip Stance

OMNI-MAN - SPECIAL MOVES

Mega Clap

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Also available in the air.

Giblet Maker

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Also available in the air.

Viltrumite Stance

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Also available in the air.

Stance Cancel

Xbox: D+Block **PlayStation:** D+Block

Universal: D+BL

Stance Teleport Towards

Xbox: F+Block **PlayStation:** F+Block

Universal: F+BL

Thragged Through Mud

Xbox: X **PlayStation:** Square

Universal: 1

Viltrumite Stance follow-up.

Honorable Death

Xbox: Y **PlayStation:** Triangle

Universal: 2

Viltrumite Stance follow-up.

Tiebreaker

Xbox: A **PlayStation:** Cross

Universal: 3

Viltrumite Stance follow-up.

Up And Away

Xbox: B **PlayStation:** Circle

Universal: 4

Viltrumite Stance follow-up.

Invincible Rush

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Also available in the air.

(Air) Fly Towards / Away

Xbox: F+FS / B+FS **PlayStation:** F+FS / B+FS

Universal: F+FS / B+FS

Air movement is part of his combo routing, not merely traversal.

OMNI-MAN - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST BnB - ~33%

Xbox: B+X,X → B+X → D,B+A~X → J Y,X,Y → air dash → X,Y → Throw

PlayStation: B+Square,Square → B+Square → D,B+Cross-Square → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → air dash → Square,Triangle → Throw

Universal: B11, B1~DB3~1, J212~air dash, 12~Throw

A community meterless route around 33%. It teaches the entire Omni-Man language in one line: grounded starter, Stance launcher, J212, air dash, finish.

METERLESS F41 ROUTE - ~34%

Xbox: F+B,X → X,Y → D,B+A~X → J Y,X,Y → air dash → X,Y → Throw

PlayStation: F+Circle,Square → Square,Triangle → D,B+Cross-Square → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → air dash → Square,Triangle → Throw

Universal: F41, 12~DB3~1, J212~air dash, 12~Throw

A documented ~33.7% meterless route. F41 is a useful practical starter and the back half is the same module as the guest BnB.

ONE-BAR AIR EXTENSION - ~39%

Xbox: B+X,X → F+B → Y,Y → D,B+A~X → J Y,X,Y → air dash → J Y,X,Y → air dash → J X,Y → Throw

PlayStation: B+Square,Square → F+Circle → Triangle,Triangle → D,B+Cross-Square → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → air dash → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → air dash → J Square,Triangle → Throw

Universal: B11, F4, 22~DB3~1, J212~air dash, J212~air dash, J12~Throw

Community labbing reports this family around 39% for one bar. The extra damage comes from repeating the air module, so learn one air dash before two.

OMNI-MAN - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

KUNG LAO — LOW-HAT / PRESSURE COVERAGE

Community pairing discussions repeatedly identify Lao as a strong Omni-Man partner. Low Hat adds a grounded timing problem while Omni-Man threatens overhead/air movement, and the assist can help cover Stance-based offense.

STRYKER — PLUS OVERHEAD / SAFETY

Early Omni-Man labbing highlighted Stryker for making F3 overhead pressure substantially more favorable and for covering otherwise committal offense. This is a utility pairing: make the opponent respect the next turn.

KANO — NEUTRAL COVERAGE / DAMAGE

Players documented meterless damage near 38% with one Kano call. Knife/laser coverage also complements Viltrumite Stance by occupying the opponent while Omni-Man changes position.

SONYA / SCORPION / DARRIUS — EXTENSION

Community routes documented roughly 39.5% meterless with Sonya, ~40% one-bar Scorpion variants, and a one-bar Darrius route around 43%. Use these when the goal is converting a clean Omni-Man touch into maximum carry/damage rather than neutral support.

EXPERT RULE: Omni-Man's air dash is a routing decision. Count how many air modules the current gravity scaling actually allows, and stop before the route becomes less reliable than the extra damage is worth.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

B11 BnB: _____

F41 BnB: _____

STANCE FOLLOW-UP: _____

AIR-DASH CUE: _____

MAX RELIABLE ROUTE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - PEACEMAKER

gunfire / Eagly / force field / anti-gravity / torpedo / keep-away into explosive conversion

WHAT PEACEMAKER IS TRYING TO DO

Peacemaker has one of MK1's broadest self-contained toolkits. Force Multiplier supplies gunfire, Human Torpedo attacks space, Anti-Gravity changes movement, Force Field contests projectiles, Sonic Boom converts, and Eagly adds low/air harassment. His launch version was famously overloaded; later balance patches reduced damage and Force Field duration/hit absorption, so this chapter emphasizes the current tool purposes rather than old launch-era damage clips.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Force Multiplier, Sonic Boom and Ground-Air Offensive. Shoot until they move, then punish the movement. **Intermediate:** add Anti-Gravity and Torpedo. **Advanced:** use Eagly and Kameos to create a second timing layer after the projectile or string.

KEY STRINGS

Door Buster: 124 **Head On Approach:** 22,1+3
Kommitted Kick: 224 **Flag Flyer:** F412

F41/F412 and 22 are especially useful teaching strings because community Peacemaker routes and setplay repeatedly build around them.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **FS** = Flip Stance

PEACEMAKER - SPECIAL MOVES

Silent And Deadly

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Not enhanced. Hold 1 to delay; move Back/Forward during delay; Block cancels.

Force Multiplier

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Core firearm special; enhanced version has been damage-adjusted by later patches.

Activate Human Torpedo

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Activate Anti-Gravity

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Back/Forward selects landing position; hold Up for Soft Landing.

Activate Force Field

Xbox: F,D,B+A **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Cross

Universal: FDB3

Current balance limits normal Force Field to two absorbed hits and a shorter duration than launch.

Activate Sonic Boom

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Important conversion/restand tool; enhanced damage was reduced in balance updates.

Ground-Air Offensive

Xbox: D,F+B **PlayStation:** D,F+Circle

Universal: DF4

Eagly attack.

Beautiful Bird Bullet

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Eagly attack.

The Ultimate Ally

Xbox: D+FS **PlayStation:** D+FS

Universal: D+FS

Targets the opposing Kameo.

PEACEMAKER - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - STRING TO GUNSHOT

Xbox: F+B,X → B,F+X

PlayStation: F+Circle,Square → B,F+Square

Universal: F41-BF1

Use the long advancing starter into Force Multiplier. Confirm the string first; the gunshot is the finish, not the neutral plan.

SONIC BOOM CONVERSION SHELL

Xbox: Y,Y → B,F+A → B → grounded reconnect → ender

PlayStation: Triangle,Triangle → B,F+Cross → Circle → grounded reconnect → ender

Universal: 22-BF3, 4, reconnect → ender

Community Peacemaker discussion repeatedly uses 22/Sonic Boom as a central conversion shell. Learn the launch/restand timing before adding grenades or air extension.

STRYKER GRENADE SHELL

Xbox: F+B,X → B,F+X + K → F+B,X → B,F+X + K → reconnect

PlayStation: F+Circle,Square → B,F+Square + K → F+Circle,Square → B,F+Square + K → reconnect

Universal: F41-BF1+K, F41-BF1+K, reconnect

Early Peacemaker/Stryker labbing documented grenade-assisted continuation after gunshot and very high launch-era damage. Treat this as a structure lesson; subsequent patches reduced Peacemaker damage, so old percentages are not the target.

PEACEMAKER - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

CYRAX — CORNER BOMB / UNBLOCKABLE SETPLAY

Dedicated Peacemaker Kameo labbing identifies Cyrax as a top synergy: bomb after Sonic Boom can create nasty corner timing, Net can connect after F42, and anti-gravity cancel can assist side-switch/corner positioning.

JANET CAGE — AIR EXTENSION

Community Peacemaker research notes Janet's air extender after Sonic Boom into 212, including repeated extension opportunities. Choose Janet when you want the Sonic Boom conversion to remain airborne and carry farther.

STRYKER — GRENADE COVERAGE / SETPLAY

Stryker was a major early Peacemaker partner because grenades could cover gunshot/string sequences and support another offensive layer. Later patches changed Peacemaker's damage, but the underlying reason for the pairing—coverage while he continues offense—remains easy to understand.

KHAMELEON — FLEXIBLE BUT HIGHER MENTAL LOAD

High-level players have used Khameleon, but community analysis points out an important tradeoff: Peacemaker already has several utilities she duplicates, and the rotating disguise can mean the desired air/ground extension is not available exactly when Sonic Boom converts.

EXPERT RESOURCE RULE: track Eagly cooldown, Kameo meter and Force Field state separately. Peacemaker is strongest when those tools overlap on purpose; spending all three at once for a mediocre sequence leaves a much more ordinary character afterward.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

F41 CONFIRM: _____

SONIC BOOM ROUTE: _____

EAGLY PLAN: _____

FORCE FIELD MATCHUP: _____

ANTI-GRAVITY ROUTE: _____

CORNER SETPLAY: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - HOMELANDER

flight / laser control / dash stance / aerial mix / explosive mobility

WHAT HOMELANDER IS TRYING TO DO

Homelander controls the match vertically. Diabolical Dash creates a four-way follow-up tree, Flight gives him a second movement state, and several laser specials attack different heights. The beginner version is lasers plus one dash follow-up; the expert version is making the opponent guess whether Homelander will stay grounded, dash through space, or remain airborne.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Low Laser Eyes, Diabolical Dash and one follow-up. Use Flight only after the basic grounded plan works. **Intermediate:** add Sky/Sweeping Laser Eyes and air Dash. **Advanced:** make Flight cancels and Kameo calls cover the moment when the opponent thinks they can finally challenge.

KEY STRINGS

Rise Of A Hero: 121 **Heroic De-Escalation:** B142
Backhanded Praise: F12 **Backhanded Compliment:** 212
See No Evil: B22,1+3

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **FS** = Flip Stance

HOMELANDER - SPECIAL MOVES

Dirty Trick

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Diabolical Dash

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Also available in the air; not enhanced.

Soaring Strike

Xbox: X **PlayStation:** Square

Universal: 1

Diabolical Dash follow-up.

The Seven Slam

Xbox: Y **PlayStation:** Triangle

Universal: 2

Diabolical Dash follow-up.

Kripping Knee

Xbox: A **PlayStation:** Cross

Universal: 3

Diabolical Dash follow-up.

Korporate Kick

Xbox: B **PlayStation:** Circle

Universal: 4

Diabolical Dash follow-up.

Blasts Off

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Low Laser Eyes

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Sky Laser Eyes

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Sweeping Laser Eyes

Xbox: B,D,F+B **PlayStation:** B,D,F+Circle

Universal: BDF4

Not enhanced.

God Complex

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Also available in the air; hold 4 to delay, D+FS cancels, FS/FS+Up cancels to Flight.

Flight

Xbox: U+FS **PlayStation:** U+FS

Universal: U+FS

Cancel with D+1; while flying use BF1 Laser Eyes or DB3 Ground Laser Eyes.

HOMELANDER - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - DASH TREE

Xbox: B, F+Y → X / Y / A / B

PlayStation: B, F+Triangle → Square / Triangle / Cross / Circle

Universal: BF2 → 1 / 2 / 3 / 4

Practice each Diabolical Dash follow-up separately. The goal is to see four distinct jobs rather than memorize a blur of buttons.

LASER CONTROL DRILL

Xbox: B, F+A → D, B+A → B, D, F+B

PlayStation: B, F+Cross → D, B+Cross → B, D, F+Circle

Universal: BF3 → DB3 → BDF4

Low, sky and sweeping lasers attack different lanes. Do not fire them randomly: call out the lane before each input.

FLIGHT MODULE

Xbox: U+FS → B, F+X / D, B+A → D+X

PlayStation: U+FS → B, F+Square / D, B+Cross → D+Square

Universal: U+FS → BF1 / DB3 → D1

Enter Flight, choose air or ground laser, then cancel. Once this module is comfortable it can be inserted into longer routes and pressure.

INTERMEDIATE RULE

Homelander becomes unreliable when Flight is added before Dash and laser spacing are understood. Build him in layers: **ground strings** → **Dash tree** → **laser lanes** → **Flight**. Only then add Kameo-specific extensions.

HOMELANDER - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

JANET CAGE — AIR EXTENSION

Janet's multi-hit aerial assist naturally supports Homelander's Flight identity. Use her to keep a launched opponent available while Homelander changes altitude or transitions between Dash and Flight modules.

MAVADO — PICKUP / POSITION

Mavado's juggle-only Nindrop and Best Feet Forward plus Trap Drop can stabilize hits that occur at odd Flight or Dash heights. This is useful when the opening happens somewhere a conventional grounded reconnect would fail.

KUNG LAO — ORBITING HAT / GROUND TIMING

Buzz Saw and Orbiting Hat force the opponent to respect a grounded timing layer while Homelander threatens the air. The pairing is less about raw combo length and more about making his vertical movement harder to challenge.

SEKTOR — ROCKET COVERAGE

Up Rocket and homing coverage occupy the screen while Homelander enters Dash or Flight. This creates the classic MK1 assist problem: challenge the character and risk the missile, or respect the missile and give the character movement time.

EXPERT RULE: Flight is not automatically the advanced answer. Use it when it changes the opponent's defensive timing, alters a combo route, or creates a Kameo window. If grounded Homelander already controls the lane, stay grounded.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

DASH FOLLOW-UP: _____

LOW LASER PLAN: _____

FLIGHT ENTRY: _____

FLIGHT CANCEL: _____

AIR PICKUP: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - T-1000

liquid-metal stance / hook control / shape-shifting weapons / anti-zoning / command movement

WHAT T-1000 IS TRYING TO DO

T-1000 turns liquid-metal transformations into a control system. Ballistic Suppression and Ballistic Approach attack with firearms, Tornado Slam and Acute Angle Hooks punish movement, and Superfluid Matter / Amorphous Step each open their own follow-up trees. The key is recognizing when T-1000 is a normal grounded fighter and when he has deliberately entered a liquid state.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Ballistic Suppression, Tornado Slam Emulation and Superfluid Matter. Use one Superfluid follow-up until it feels automatic. **Intermediate:** add Amorphous Step and Sacral Spike placement. **Advanced:** switch between the two liquid-state trees based on whether you need defense, launch, command-grab pressure or position.

KEY STRINGS

Clavicle Awl: 121 **Ethmoid Lance:** F13,1+3
Diaphragm Rupture: F14 **Manifold Perforation:** 24,1+3 / 2+4
Abductive Splitter: F22 **Multiplaner Laceration:** 43434

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

T-1000 - SPECIAL MOVES

Ballistic Suppression

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Ballistic Approach

Xbox: D,F+Hold X **PlayStation:** D,F+Hold Square

Universal: DF Hold 1

Hold to extend.

Tornado Slam Emulation

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Acute Angle Hooks

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Enhanced version has armor.

Wrath Hammer Emulation

Xbox: D,B,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,B,F+Triangle

Universal: DBF2

Superfluid Matter

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Enters liquid state.

Defensive Lattice

Xbox: X **PlayStation:** Square

Universal: 1

Superfluid Matter follow-up.

Elevating Hooks

Xbox: Y / B **PlayStation:** Triangle / Circle

Universal: 2 / 4

Superfluid Matter follow-up; launch behavior.

Form Reversion

Xbox: A **PlayStation:** Cross

Universal: 3

Leaves Superfluid Matter.

Sacral Spike

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Back/Forward changes posterior/anterior placement.

Massive Droplet

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Enhanced version enters Superfluid State.

Amorphous Step

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Amorphous Hooks

Xbox: Y **PlayStation:** Triangle

Universal: 2

Amorphous Step follow-up.

Liquiform Suplex

Xbox: X / A **PlayStation:** Square / Cross

Universal: 1 / 3

Amorphous Step follow-up.

Form Reversion**Xbox:** B **PlayStation:** Circle**Universal:** 4

Leaves Amorphous Step.

Superfluid Matter**Xbox:** Block **PlayStation:** Block**Universal:** BL

Enhanced-only transition from Amorphous Step.

T-1000 - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST DRILL - LIQUID TREE

Xbox: B, F+A → X / Y / B / A

PlayStation: B, F+Cross → Square / Triangle / Circle / Cross

Universal: BF3 → 1 / 2 / 4 / 3

Enter Superfluid Matter and practice each follow-up independently. Learn which one defends, launches, or exits.

BASIC ADVANCED ROUTE

Xbox: B, F+A → Y → J X, Y, Y → B, A, B, A, B

PlayStation: B, F+Cross → Triangle → J Square, Triangle, Triangle → Circle, Cross, Circle, Cross, Circle

Universal: BF3~2, J122, 43434

The published advanced-combo shell is beautifully simple: Superfluid Matter into Elevating Hooks, air string, then Multiplaner Laceration.

AMORPHOUS DECISION DRILL

Xbox: B, F+B → Y / X / A / B

PlayStation: B, F+Circle → Triangle / Square / Cross / Circle

Universal: BF4 → 2 / 1 / 3 / 4

Amorphous Step is a second mini-character. Call out 'hooks, suplex, or revert' before pressing the follow-up so the state never becomes random.

INTERMEDIATE RULE

T-1000 has two follow-up trees, so do not learn them simultaneously. Own **Superfluid Matter** first. Add **Amorphous Step** only when you can enter, choose a follow-up, and revert without looking at the move list.

T-1000 - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

MAVADO — TRAP / JUGGLE PICKUP

Mavado's conditional juggle assists fit T-1000's launch-heavy liquid states. Use him when Elevating Hooks, Acute Angle Hooks or another unusual launch leaves the opponent at a height where a normal reconnect is awkward.

GORO — MIDSCREEN STABILITY

Raise The Roof offers multiple placements and Punch Walk provides a grounded extension. Goro is useful when you want the liquid-state decision to remain the hard part and the Kameo pickup to remain simple.

SEKTOR — MISSILE COVERAGE

Rocket coverage gives T-1000 time to enter Superfluid Matter or Amorphous Step without asking the opponent to politely wait. It also complements Ballistic Suppression by creating two projectile timings instead of one.

SHUJINKO — MATCHUP COPY THEME

Shujinko's Mimic/Kopy Kat identity is thematically and strategically interesting beside T-1000: both characters gain value from matchup knowledge. It is the higher-mental-load option, best saved until T-1000's own two stance trees are automatic.

EXPERT RULE: treat liquid state as a decision tree, not a combo animation. Before BF3 or BF4, know the purpose: absorb/defend, launch, command-grab, reposition, or revert. The opponent should be reacting to the transformation while you already know its ending.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

SUPERFLUID FOLLOW-UP: _____

AMORPHOUS FOLLOW-UP: _____

SACRAL SPIKE RANGE: _____

LIQUID LAUNCH ROUTE: _____

STATE REVERSION CUE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - CONAN THE BARBARIAN

greatsword reach / leap control / stance cancel / brutal launchers / deliberate pressure

WHAT CONAN IS TRYING TO DO

Conan is built around enormous sword coverage and committed, readable violence. His basic strings already reach far; Skyward Guardian and Cimmerian Rising turn space into launch opportunities; Barbarian Blitz/Blade can be delayed or cancelled; and Berserker's March gives him a direct advancing threat. The character rewards choosing the right heavy tool instead of constantly pressing.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn one long sword string, Skyward Guardian, Cimmerian Rising and Berserker's March.

Intermediate: add the Barbarian Blade delay/cancel and one launcher route. **Advanced:** use Mavado or another assist to turn Conan's big grounded hits into repeatable pickups and restands.

KEY STRINGS

Two-Handed Uppercut: 112 **Barbarian's Scar:** B122

Conqueror's Heel: F2114 **Spellbreaker:** 321+3

Wild Smash: F332 **Two-Handed Sweep:** F334

Flesh Is Stronger: 421+3

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle

F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **BL** = Block

CONAN - SPECIAL MOVES

Skyward Guardian

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Hold Forward for the longer leap; enhanced version launches.

Cimmerian Rising

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Press 1 during start-up for Destroyer's Drop.

Destroyer's Drop

Xbox: X during DF2 start-up **PlayStation:** Square during DF2 start-up

Universal: 1 during DF2 start-up

Barbarian Blitz / Blade

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Hold 3 to delay the attack; Down + Block cancels the delayed stance.

Berserker's March

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Crom's Curse

Xbox: D,B+FS **PlayStation:** D,B+FS

Universal: DB+FS

Thief's Catapult

Xbox: D,F+FS **PlayStation:** D,F+FS

Universal: DF+FS

Uses the available Kameo; unavailable with Motaro.

Special-move lesson: Conan has fewer specials than many MK1 characters, but several contain meaningful branches. Treat the held Barbarian Blade, its cancel, and Destroyer's Drop as separate tools during practice.

CONAN - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST CONFIRM

Xbox: X,X → D,F+X

PlayStation: Square,Square → D,F+Square

Universal: 11-DF1

A simple published special-cancel starter. Use this as the 'I hit them, now finish cleanly' drill before learning launch routes.

PRACTICAL METERLESS BnB

Xbox: F+A,A,B → J X,Y,A → D,B+Y → A,Y → D,F+Y~X

PlayStation: F+Cross,Cross,Circle → J Square,Triangle,Cross → D,B+Triangle → Cross,Triangle → D,F+Triangle-Square

Universal: F334, J123-DB2, 32-DF2-1

A documented Conan route: F334 launches, J123 carries, Skyward Guardian stabilizes, and Cimmerian Rising into Destroyer's Drop ends the sequence.

ONE-BAR EXTENSION

Xbox: B+X,Y → EX D,F+X → F+A,A,B → J X,Y,A → D,B+Y → A,Y → D,F+Y~X

PlayStation: B+Square,Triangle → EX D,F+Square → F+Cross,Cross,Circle → J Square,Triangle,Cross → D,B+Triangle → Cross,Triangle → D,F+Triangle-Square

Universal: B12-EX DF1, F334, J123-DB2, 32-DF2-1

Published combo-guide routing adds enhanced DF1 before the same dependable BnB structure. This is the right way to add complexity: extend a route you already know rather than replace it.

CONAN - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

MAVADO - PRIMARY COMBO PARTNER

Current combo resources consistently flag Mavado as a standout Conan Kameo. Up Kameo pickups appear throughout documented routes after Cimmerian Rising, and Mavado can also turn command-grab/end-string situations into another launch. This is the first advanced pairing to learn.

SUB-ZERO - FREEZE / SETUP TIME

Current community routes also use Sub-Zero with Conan. Freeze gives a slow, heavy character time to establish the next sword sequence and makes longer conversions easier to read before committing to the next launcher.

FERRA - DAMAGE / SECOND THREAT

Ferra routes exist for Conan and fit his identity well: Conan supplies the huge grounded hit while Ferra adds another conversion or damage decision. Use this pairing after the basic sword/launcher timing is stable.

BARBARIAN BLADE CANCEL

A documented expert route uses F33 into held BF3, cancels with Down+Block, then continues into B12 and a Mavado pickup. This is the real purpose of the cancel: make the opponent respect the delayed blade, then steal another turn when they freeze.

EXPERT RULE: Conan is not a speed character. His best advanced play still looks deliberate. Use range, delayed Blade timing and Kameo pickups to make one correct sword hit matter enormously.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

METERLESS BnB: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

BLADE DELAY/CANCEL: _____

MAVADO PICKUP: _____

REstand / OKI ENDER: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - GHOSTFACE

killer swapping / knife pressure / rush stance / prone mix / borrowed Black Dragon tools

WHAT GHOSTFACE IS TRYING TO DO

Ghostface is effectively a small team hidden inside one fighter. Original Ghostface has Father Dash, Psychotic Rush and Psychotic Dive; the Black Dragon Enforcer brings Horrorshow and heavy strikes; the Assassin brings Knife Toss, Black Dragon Ball and Nightshade. Killer Swap changes which accomplice is available, so advanced Ghostface is about choosing the right killer for the next problem.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: stay with Original Ghostface and learn Psychotic Rush, Psychotic Dive and one grounded string.
Intermediate: add Killer Swap and learn one Enforcer tool plus Knife Toss from Assassin. **Advanced:** route combos and pressure around which killer you want available after the knockdown.

KEY STRINGS

Surprise, Sidney: 122 **Scene Stealer:** 123
Final Cut: 222 **Your Bloody Valentine:** F212
Killer Dropkick: B34 **Stab Trilogy:** 444

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo **FS** = Flip Stance **TH** = Throw

GHOSTFACE - UNIVERSAL / ORIGINAL SPECIALS

Ghostface Killer Swap

Xbox: Hold FS / TH **PlayStation:** Hold FS / TH

Universal: Hold FS / TH

Selects Black Dragon Enforcer or Assassin.

Backstage Pass

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Hold Back during start-up to change sides; hold 3 to fake out/withhold the attack.

Always Outnumbered

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Hold 2 for Upper; hold 4 to delay Swipe; hold 4 then 1 to cancel.

Father Dash

Xbox: B,D,F+X **PlayStation:** B,D,F+Square

Universal: BDF1

Original Ghostface. Hold Back on hit to switch sides.

Psychotic Rush

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Original Ghostface stance with four follow-ups.

Rushing Stab

Xbox: X **PlayStation:** Square

Universal: 1

Psychotic Rush follow-up.

Rushing Pounce

Xbox: Y **PlayStation:** Triangle

Universal: 2

Psychotic Rush follow-up.

Halt Psychotic Rush

Xbox: A **PlayStation:** Cross

Universal: 3

Stops the rush.

Psychotic Dive

Xbox: B **PlayStation:** Circle

Universal: 4

Rush follow-up; enhanced version has armor.

Psychotic Dive

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Original Ghostface prone state: 1 Sweep, 2 Stab, 3 Crawl, 4 Regain Footing.

GHOSTFACE - BLACK DRAGON SPECIALS

BLACK DRAGON ENFORCER

Horrorshow Act 1

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Act 2 = Up/Down + 1; Act 3 = Back + 1. Enhanced Act 3 launches.

Black Dragon Smash

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Windmill Kick

Xbox: D,F+B **PlayStation:** D,F+Circle

Universal: DF4

BLACK DRAGON ASSASSIN

Knife Toss

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Also available in air. Hold 1 to delay; FF advances; BB retreats.

Black Dragon Ball

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Nightshade

Xbox: D,F+B **PlayStation:** D,F+Circle

Universal: DF4

Killer-swap rule: do not memorize these as one giant list. Learn Original first, then Enforcer, then Assassin. The real mastery test is knowing which killer you want *after* the current sequence ends.

GHOSTFACE - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST METERLESS - ~27%

Xbox: Y,Y,X+Throw → J Y,Y → F+B → J Y,Y → B+A → D,F+A~X

PlayStation: Triangle, Triangle, Square+Throw → J Triangle, Triangle → F+Circle → J Triangle, Triangle → B+Cross → D,F+Cross-Square

Universal: 221+3, J22, F4, J22, B3, DF3-1

A documented ~27% meterless Ghostface route. It teaches a grounded launcher, two simple J22 air modules, then Psychotic Rush into Rushing Stab.

ONE-BAR NO KAMEO - ~35%

Xbox: Y,Y,Y → EX D,B+A → Y,Y,X+Throw → J Y,Y → B+A → D,F+A~X

PlayStation: Triangle, Triangle, Triangle → EX D,B+Cross → Triangle, Triangle, Square+Throw → J Triangle, Triangle → B+Cross → D,F+Cross-Square

Universal: 222-EX DB3, 221+3, J22, B3, DF3-1

A documented ~35% route. Enhanced Backstage Pass opens the longer conversion while the back half stays familiar.

SAREENA ROUTE - ~41%

Xbox: F+Y,X → B+K → B+A → EX D,B+A → B,B → B+K → Y,Y,X+Throw → J Y,Y → F+B → J Y,Y → B+A → D,F+A~X

PlayStation: F+Triangle, Square → B+K → B+Cross → EX D,B+Cross → Circle, Circle → B+K → Triangle, Triangle, Square+Throw → J Triangle, Triangle → F+Circle → J Triangle, Triangle → B+Cross → D,F+Cross-Square

Universal: F21, B+K, B3-EX DB3, 44, B+K, 221+3, J22, F4, J22, B3, DF3-1

Published Ghostface/Sareena routing reaches about 41%. Sareena gives a very readable bridge between grounded Ghostface pieces.

GHOSTFACE - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

SCORPION - DAMAGE / AIR EXTENSION

Current Ghostface combo resources list Scorpion as a top partner, and published routes reach roughly 42-44% with his assist. Scorpion is the damage-forward choice when you already understand Ghostface's killer states.

JAX - GROUNDED EXTENSION

A documented Jax route from F212 reaches about 42%. Jax gives Ghostface a straightforward grounded continuation and is easier to reason about than a rotating or stance-heavy Kameo.

SAREENA - SIMPLE CONFIRM STRUCTURE

Returning blades create the clean ~41% route on the previous page. She is excellent for learning Ghostface because the Kameo remains predictable while you spend mental energy on Killer Swap and Psychotic Rush/Dive choices.

MAVADO - PICKUPS / MODERN ROUTING

Current community combo databases contain multiple Ghostface/Mavado routes, including midscreen conversions in the mid-to-high 30% range. His pickup/trap utility is especially useful when a killer-specific hit leaves the opponent at an awkward height.

EXPERT KILLER RULE: choose the next killer before the combo finishes. Enforcer gives heavy Horrorshow/strike tools; Assassin gives Knife Toss and Black Dragon mobility; Original retains the rush/prone mix. The swap is strongest when it solves the next neutral or wake-up situation.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

ORIGINAL BnB: _____

ENFORCER TOOL: _____

ASSASSIN TOOL: _____

KILLER-SWAP CUE: _____

PSYCHOTIC RUSH CHOICE: _____

PRONE CHOICE: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - CYRAX

bomb setplay / Capture Foam / Mistwalk mobility / aerial saw routes / high execution ceiling

WHAT CYRAX IS TRYING TO DO

Cyrax is a setplay character with real movement. Capture Foam freezes the situation long enough to build bombs, Close/Mid/Far Bomb control different wake-up spaces, Mistwalk shifts position, and Sawtooth Kick finishes or relaunches. Her strongest routes are less about one giant string than arranging explosions so the opponent falls into the next hit.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Capture Foam, one Bomb and Sawtooth Kick. **Intermediate:** learn the difference between Close/Mid/Far Bomb and one Mistwalk. **Advanced:** make bomb bounce timing, Mistwalk and Kameo pickups feel like a planned sequence instead of controlled chaos.

KEY STRINGS / NORMALS

21 is a practical starter in community BnBs. **B33** feeds Capture Foam and bomb routes. **B2** can launch meterlessly. **234** becomes a major corner/Kameo conversion point. Standing 3 is repeatedly used as the height-control button inside bomb loops.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

CYRAX - SPECIAL MOVES

Capture Foam

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Enhanced version destroys projectiles. Current patch: Foam can itself be destroyed by other projectiles.

Close Bomb

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Hold 4 during bomb startup for Dud.

Mid Bomb

Xbox: D,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,F+Triangle

Universal: DF2

Hold 4 during bomb startup for Dud.

Far Bomb

Xbox: D,B,F+Y **PlayStation:** D,B,F+Triangle

Universal: DBF2

Hold 4 during bomb startup for Dud.

Bomb Mistwalk

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Mistwalk

Xbox: D,F+A **PlayStation:** D,F+Cross

Universal: DF3

Enhanced Away = DB3+Block; Enhanced Toward = DF3+Block.

Friction Boot Parkour

Xbox: U near corner during enhanced Mistwalk **PlayStation:** U near corner during enhanced Mistwalk

Universal: U near corner during enhanced Mistwalk

Friction Assist Dive Kick

Xbox: U+A near corner **PlayStation:** U+Cross near corner

Universal: U+3 near corner

Sawtooth Kick

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Enhanced version available.

Patch-aware note: the August 2025 balance pass reduced bomb meter gain/block damage and made Capture Foam destructible by projectiles. The setplay remains the point; do not rely on launch-era resource behavior.

CYRAX - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST CONFIRM

Xbox: Y,X → B,F+X

PlayStation: Triangle,Square → B,F+Square

Universal: 21-BF1

A clean string into Capture Foam. This teaches the most important visual idea: once the opponent is foamed, Cyrax gets time to arrange the next layer.

METERLESS BnB - ~35%

Xbox: B+Y → J X,Y → A~B,F+X → D,F+Y → D,F+Y (bounce) → A (bounce) → A~D,B+B

PlayStation: B+Triangle → J Square,Triangle → Cross~B,F+Square → D,F+Triangle → D,F+Triangle (bounce) → Cross (bounce) → Cross~D,B+Circle

Universal: B2, J12, S3~BF1, DF2, DF2 (BE), S3 (BE), S3~DB4

A community route around 35% with no meter or Kameo. The bomb explosions do the lifting; standing 3 manages height between detonations.

BOMB-SETUP ROUTE - ~32%

Xbox: bomb explodes → J X,Y~B,F+X → D,B+Y → D,F+Y (bounce) → D,B+Y → A (bounce) → A~D,B+B

PlayStation: bomb explodes → J Square,Triangle~B,F+Square → D,B+Triangle → D,F+Triangle (bounce) → D,B+Triangle → Cross (bounce) → Cross~D,B+Circle

Universal: (Bomb), J12~BF1, DB2, DF2 (BE), DB2, S3 (BE), S3~DB4

A documented after-bomb setup route around 32%. This is the real Cyrax lesson: the combo begins before the first visible hit, when you decide where the bomb will be.

CYRAX - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

MAVADO - PRIMARY PICKUP / LOW & STRING CONVERSIONS

Community routing shows Mavado converting 234 midscreen, B24 low strings, and adding another DB4 to Cyrax's main BnB. In the corner, Mavado routes reach about 40% without meter while preserving bomb structure.

FROST - BOMB-SUBSTITUTE SETPLAY

Modern Cyrax synergy research notes Frost's Snow Flakes can replace the second Bomb during a double-bomb Capture Foam setup. This is a true setplay partner: the Kameo changes the geometry rather than merely adding damage.

JANET CAGE - AIR EXTENSION

Janet works when the bomb sequence launches at a height where you want extra airborne time. She is the damage/air-control option after basic bomb routing is stable.

SEKTOR - COVERAGE / MISSILE TIMING

Sektor's missiles can occupy the opponent while Cyrax places Bombs or Mistwalks. The pairing is especially intuitive because missile timing gives Cyrax a safe-ish window to establish the next piece of setplay.

EXPERT RULE: call out each bomb's job before placing it: *launch, hold wake-up, catch retreat, or extend*. If you cannot name the job, the bomb is probably decoration.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

B2 BnB: _____

DOUBLE-BOMB SETUP: _____

MISTWALK CUE: _____

MAVADO PICKUP: _____

WAKE-UP BOMB PLAN: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - SEKTOR

missile zoning / flamethrower damage-over-time / flak launcher / blast-shield defense / jet mobility

WHAT SEKTOR IS TRYING TO DO

Sektor is an armored-weapons specialist who can fight at every lane. Unguided Rocket and Sidewinder control grounded space, Burst Grenade attacks from the air, Flamethrower creates damage-over-time routing, Anti-Air Flak launches, Blast Shield answers projectiles, and Tactical Redeploy converts into air offense. Her strongest Kameo teams often exploit teleport assists to keep combos going after enhanced Flamethrower.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Unguided Rocket, Flamethrower and Tactical Redeploy. **Intermediate:** add Anti-Air Flak and Sidewinder placements. **Advanced:** use Blast Shield and teleport Kameos so the opponent must respect missiles while Sektor cashes out on the hit.

KEY STRINGS

11 is Sektor's fastest practical punish starter in community routes. **42** is a core launcher/confirm shell. **J212** is the standard air module. Community BnBs repeatedly end in DB2 or DB4 depending on whether you want safe-jump position, redeploy carry, or another missile setup.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle
F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

SEKTOR - SPECIAL MOVES

Unguided Rocket

Xbox: B,F+X **PlayStation:** B,F+Square

Universal: BF1

Enhanced Incendiary Rocket destroys projectiles and applies damage over time.

Sidewinder

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Back = Close, Down = Mid, Forward = Very Far, Up = Anti-Air. Enhanced version homes.

(Air) Burst Grenade

Xbox: D,B+X **PlayStation:** D,B+Square

Universal: DB1

Back = Close; Forward/Down = Far. Enhanced version can detonate on release and cancel into other air specials.

Flamethrower

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Enhanced Ignition has armor; enhanced Detonation can be triggered when Flamethrower is blocked/misses.

Anti-Air Flak

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Enhanced version gives jump-attack follow-up advantage.

Blast Shield

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Negates projectile damage/pushback; hold 3 to sustain. Successful deflection energizes other tools.

Tactical Redeploy

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Also available in the air; enhanced version gives jump-attack follow-up advantage.

(Air) Thruster Boost

Xbox: UB / U / UF + Block **PlayStation:** UB / U / UF + Block

Universal: UB / U / UF + BL

Consecutive boosts cost meter.

SEKTOR - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST CONFIRM

Xbox: B,Y → B,F+Y

PlayStation: B,Triangle → B,F+Triangle

Universal: 42-BF2

A documented 15% confirm. The point is not damage: it teaches 42 into Flamethrower and lets you visually recognize the hit before spending resources.

FAST PUNISH BnB - ~31%

Xbox: X,X → D,B+B → J Y,X,Y → D,B+Y → J Y,X,Y → D,B+B

PlayStation: Square,Square → D,B+Circle → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → D,B+Triangle → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → D,B+Circle

Universal: 11-DB4, J212-DB2, J212-DB4

A community meterless route around 31% from Sektor's fast punish. Redeploy launches, J212 carries, Flak re-launches, then Redeploy finishes.

SAFE-JUMP / MISSILE SETUP ROUTE

Xbox: B,Y → D,B+B → J Y,X,Y → D,B+Y → F+Y-D,B+Y / missile

PlayStation: B,Triangle → D,B+Circle → J Triangle,Square,Triangle → D,B+Triangle → F+Triangle-D,B+Triangle / missile

Universal: 42-DB4, J212-DB2, F2-DB2 / missile setup

Community routing uses the DB2 ending for advantageous positioning or substitutes a missile setup after S3. This teaches Sektor to choose what happens after the combo, not just the damage number.

SEKTOR - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

KUNG LAO - TELEPORT COMBO AFTER EX ROCKET

Community testing specifically identifies Kung Lao teleport as a major Sektor damage tool because it lets her continue after enhanced BF1's damage-over-time hit. A one-bar/one-Kameo route reaches about 43%; full Kameo/two-bar versions can exceed 50%.

MOTARO - TELEPORT COMBO / POSITION

Motaro fills the same core role as Lao: teleport Sektor into range after EX BF1 so 42 can restart the launch shell. Choose between them based on the rest of the matchup utility you want.

SCORPION - AIR DAMAGE EXTENSION

Scorpion's far Fire Breath/air support combines well with DB4 -> J212 structures and lets Sektor push the route farther once the basic no-Kameo BnB is automatic.

CYRAX - SETPLAY COVERAGE

Cyrax Bomb/Capture-Foam style assistance can occupy the screen while Sektor establishes Sidewinder or Blast Shield decisions. This is a high-mental-load pairing best saved until Sektor's missile lanes are already automatic.

EXPERT RULE: decide whether BF1 is being used for zoning, chip, damage-over-time conversion, or Kameo teleport routing. The same rocket is a different move depending on what you plan to do after it touches the opponent.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

11 PUNISH: _____

42 BnB: _____

EX ROCKET TELEPORT: _____

MISSILE SETUP: _____

BLAST-SHIELD MATCHUP: _____

MORTAL KOMBAT 1 - NOOB SAIBOT

Shadow Klone / Ghostball / teleport routing / Embrace Khaos transformation / portal setplay

WHAT NOOB SAIBOT IS TRYING TO DO

Noob is two characters layered together: Bi-Han and his Shadow Klone. Ghostball/Exorcism, Shadow Tackle, Shadow Slide/Sweep, portal placement and Tele-Slam all depend on whether the Klone is available. Embrace Khaos temporarily upgrades that relationship, but when it expires the Shadow Klone is gone. The expert challenge is resource-state awareness, not just combo execution.

THE ARCADE VERSION

New player: learn Shadow Tackle, Tele-Slam and 212. **Intermediate:** add Ghostball and portal routes.

Advanced: learn Embrace Khaos as a once-per-match mode where Shadow moves warp opponents toward Noob and new Summons become available.

KEY STRINGS

212 is the universal beginner confirm. **44** is a central launch/extension shell. **B33** is a practical one-bar starter.

J234 and **J1234** are the main air modules used repeatedly in community routes.

NOTATION

1 = X / Square **2** = Y / Triangle **3** = A / Cross **4** = B / Circle

F/B/D/U = direction **J** = jump **EX** = enhanced **K** = Kameo

NOOB SAIBOT - SPECIAL MOVES

Ghostball

Xbox: D,F+X **PlayStation:** D,F+Square

Universal: DF1

Requires Shadow Klone; enables Exorcism on hit/block.

Exorcism

Xbox: D,F+X after Ghostball **PlayStation:** D,F+Square after Ghostball

Universal: DF1 after Ghostball

Enhanced Exorcism = BDF1+Block.

Embrace Khaos

Xbox: F,D,B+X **PlayStation:** F,D,B+Square

Universal: FDB1

Once per match. Enables Netherrealm Summons and changes Shadow Klone behavior; after it expires the Klone is unavailable.

Netherrealm Summons

Xbox: B,F+Y **PlayStation:** B,F+Triangle

Universal: BF2

Requires Embrace Khaos.

Netherrealm Portal

Xbox: D,B+Y **PlayStation:** D,B+Triangle

Universal: DB2

Back = Close; Forward = Far.

Shadow Tackle

Xbox: B,F+A **PlayStation:** B,F+Cross

Universal: BF3

Requires Shadow Klone.

Shadow Slicer

Xbox: D,B+A **PlayStation:** D,B+Cross

Universal: DB3

Requires Shadow Klone.

Shadow Slide

Xbox: B,F+B **PlayStation:** B,F+Circle

Universal: BF4

Requires Klone; becomes Saibot Slide when Klone unavailable. Air version becomes Shadow Kick.

Shadow Sweep

Xbox: D,B+B **PlayStation:** D,B+Circle

Universal: DB4

Requires Klone; air version is Shadow Dive. When Klone unavailable, air route becomes Dive Kick.

Shadow Plunge

Xbox: D,D+B **PlayStation:** D,D+Circle

Universal: DD4

Air move requiring Shadow Klone.

Tele-Slam

Xbox: D,U **PlayStation:** D,U

Universal: DU

Also available in the air; enhanced version extends.

NOOB SAIBOT - GUEST → INTERMEDIATE

GUEST CONFIRM - 16%

Xbox: Y,X,Y → D,U

PlayStation: Triangle,Square,Triangle → D,U

Universal: 212~DU

The cleanest Noob teaching combo: hit-confirm 212 and finish with Tele-Slam.

METERLESS KLONE ROUTE - ~23%

Xbox: Y,X,Y → B,F+A → Y,X → D,U

PlayStation: Triangle,Square,Triangle → B,F+Cross → Triangle,Square → D,U

Universal: 212~BF3, 21~DU

A documented meterless route. Shadow Tackle is the bridge; the 21 reconnect teaches the basic Klone-to-Noob handoff.

ONE-BAR BnB - ~35%

Xbox: B+A, A → EX B, F+A → J Y,A,B → J Y,A,B → B+B

PlayStation: B+Cross,Cross → EX B, F+Cross → J Triangle,Cross,Circle → J Triangle,Cross,Circle → B+Circle

Universal: B33~EX BF3, J234, J234, B4

A documented ~35% one-bar route. It is consistent and readable: starter, enhanced Shadow Tackle, two J234 air modules, finish.

GHOSTBALL VARIANT

When Ghostball is active, community routing replaces the enhanced Tele-Slam extension with Exorcism for roughly the same damage without spending bar: **212~BF3, 212~DF1, J234, B4**. This is why state awareness matters: the resource you already established changes the efficient route.

NOOB SAIBOT - ADVANCED → EXPERT / KAMEOS

SCORPION - TELE-SLAM AIR EXTENSION

Scorpion can call Up Kameo after Tele-Slam and extend into J234/J1234 modules. Community routes land around 35% for one call and 41% with full Kameo meter, while one-bar full-Kameo variants reach the mid-40s.

MAVADO - LOW / THROW / 443 CONVERSIONS

Mavado can pick up after Tele-Slam like Scorpion, but also converts Noob's low 24, throw, and 443 situations. That makes him the flexible conversion partner rather than only a damage extender.

SUB-ZERO - SAFE GHOSTBALL / PORTAL SETUP

Community labbing explicitly uses Sub-Zero freeze to establish Ghostball and portal safely. Published routes reach the mid-40s while leaving Noob in a prepared state instead of merely cashing out.

EMBRACE KHAOS - ONCE-PER-MATCH MODE

With Embrace Khaos active, Shadow specials warp the opponent and Netherrealm Summons becomes available. Community routes exceed 40% meterless, and Sub-Zero/Mavado extensions go higher. The catch is strategic: after the mode expires, the Shadow Kloner is unavailable.

EXPERT RULE: track three states at all times: *Kloner available*, *Ghostball active*, *Embrace Khaos active*. The best route changes with the state. If you need to look at the character model mid-combo to remember which state you are in, simplify the route.

BOOX PRACTICE NOTES

MY KAMEO: _____

212 CONFIRM: _____

ONE-BAR BnB: _____

GHOSTBALL ROUTE: _____

PORTAL SETUP: _____

EMBRACE KHAOS ROUTE: _____